# TRIPLE QUANTUM SCHUBERT CALCULUS

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ABSTRACT. We study the structure constants $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)$ that arise when a product of two quantum double Schubert polynomials in *different* sets of equivariant parameters, $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(x;z)$, is expanded in the basis $\{\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y)\}$. We call them triple quantum Schubert structure constants; they specialize to the equivariant quantum Littlewood–Richardson coefficients when $z = y$ and to the ordinary triple Schubert structure constants when $q = 0$. Adapting an argument of Xiao and Yue, we show that they are polynomials in the differences $y_i - z_j$ with nonnegative integer coefficients. We prove a Pieri formula for multiplication by a quantum factorial elementary polynomial, indexed by a quantum analogue of Sottile's relation, in which each coefficient is a monomial in $q$ times a product of differences $y_a - z_1$; the proof is a self-contained analysis of chains in the quantum Bruhat graph. We extend the Peterson–Woodward comparison formula and the quantum-to-classical reduction of Huang and Li to the triple constants, thereby reducing the computation of the parabolic triple quantum structure constants to the complete flag case. Finally we describe the algorithms implemented in the package `schubmult` for computing these constants, and give an interpretation of the coefficients in terms of the Fomin–Gelfand–Postnikov difference operators.

**Keywords**: quantum double Schubert polynomial, structure constant, Littlewood-Richardson rule, Pieri formula, quantum Bruhat graph, Peterson–Woodward comparison formula

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## 1. INTRODUCTION

Let $\mathfrak{S}_w(x;y)$, $w \in S_\infty$, denote the double Schubert polynomials of Lascoux and Schützenberger, which represent the torus-equivariant Schubert classes of the complete flag variety, and let $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y)$ denote the quantum double Schubert polynomials of Kirillov and Maeno [9], which represent the Schubert classes in torus-equivariant quantum cohomology [10]. The structure constants of the equivariant quantum cohomology ring are the coefficients in

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(x;y) = \sum_{w,d} q^d\, c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;y)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y),$$

and Mihalcea [12] proved that they are polynomials in the negative simple roots $y_{i+1} - y_i$ with nonnegative integer coefficients.

In this paper we study the coefficients obtained when the two factors carry *different* equivariant parameters:

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(x;z) = \sum_{w,d} q^d\, c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y).$$

We call the $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)$ the *triple quantum Schubert structure constants*. At $z = y$ they recover the equivariant quantum structure constants, and at $q = 0$ they recover the triple Schubert structure constants $c_{u,v}^{w}(y;z)$ of [16], which were recently shown by Gao and Xiong [6] to be polynomials in the differences $y_i - z_j$ with nonnegative integer coefficients. The triple constants carry strictly more information than the equivariant ones: the equivariant quantum constant $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;y)$ is a specialization of $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)$, while conversely $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)$ is recovered from the constants $c_{u,v_2}^{w,d}(y;y)$, $v_2$ ranging over the right factors of the reduced factorizations $v = v_1 \cdot v_2$, by the quantum Cauchy identity (Lemma 2.1).

Our main results are the following.

(1) *Positivity* (Theorem 2.3). The constants $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)$ lie in $\mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}[y_i - z_j]$. The proof, which we reproduce from the manuscript of Xiao and Yue [21] with their permission, combines the geometric argument of Mihalcea with the Graham-positivity theorem of Gao and Xiong for $B^-$-stable effective cycles.

(2) *A quantum Pieri formula* (Theorem 3.4). Let $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_1 s_2 \cdots s_k}(x;z)$ be the quantum factorial elementary polynomial. We prove

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = \sum_{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w} q_k(u,w) \prod_{a \in \mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)} (y_a - z_1)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y),$$

where $\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ is a quantum analogue of the relation introduced by Sottile [19] for the classical Pieri rule, $q_k(u,w)$ is a monomial in the $q_i$ recording the length-decreasing steps of a chain from $u$ to $w$ in the quantum Bruhat graph, and $\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)$ is the set of values fixed by the chain in the first $k$ positions. This is an explicit instance of the positivity theorem, and it is the engine of the multiplication algorithm. The proof occupies Section 6; it proceeds by induction on $k$ via the single-variable Monk formula, and rests on an intrinsic description of the chains (every cycle of $u^{-1}w$ has exactly one element exceeding $k$, and a single length identity) which makes the term-by-term cancellations tractable. In the non-equivariant case the quantum Pieri formula for complete flag manifolds is due to Ciocan-Fontanine [3] and Postnikov [15].

(3) *Parabolic reduction* (Proposition 2.10). The Peterson–Woodward comparison formula, in the form proved by Huang and Li [7] for equivariant quantum cohomology, extends verbatim to the triple constants. Consequently the triple structure constants of the parabolic quantum double Schubert polynomials of Lam and Shimozono are equal to triple constants of the complete flag variety, and in particular they are also Graham-positive (Corollary 2.12).

(4) *Algorithms and operators* (Sections 4 and 5). We describe the algorithms implemented in the package `schubmult` [18] for computing products of (quantum) double Schubert polynomials, which combine the Pieri formula on one factor with a signed expansion of the other factor into products of factorial elementary polynomials; the quantum algorithm also uses a "doubled" Pieri rule (Theorem 7.4) for the quantization of a product of two elementary polynomials in the same variables, which is obtained from two iterated Pieri steps by omitting the pairs of chains that are not compatible in a precise cycle-theoretic sense. We prove an alternating form of this rule (Theorem 7.8), prove the positive form for $k \leq 2$, and reduce it in general to a single combinatorial identity (Conjecture 7.21, with a termwise version in Conjecture 7.23), which we have verified by computer but not proved. We also show that the Fomin–Gelfand–Postnikov quantization operators [5] package the triple constants: the coefficient of $\partial^u$ in $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)};z)$ is $\sum_d q^d c^{1,d}_{u,v}(x;z)$. Finally, we extend the quantum-to-classical reduction of Huang and Li to the triple constants.

The paper is organized as follows. Section 2 fixes notation, proves the positivity theorem and treats the parabolic case. Section 3 states the Pieri formula, whose proof is given in Section 6. Section 4 describes the algorithms and the operator interpretation, Section 5 the quantum-to-classical reduction, Section 7 the iterated Pieri formula, and Section 8 the Peterson–Woodward comparison formula.

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## 2. Definitions and statement of results

2.1. **Quantum double Schubert polynomials and triple quantum Schubert structure constants.** We fix $n \geq 1$ and write

$$x = (x_1, \ldots, x_n), \qquad y = (y_1, \ldots, y_n), \qquad q = (q_1, \ldots, q_{n-1}).$$

For $1 \leq a < b \leq n$, set

$$q_{ab} := q_a q_{a+1} \cdots q_{b-1},$$

and use the cohomological grading $\deg q_i = 2$ (equivalently $\deg q_{ab} = 2(b-a)$).

Let $s_i$ act on the $y$-variables by swapping $y_i, y_{i+1}$, and define the divided difference operators

$$\partial_i^{(y)} f := \frac{f - s_i f}{y_i - y_{i+1}} \qquad (1 \leq i \leq n-1).$$

For $w \in S_n$, if $w = s_{i_1} \cdots s_{i_r}$ is any reduced word, set

$$\partial_w^{(y)} := \partial_{i_1}^{(y)} \cdots \partial_{i_r}^{(y)}.$$

Following Kirillov–Maeno [9], define the quantum elementary polynomials $e_j^{(q)}(x_1,\dots,x_k)$ by

$$\Delta_k(t \mid x_1,\dots,x_k) := \sum_{j=0}^{k} t^{k-j} e_j^{(q)}(x_1,\dots,x_k),$$

where

$$\Delta_k(t \mid x_1,\dots,x_k) = \det\begin{pmatrix} x_1+t & q_1 & 0 & \cdots & 0 \\ -1 & x_2+t & q_2 & \ddots & \vdots \\ 0 & -1 & x_3+t & \ddots & 0 \\ \vdots & \ddots & \ddots & \ddots & q_{k-1} \\ 0 & \cdots & 0 & -1 & x_k+t \end{pmatrix}.$$

Let $w_0 \in S_n$ be the longest permutation. The top quantum double Schubert polynomial is

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{w_0}(x;y) := \prod_{i=1}^{n-1} \Delta_i(-y_{n-i} \mid x_1,\dots,x_i),$$

and for $w \in S_n$ we define

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y) := (-1)^{\ell(w_0)-\ell(w)} \partial^{(y)}_{ww_0}\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{w_0}(x;y).$$

Its specialization

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x) := \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;0)$$

is the quantum Schubert polynomial. In particular, at $q=0$ these recover the ordinary double and single Schubert polynomials.

Given their stability property, we may let the number of variables be infinite, indexing the polynomials by $S_\infty$. As a module over $\mathbb{Z}[q][y]$, the quantum double Schubert polynomials form a basis of $\mathbb{Z}[q][x,y]$, and we may write

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(x;z) = \sum_{w,d} q^d c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y)$$

where $d=(d_1,\dots,d_{n-1})$ is a weak composition and $q^d = q_1^{d_1}\cdots q_{n-1}^{d_{n-1}}$. The coefficients $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)$ are the *triple quantum Schubert structure constants*, which are polynomials in $y$ and $z$ with integer coefficients. This product respects the grading where for each $i$, $\deg y_i = \deg z_i = 1$ and $\deg q_i = 2$. In particular, if $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z) \neq 0$, then $\deg c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z) = \ell(u)+\ell(v)-\ell(w)+2\sum_i d_i$. Unlike the usual triple Schubert structure constants, they do not exhibit triangularity in Bruhat order, and indeed we may have $\ell(w) < \ell(u)+\ell(v)$. There is an ordering in which the quantum double Schubert polynomials are triangular, but we will not need this in full generality.

Throughout, a factorization $w = v_1 \cdot v_2$ written with a dot is understood to be *reduced*, i.e. $\ell(w) = \ell(v_1)+\ell(v_2)$. The following identity will be used repeatedly to pass between the triple constants and the equivariant quantum structure constants $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;y)$. Setting $y=0$ in it recovers the expansion $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;z) = \sum_{v_1\cdot v_2=w} \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(0;z)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{v_2}(x)$ of Kirillov–Maeno [9] in terms of quantum Schubert polynomials.

**Lemma 2.1** (Quantum Cauchy identity)**.** *For all $w \in S_\infty$,*

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;z) = \sum_{v_1\cdot v_2=w} \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(y;z)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{v_2}(x;y).$$

*Consequently, for all $u,v,w$ and $d$,*

$$c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z) = \sum_{v_1\cdot v_2=v} c_{u,v_2}^{w,d}(y;y)\;\mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(y;z).$$

*Proof.* Let $\theta$ denote the quantization map of Fomin, Gelfand and Postnikov [5], the $\mathbb{Z}[q]$-linear map on polynomials in $x$ which sends each standard elementary monomial $\prod_j e_{i_j}(x_1,\dots,x_j)$ to $\prod_j e_{i_j}^{(q)}(x_1,\dots,x_j)$, extended linearly over any further coefficient variables. Since the divided differences in the $y$-variables commute with $\theta$, the definition of $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y)$ by $y$-divided differences gives $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y) = \theta(\mathfrak{S}_w(x;y))$ [10, (10)]. Now apply $\theta$, which is $\mathbb{Z}[y,z]$-linear, to the classical Cauchy-type expansion $\mathfrak{S}_w(x;z) = \sum_{v_1\cdot v_2=w} \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(y;z)\,\mathfrak{S}_{v_2}(x;y)$ [11, (6.3)]: the left side becomes $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;z)$ and the right side becomes $\sum_{v_1\cdot v_2=w} \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(y;z)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{v_2}(x;y)$. For the

second assertion, multiply the first identity (with $w = v$) by $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)$ and expand each $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{v_2}(x;y)$ in the basis $\{\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y)\}$ with coefficients $q^d c^{w,d}_{u,v_2}(y;y)$. □

*Remark* 2.2 ($\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ and the quantum $k$-Bruhat order). The *quantum $k$-Bruhat order* was introduced by Benedetti, Bergeron, Colmenarejo, Saliola, and Sottile [1] and studied further by Colmenarejo and Mayers [4]. That order $\preceq_k^{\mathbf{q}}$ on $S_\infty[\mathbf{q}]$ is generated by cover relations

$$u' \lessdot_k^{\mathbf{q}} \mathbf{q}^\gamma u' t_{ab}, \qquad a \le k < b,$$

each of exactly two kinds: a *classical* cover, with $\gamma = 0$ and $\ell(u't_{ab}) = \ell(u') + 1$, or a *quantum* cover, with $\ell(u') + 1 = \ell(\mathbf{q}^\gamma u' t_{ab}) = \ell(u't_{ab}) + 2(b-a)$, that is $\ell(u't_{ab}) = \ell(u') - 2(b-a) + 1$ and $\gamma = e_a + \cdots + e_{b-1}$. These are exactly the two alternatives of condition (4) of Definition 3.1. Consequently every sequence $t_{a_1b_1}, \ldots, t_{a_pb_p}$ witnessing $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ is a saturated chain from $u$ to $\mathbf{q}^\alpha w$ in the quantum $k$-Bruhat order, where $\mathbf{q}^\alpha$ is the monomial recorded by $q_k(u,w)$; in particular $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ implies $u \preceq_k^{\mathbf{q}} \mathbf{q}^\alpha w$.

The relation $\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ is *not* the full order $\preceq_k^{\mathbf{q}}$, however. Definition 3.1 imposes the additional requirements that the lower indices $a_1, \ldots, a_p$ be pairwise distinct, so that $\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ admits only those saturated chains of a special form. Thus $\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ is strictly larger than the covering relation $\lessdot_k^{\mathbf{q}}$ but strictly smaller than $\preceq_k^{\mathbf{q}}$: a general chain in the quantum $k$-Bruhat order may reuse a lower index $a_i$, and such chains do not contribute to the Pieri expansion. This is the quantum counterpart of the classical situation, where the Pieri relation of [19, 16] is likewise the restriction of the $k$-Bruhat order to chains with distinct lower indices, and it is exactly this restriction that makes the Pieri coefficients well defined.

What we use below is only that each individual step of a $\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ chain is a cover, and hence is governed by the following length-free description of the covers [1, Proposition 3.1] (see also [4, Proposition 4.2]): with $i \le k < j$, the step $u' \lessdot_k^{\mathbf{q}} \mathbf{q}^\gamma u' t_{ij}$ is a classical cover exactly when $u'(i) < u'(j)$ and no $l$ with $i < l < j$ satisfies $u'(i) < u'(l) < u'(j)$, and it is a quantum cover exactly when $u'(i) > u'(j)$ and every $l$ with $i < l < j$ satisfies $u'(j) < u'(l) < u'(i)$. This characterization is an immediate consequence of the standard formula for the length of $u't_{ij}$ (Lemma 6.2 below), and it is the form in which the covers are used throughout Section 6.

For $d = (0, \ldots, 0)$, this is the ordinary triple Schubert calculus structure constant, and it was proved in [6] that these have the positivity property that they are polynomials in the differences $y_i - z_j$ with nonnegative integer coefficients. We will refer to this as *triple Schubert positivity*. Our first main result is that it persists in the quantum setting.

**Theorem 2.3** (Triple quantum Schubert positivity)**.** *For all $u, v, w$ and $d$, the structure constants $c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;z)$ are polynomials in the differences $y_i - z_j$ with nonnegative integer coefficients.*

*Proof.* The proof below is adapted from the manuscript of Tongren Xiao and Yihua Yue [21], with their permission. Their product is written with the output basis carrying the parameters of the second factor. Commutativity of multiplication therefore identifies their coefficient $C^{w,d}_{v,u}(z,y)$ with $c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;z)$. It is enough to prove that $C^{w,d}_{u,v}(y,t)$ is in $\mathbb{Z}_{\ge 0}[t_i - y_j]$.

Fix $u, v, w \in S_n$, increasing $n$ if necessary so that all permutations and parameters occurring in the coefficient under consideration are included. Write $\mathbf{a} = (t_1, \ldots, t_n, y_1, \ldots, y_n)$, and let $\tau \in S_{2n}$ interchange the two blocks, so that $\tau\mathbf{a} = (y_1, \ldots, y_n, t_1, \ldots, t_n)$. Regard the product expansion in $S_{2n}$:

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;\tau\mathbf{a})\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(x;\mathbf{a}) = \sum_{w \in S_{2n}} C^{w,\tau}_{u,v}(\mathbf{a};q)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;\mathbf{a}). \tag{2.1}$$

We recall the geometric interpretation of these coefficients. Let $e_i(x)$ and $E_i(x,q)$ denote, respectively, the elementary symmetric polynomials and their quantum analogues in $2n$ variables, and set

$$J^{2n}_{\mathbf{a}} = \langle e_i(x) - e_i(\mathbf{a}) : 1 \le i \le 2n \rangle, \qquad J^{2n}_{q\mathbf{a}} = \langle E_i(x,q) - e_i(\mathbf{a}) : 1 \le i \le 2n \rangle.$$

The Fomin–Gelfand–Postnikov deformation map [5], extended $\mathbb{Z}[\mathbf{a}]$-linearly, induces

$$\bar{\theta} : \mathbb{Z}[x,\mathbf{a}]/J^{2n}_{\mathbf{a}} \longrightarrow \mathbb{Z}[x,\mathbf{a},q]/J^{2n}_{q\mathbf{a}}.$$

The classical Borel presentation identifies the source with $H^*_T(X)$, and Kim's presentation [8] identifies the target with $QH^*_T(X)$, where $X = \mathrm{Fl}_{2n}$. Under the Lam–Shimozono identification [10] of quantum

double Schubert polynomials with quantum Schubert classes, (2.1) is the quantum equivariant Littlewood–Richardson expansion for the classes obtained by applying $\bar{\theta}$ to the first factor. Consequently,

$$C_{u,v}^{w,\tau}(\mathbf{a};q) = \sum_{d\geq 0} q^d (\pi_{M_d})_*^T \left(\mathrm{ev}_1^*[\tau X_u]^T \ \mathrm{ev}_2^*[X_v]^T \ \mathrm{ev}_3^*[Y_w]^T\right). \tag{2.2}$$

Here $M_d = \overline{M}_{0,3}(X,d)$, $\mathrm{ev}_i : M_d \to X$ are the evaluation maps, $\pi_{M_d} : M_d \to \mathrm{pt}$ is the structure map, and $X_r$ and $Y_r$ denote the Schubert and opposite Schubert varieties indexed by $r$.

For each effective degree $d$, put

$$F = (\mathrm{ev}_1, \mathrm{ev}_2) : M_d \longrightarrow X \times X, \qquad I_{u,v}^d = F^{-1}(\tau X_u \times X_v), \qquad \Gamma_{u,v}^d = (\mathrm{ev}_3)_*[I_{u,v}^d].$$

The incidence scheme $I_{u,v}^d$ is reduced and locally irreducible, and all its irreducible components have codimension $\ell(u)+\ell(v)$. Indeed, the moduli space $M_d$ is irreducible by Thomsen's theorem [20], and Mihalcea's incidence lemma [12, Lemma 6.3] applies after diagonal translation by $a_0 = 1 \times w_0 \in S_{2n}$, where $w_0$ is the longest element in the second block: it identifies $\tau X_u \times X_v$ with $w_0^{(2n)} X_u \times X_v$. The codimension is therefore

$$\mathrm{codim}_X(w_0^{(2n)} X_u) + \ell(v) = \ell(u) + \ell(v).$$

By the incidence formula of Mihalcea [12, Section 3.1], this gives

$$\mathrm{ev}_1^*[\tau X_u]^T \ \mathrm{ev}_2^*[X_v]^T \cap [M_d]^T = [I_{u,v}^d]_T. \tag{2.3}$$

The cycle $\Gamma_{u,v}^d$ is effective and $B^-(\tau)$-invariant. To see invariance, write $N^-(\tau) = N^- \cap \tau N^- \tau^{-1}$ and $B^-(\tau) = TN^-(\tau)$. The varieties $X_v$ and $\tau X_u$ are stable under the corresponding actions, so their product, its inverse image under the equivariant map $F$, and its proper push-forward under $\mathrm{ev}_3$ are $B^-(\tau)$-invariant. Effectivity follows from the reducedness of $I_{u,v}^d$.

There is a unique expansion

$$[\Gamma_{u,v}^d]_T = \sum_{r\in S_{2n}} p_{u,v}^{r,d}(\mathbf{a})[X_r]_T \quad \text{in } H_T^*(X).$$

By Gao and Xiong's Graham–positivity theorem for $B^-(\tau)$-invariant effective cycles [6, Theorem 2.3 and Corollary 2.4],

$$p_{u,v}^{r,d}(\mathbf{a}) \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}[t_i - y_j : 1 \leq i,j \leq n].$$

Finally, by equivariant Poincaré duality, (2.3), and the projection formula,

$$(\mathrm{ev}_3)_*^T \left(\mathrm{ev}_1^*[\tau X_u]^T \, \mathrm{ev}_2^*[X_v]^T\right) = [\Gamma_{u,v}^d]_T,$$

and hence the degree-$d$ summand of (2.2) is

$$(\pi_X)_*^T\left([\Gamma_{u,v}^d]_T [Y_w]^T\right) = \sum_{r\in S_{2n}} p_{u,v}^{r,d}(\mathbf{a})(\pi_X)_*^T\left([X_r]^T[Y_w]^T\right) = p_{u,v}^{w,d}(\mathbf{a}).$$

Thus every coefficient $C_{u,v}^{w,d}(y,t)$ is in $\mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}[t_i - y_j]$. Replacing $(u,v,y,t)$ by $(v,u,z,y)$ proves the asserted positivity of $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)$. □

**Example 2.4.** We compute the product $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{15423}(x;y)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1432}(x;z)$:

$$\begin{aligned}
&q_2q_3\,(y_1+y_4-z_1-z_2)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{124635}\,(x;y) + q_2q_3\,(y_1+y_4-z_1-z_2)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{13452}\,(x;y)\\
&+ q_2q_3\,(y_1+y_4-z_1-z_2)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{14253}\,(x;y)\\
&+ q_2q_3\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{125634}\,(x;y) + q_2q_3\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{126435}\,(x;y) + q_2q_3\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{13542}\,(x;y) + q_2q_3\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{214635}\,(x;y)\\
&+ q_2q_3\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{23451}\,(x;y) + q_2q_3\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{24153}\,(x;y) + q_2q_3\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{31452}\,(x;y) + q_2q_3\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{41253}\,(x;y)\\
&+ q_2\,(y_1+y_4-z_1-z_2)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{146235}\,(x;y) + q_2\,(y_4+y_5-z_1-z_2)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{24513}\,(x;y)\\
&+ q_2\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{246135}\,(x;y) + q_3\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1724356}\,(x;y) + q_3\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{261435}\,(x;y) + q_3\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{35142}\,(x;y)\\
&+ (q_2q_3 + q_2\,((y_1-z_2)\,(y_4+y_5-z_1-z_2) + (y_4-z_1)\,(y_5-z_1)))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{14523}\,(x;y)\\
&+ ((y_4-z_1)\,(y_5-z_3) + (y_4-z_1)\,(y_1+y_2-z_1-z_2)\\
&\quad + (y_5-z_2)\,(y_5-z_3) + (y_5-z_2)\,(y_1+y_2-z_1-z_2))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{25413}\,(x;y)
\end{aligned}$$

$$
\begin{aligned}
&+ ((y_1 - z_2)(y_1 - z_3)(y_4 - z_2) + (y_1 - z_2)(y_1 - z_3)(y_5 - z_1) + (y_1 - z_2)(y_5 - z_1)(y_5 - z_2) \\
&\quad + (y_1 - z_3)(y_4 - z_1)(y_5 - z_1) + (y_4 - z_1)(y_5 - z_1)(y_5 - z_2))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{15423}(x;y) \\
&+ (q_2 + (y_1 - z_2)(y_1 - z_3) + (y_1 - z_3)(y_5 - z_1) + (y_5 - z_1)(y_5 - z_2))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{156234}(x;y) \\
&+ (q_3 + (y_1 - z_1)(y_4 - z_1) + (y_5 - z_2)(y_1 + y_4 - z_1 - z_2))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{45123}(x;y) \\
&+ (q_2q_3 + q_3((y_1 - z_1)(y_1 + y_5 - z_2 - z_3) + (y_5 - z_2)(y_5 - z_3)))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{15243}(x;y) \\
&+ q_3(y_1 + y_5 + y_6 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{162435}(x;y) + q_3(y_1 + y_2 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{25143}(x;y) \\
&+ q_2q_3(y_1 + y_2 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{12543}(x;y) + q_2q_3(y_1 + y_2 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{21453}(x;y) \\
&+ q_2q_3((y_1 - z_2)(y_1 - z_3) + (y_1 - z_2)(y_2 - z_2) + (y_1 - z_2)(y_4 - z_1) \\
&\quad + (y_1 - z_2)(y_5 - z_1) + (y_2 - z_1)(y_4 - z_1) + (y_4 - z_1)(y_5 - z_3))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{12453}(x;y) \\
&+ (y_1 + y_4 - z_1 - z_2)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1742356}(x;y) + (y_1 + y_4 - z_1 - z_2)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{461235}(x;y) \\
&+ (y_4 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{35412}(x;y) + (y_4 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{45213}(x;y) \\
&+ ((y_1 - z_2)(y_1 - z_3) + (y_1 - z_2)(y_5 + y_6 - z_1 - z_2) \\
&\quad + (y_1 - z_3)(y_4 - z_1) + (y_4 - z_1)(y_5 + y_6 - z_1 - z_2))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{164235}(x;y) \\
&+ (y_1 + y_2 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{256134}(x;y) + (y_1 + y_5 + y_6 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{165234}(x;y) \\
&+ (y_1 + y_2 + y_4 + y_5 + y_6 - 2z_1 - 2z_2 - z_3)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{264135}(x;y) \\
&+ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1752346}(x;y) + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{265134}(x;y) + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{2741356}(x;y) \\
&+ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{356124}(x;y) + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{364125}(x;y) + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{462135}(x;y) \\
&+ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{561234}(x;y)
\end{aligned}
$$

By inspection, we can see that the coefficients exhibit triple Schubert positivity.

*Remark* 2.5. The Pieri formula of Theorem 3.4 below is an explicit instance of Theorem 2.3: for $v = s_1 s_2 \cdots s_k$ each coefficient $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)$ is a product of differences $y_a - z_1$. The parabolic reduction of Proposition 2.10 shows that the structure constants of the parabolic quantum double Schubert polynomials of the next subsection are also triple Schubert positive (Corollary 2.12).

2.2. **The parabolic case.** Unlike ordinary cohomology or equivariant cohomology, quantum cohomology and equivariant quantum cohomology do not demonstrate simple functoriality, in the sense that a projection of the complete flag variety $G/B$ to a partial flag variety $G/P$ does not induce a homomorphism of rings $QH_T^*(G/P) \to QH_T^*(G/B)$, and indeed the quantum cohomology of $G/P$ is not isomorphic to the subring of the quantum cohomology of $G/B$ generated by the Schubert classes indexed by $W^P$. This is reflected in the fact that there are parabolic quantum double Schubert polynomials defined in a different manner that represent Schubert classes in $QH_T^*(G/P)$ [10] and are not in general equal to the quantum double Schubert polynomials above.

**Definition 2.6** (Parabolic quantum double Schubert polynomials)**.** Following Lam and Shimozono [10], we define parabolic quantum double Schubert polynomials as follows. Fix an integer $n > 0$. A parabolic subgroup $W_P$ of $S_n$, which has Coxeter generators $s_1, \ldots, s_{n-1}$, is generated by a subset $P \subseteq \{s_1, \ldots, s_{n-1}\}$. In terms of the subgroup's properties, it is most natural to identify $P$ by the reflections that it *excludes*. If $P$ is generated by $S \setminus \{s_{i_1}, \ldots, s_{i_k}\}$ in increasing order, we define integers $n_1, \ldots, n_{k+1}$ with

$$n_1 + \cdots + n_{k+1} = n$$

by $n_1 = i_1$ and $n_p = i_p - i_{p-1}$ for $2 \le p \le k+1$. Then $N_j$ for $j \ge 1$ is defined by

$$N_j = n_1 + \cdots + n_j$$

for $0 \le j \le k+1$.

For such a setup, define a matrix $D_j^P$ to be the $n \times n$ matrix with $x_1, \ldots, x_n$ on the diagonal, $-1$ on the superdiagonal, and $(-1)^{n_{j+1}+1} q_j$ at $(N_{j+1}, N_{j-1} + 1)$ for $1 \le j \le k$. Notice that there are precisely $k$ $q$

variables, and we set

$$\deg q_j = n_j + n_{j+1}$$

Define

$$\Delta_j^P(t;x) = \det(D_j^P - t\mathrm{Id})$$

Then we define the parabolic quantum double Schubert polynomials $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w^P(x;y)$ for $w \in W^P$ by

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w^P(x;y) = (-1)^{\ell(w(w_0^P)^{-1})}\partial^{(y)}_{w(w_0^P)^{-1}} \prod_{j=1}^{k} \Delta_j^P(-y_{n-N_{j+1}+1},\ldots,-y_{n-N_j};x)$$

where $w_0^P$ is the longest element of $W^P$.

Taken as defined, when we vary $n$ these polynomials are not stable under inclusion and do not form a basis of $\mathbb{Z}[q][x_1,\ldots,x_n;y]$ as a module over $\mathbb{Z}[q][y]$. To obtain stability and a basis, instead we fix $n$ and choose $N > n$ as large as we would like, maintaining $N_{k+1} = n$ and setting $n_{k+2} = N - n$. From a cohomological perspective, this introduces "extraneous" polynomials that are indexed by elements not in $W^P$. The full indexing set is $W^{\widehat{P}} \subset S_\infty$, where

$$\widehat{P} = P \cup \{s_{n+1}, s_{n+2}, \ldots\}$$

**Example 2.7.** As equivariant cohomology rings of finite dimensional projective varieties over $\mathbb{C}$ are finitely generated modules over the coefficient ring, it is fully expected that products of double Schubert polynomials may include terms indexed by permutations that do not lie within the indexing set of the basis of Schubert classes. For example, consider the following non-quantum double Schubert polynomial product, with $P = \{s_1, s_3\}$ and basis elements in $S_4$:

$$\begin{aligned}\mathfrak{S}_{2413}(x;y)\,\mathfrak{S}_{3412}(x;y) = &-(\alpha_1+\alpha_2)(\alpha_1+\alpha_2+\alpha_3)(\alpha_2+\alpha_3)\ \mathfrak{S}_{3412}(x;y)\\ &+(\alpha_1+\alpha_2)(\alpha_1+2\alpha_2+2\alpha_3+\alpha_4)\ \mathfrak{S}_{35124}(x;y)\\ &-(\alpha_1+\alpha_2)\ \mathfrak{S}_{361245}(x;y)\\ &-(\alpha_1+2\alpha_2+2\alpha_3+\alpha_4)\ \mathfrak{S}_{45123}(x;y)\\ &+\mathfrak{S}_{461235}(x;y).\end{aligned}$$

Not only does the product $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{2413}^P(x;y)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{3412}^P(x;y)$ include extra terms indexed by permutations in $W^P$, there are also terms with nonzero coefficients that are in $W^{\widehat{P}} \setminus W^P$:

$$\begin{aligned}q_1(\alpha_1\alpha_2+\alpha_1\alpha_3+\alpha_2\alpha_3+\alpha_2^2)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{132}^P(x;y) &+ q_1(\alpha_1+\alpha_2)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{231}^P(x;y)\\ &+ q_1(\alpha_2+\alpha_3)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1423}^P(x;y)\\ &+ q_1(\alpha_1+\alpha_2)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{13254}^{\widehat{P}}(x;y)\\ &+ q_1\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{14253}^{\widehat{P}}(x;y)\\ &+ q_1\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{15234}^P(x;y)\\ &+ q_1\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{2413}^P(x;y)\end{aligned}$$

**Definition 2.8** ($q$-vectors and Peterson-Woodward lifts)**.** Define $Q^\vee$, for legacy purposes, to be the set of weak compositions. For an integer $i$ and $d \in Q^\vee$, define

$$\langle d\rangle_i = 2d_i - d_{i-1} - d_{i+1}$$

The double indexed version will be denoted by

$$\langle d\rangle_{ij} = \sum_{k=i}^{j-1}\langle d\rangle_k$$

For a parabolic subgroup $W_P$, we define $Q_P^\vee$ to be the set of weak compositions $d$ such that $\langle d\rangle_i = 0$ for all $s_i \notin P$. The $q$-vectors in $W^P$ are indexed by $Q^\vee/Q_P^\vee$.

Let $d_P \in Q^\vee/Q_P^\vee$. A *Peterson-Woodward lift* of $d_P$ is a $d \in Q^\vee$ such that $d_P \in d + Q_P^\vee$ and $\langle d\rangle_{ij} \in \{0,-1\}$ for all $i,j$ such that $s_i,\ldots,s_{j-1} \in P$.

**Method 2.9** (Checking the Peterson-Woodward lift property)**.** While backing out a Peterson-Woodward lift is difficult, going in the other direction is not. Suppose $d \in Q^\vee$ and $P$ is parabolic. If there is any $i \in P$ such that $\langle d \rangle_i \notin \{0, -1\}$, then $d$ is not a Peterson-Woodward lift. If this condition does hold, let $I_1, \ldots, I_m$ be the maximal intervals of consecutive indices $i$ with $s_i \in P$. Since $\langle d \rangle_{ij} = \sum_{l=i}^{j-1} \langle d \rangle_l$, the condition $\langle d \rangle_{ij} \in \{0, -1\}$ for all $i < j$ with $s_i, \ldots, s_{j-1} \in P$ holds if and only if each interval $I_r$ contains at most one index $l$ with $\langle d \rangle_l = -1$. If and only if this is the case, $d$ is the Peterson-Woodward lift of a unique $d_P \in Q^\vee / Q_P^\vee$, namely its image, which we denote by $\pi_P(d)$. In that case we let

$$z_P(d) = \{\, i \mid s_i \in P,\ \langle d \rangle_i = 0 \,\}$$

and write $w_{z_P(d)}$ for the longest element of the parabolic subgroup generated by $\{s_i \mid i \in z_P(d)\}$, and $w_P$ for the longest element of $W_P$.

This algorithm is polynomial in the length of $d$, which in almost all currently feasible cases is quite small. In contrast, a naive search for $d$ with $d_P$ as the input has an exponential search space, though a more refined algorithm may exist.

The parabolic triple quantum Schubert structure constants $c_{u,v}^{w,d_P}(y;z)$ are defined by

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u^P(x;y)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v^P(x;z) = \sum_{w \in W^{\widehat{P}},\, d_P} q^{d_P}\, c_{u,v}^{w,d_P}(y;z)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w^P(x;y).$$

We prove the following result in Section 8, as a consequence of the Peterson–Woodward comparison formula of Huang and Li [7] and Lemma 2.1.

**Proposition 2.10.** *Let $W_P$ be a parabolic subgroup of $S_\infty$ with $P = \widehat{P}$ and let $u, v, w \in W^P$. Then for any $d_P \in Q^\vee / Q_P^\vee$ with Peterson–Woodward lift $d$, we have that*

$$c_{u,v}^{w,d_P}(y;z) = c_{u,v}^{w w_P w_{z_P(d)},\, d}(y;z).$$

Thus, though we lack a simple functoriality property, we can reduce the computation of parabolic triple quantum Schubert structure constants completely to the complete flag variety case with an efficient algorithm. We obtain a nontrivial corollary from this.

**Example 2.11.** The product in the example above, with $P = \widehat{P}$ satisfying $P \cap \{s_1, s_2, s_3, s_4, s_5\} = \{s_1, s_4\}$, allows us to compute the triple structure constants for the corresponding parabolic quantum double Schubert polynomials:

$$\begin{aligned}
&q_1 q_2\,(y_1 + y_2 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1243}^P(x;y)\\
&+ q_1 q_2\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{124365}^P(x;y) + q_1 q_2\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1342}^P(x;y) + q_1 q_2\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1423}^P(x;y)\\
&+ q_2\,((y_1 - z_2)(y_1 - z_3) + (y_1 - z_3)(y_5 - z_1) + (y_5 - z_1)(y_5 - z_2))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{15234}^P(x;y)\\
&+ q_2\,(y_1 + y_5 + y_6 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{162345}^P(x;y) + q_2\,(y_1 + y_2 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{25134}^P(x;y)\\
&+ ((y_1 - z_2)(y_1 - z_3)(y_4 - z_2) + (y_1 - z_2)(y_1 - z_3)(y_5 - z_1) + (y_1 - z_2)(y_5 - z_1)(y_5 - z_2)\\
&\quad + (y_1 - z_3)(y_4 - z_1)(y_5 - z_1) + (y_4 - z_1)(y_5 - z_1)(y_5 - z_2))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{15423}^P(x;y)\\
&+ q_2\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1723456}^P(x;y) + q_2\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{261345}^P(x;y) + q_2\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{35124}^P(x;y)\\
&+ ((y_1 - z_2)(y_1 - z_3) + (y_1 - z_3)(y_5 - z_1) + (y_5 - z_1)(y_5 - z_2))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{156234}^P(x;y)\\
&+ ((y_1 - z_2)(y_1 - z_3) + (y_1 - z_2)(y_5 + y_6 - z_1 - z_2)\\
&\quad + (y_1 - z_3)(y_4 - z_1) + (y_4 - z_1)(y_5 + y_6 - z_1 - z_2))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{164235}^P(x;y)\\
&+ ((y_4 - z_1)(y_5 - z_3) + (y_4 - z_1)(y_1 + y_2 - z_1 - z_2)\\
&\quad + (y_5 - z_2)(y_5 - z_3) + (y_5 - z_2)(y_1 + y_2 - z_1 - z_2))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{25413}^P(x;y)\\
&+ ((y_1 - z_1)(y_4 - z_1) + (y_5 - z_2)(y_1 + y_4 - z_1 - z_2))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{45123}^P(x;y)\\
&+ (y_1 + y_5 + y_6 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{165234}^P(x;y) + (y_1 + y_2 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{256134}^P(x;y)
\end{aligned}$$

$$+ (y_1 + y_4 - z_1 - z_2)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{1742356}(x;y) + (y_1 + y_4 - z_1 - z_2)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{461235}(x;y)$$
$$+ (y_1 + y_2 + y_4 + y_5 + y_6 - 2z_1 - 2z_2 - z_3)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{264135}(x;y)$$
$$+ (y_4 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{35412}(x;y) + (y_4 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{45213}(x;y)$$
$$+ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{1752346}(x;y) + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{265134}(x;y) + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{2741356}(x;y)$$
$$+ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{356124}(x;y) + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{364125}(x;y) + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{462135}(x;y)$$
$$+ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{561234}(x;y)$$

For an illustration, consider $d_P = (-,0,1,-,0)$ for the coefficient of 162345. $q^{d_P} = q_2$. The Peterson-Woodward lift of $d_P$ is $d = (0,0,1,0,0)$, and $w_P = 21354$. $z_P(d) = \{1\}$, so $w_P w_{z_P(d)} = 12354$. Thus, $ww_P w_{z_P(d)} = 162435$, and the $q_2$-component of the coefficient of $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{162345}(x;y)$ is $(y_1 + y_5 + y_6 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3)$, which is the same as the $q_3$-component ($q^d$) of the coefficient of $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{162435}(x;y)$ in the complete flag variety case (Example 2.4).

**Corollary 2.12** (Triple quantum Schubert positivity for the parabolic case)**.** *Let $W_P$ be a parabolic subgroup with $P = \widehat{P}$ and let $u, v, w \in W^P$. Then for every $d_P$ the parabolic structure constant $c^{w,d_P}_{u,v}(y;z)$ exhibits triple Schubert positivity. In particular this holds when $u, v, w$ are $k$-Grassmannian and $P$ is the corresponding maximal parabolic subgroup ($n_1 = k$, $n_2 = n - k$).*

*Proof.* By Proposition 2.10, $c^{w,d_P}_{u,v}(y;z)$ equals a structure constant $c^{w',d}_{u,v}(y;z)$ of the complete flag variety, which lies in $\mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}[y_i - z_j]$ by Theorem 2.3. □

## 3. Pieri

**Definition 3.1** ($\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$, $\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)$, $q_k(u,w)$, $E_{p,k}(y;z)$, $\mathbf{E}(y_A;z)$)**.** We define a relation $\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ on pairs of permutations, introduced in its non-quantum form by Sottile [19], which was used originally to indicate when the coefficient of a Schubert polynomial is nonzero in a suitable application of the Pieri formula. In the generalization to double Schubert polynomials in [16], the same relation applies to all nonzero coefficients in the expansion of the generalized Pieri formula. The relation plays the same role in our case.

Given $u, u' \in S_\infty$ and a positive integer $k$, we declare that $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ if there exists a $p$ with $0 \leq p \leq k$ such that there are transpositions $t_{a_1 b_1}, \ldots, t_{a_p b_p}$ satisfying

(1) $a_i \leq k < b_i$ for all $i$
(2) $a_i \neq a_j$ whenever $i \neq j$
(3) $b_i \geq b_j$ whenever $i < j$
(4) We have either
$$\ell(ut_{a_1 b_1} \cdots t_{a_i b_i}) = \ell(ut_{a_1 b_1} \cdots t_{a_{i-1} b_{i-1}}) + 1$$
or
$$\ell(ut_{a_1 b_1} \cdots t_{a_i b_i}) = \ell(ut_{a_1 b_1} \cdots t_{a_{i-1} b_{i-1}}) - 2(b_i - a_i) + 1$$
for all $i$
(5) $w = ut_{a_1 b_1} \cdots t_{a_p b_p}$

In contrast to the non-quantum case, $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ does not imply that $\ell(u) \leq \ell(w)$, as the final condition can cause the length of the permutation to drop. For intuition, the condition $\ell(ut_{ab}) = \ell(u) - 2(b-a) + 1$ means that if we write the reflection $t_{ab}$ as
$$s_b s_{b-1} \cdots s_{a+1} s_a s_{a+1} \cdots s_{b-1} s_b$$
then each simple reflection in this word cancels a corresponding simple reflection in a reduced word for $u$, as opposite to the length-increase case where there is a word for which precisely one simple reflection is inserted, regardless of the length of the reflection as a permutation.

If $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, define
$$\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w) = \{u(i) \mid i \leq k \text{ and } u(i) = w(i)\}$$
and
$$n_k(u,w) = k - |\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)|.$$

Also, we define $q_k(u,w)$ recursively. If $u = w$, define $q_k(u,w) = 1$. If we have defined $q_k(u,w')$ with $w' = t_{a_1b_1}\cdots t_{a_{p-1}b_{p-1}}$, suppose $\ell(w't_{a_pb_p}) = \ell(w') + 1$. Then define

$$q_k(u,w) = q_k(u,w')$$

If instead $\ell(w't_{a_pb_p}) = \ell(w') - 2(b_p - a_p) + 1$, define

$$q_k(u,w) = q_k(u,w')q_{a_pb_p}$$

Suppose $y$ and $z$ are sets of variables and $0 \leq p \leq k$ are integers. We define $E_{p,k}(y;z)$ to be the factorial elementary symmetric polynomial in $y$ and $z$. For specificity, this is the double Schubert polynomial $\mathfrak{S}_{c[p,k]}(y;z)$ where

$$c[p,k] = s_{k-p+1}\cdots s_{k-1}s_k$$

If $p = 0$, the polynomial is identically 1. If $p = k$, $E_{k,k}(y;z)$ can be simply written as

$$E_{k,k}(y;z) = \prod_{i=1}^{k}(y_i - z_1)$$

An explicit formula can be written for general $p$ without too much trouble as well, using e.g. [14]:

$$E_{p,k}(y;z) = \sum_{1\leq i_1<\cdots<i_p\leq k}\prod_{j=1}^{p}(y_{i_j} - z_{i_j-j+1})$$

For a set $A = \{i_1,\ldots,i_{|A|}\}$, we define

$$\mathbf{E}(y_A;z) = \prod_{i\in A}(y_i - z_1) = E_{|A|,|A|}(y_{i_1},\ldots,y_{i_{|A|}};z),$$

the specialization of the factorial elementary polynomial to which the coefficients of the Pieri formula reduce. It will be used to express those coefficients.

**Definition 3.2** (Quantum factorial elementary polynomials $\widetilde{E}_{p,k}(x;z)$)**.** For $0 \leq p \leq k$ we define

$$\widetilde{E}_{p,k}(x;z) = \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{c[p,k]}(x;z),$$

the quantum double Schubert polynomial of the Grassmannian permutation $c[p,k] = s_{k-p+1}\cdots s_k$, whose diagram is a single column of height $p$ with descent at $k$. At $q = 0$ this is $E_{p,k}(x;z)$. We also set $\widetilde{E}_{0,k} = 1$ and $\widetilde{E}_{p,k} = 0$ for $p < 0$.

**Lemma 3.3.** *For $k \geq 1$,*

$$\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = \Delta_k(-z_1 \mid x_1,\ldots,x_k) = \sum_{j=0}^{k}(-z_1)^{k-j}e_j^{(q)}(x_1,\ldots,x_k).$$

*Proof.* The permutation $c[k,k] = s_1s_2\cdots s_k$ has a unique reduced word, so its reduced factorizations are $v_1 = s_1\cdots s_j$, $v_2 = s_{j+1}\cdots s_k$ for $0 \leq j \leq k$. By Lemma 2.1 with $y = 0$, $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = \sum_j \mathfrak{S}_{s_1\cdots s_j}(0;z)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_{j+1}\cdots s_k}(x)$. Here $s_1\cdots s_j$ is dominant with code $(1^j)$, so $\mathfrak{S}_{s_1\cdots s_j}(x;z) = \prod_{i\leq j}(x_i - z_1)$ and $\mathfrak{S}_{s_1\cdots s_j}(0;z) = (-z_1)^j$; and $s_{j+1}\cdots s_k$ is the Grassmannian permutation with descent at $k$ and a single column of height $k-j$, whose Schubert polynomial $e_{k-j}(x_1,\ldots,x_k)$ is a standard elementary monomial, so that its quantum Schubert polynomial is $e^{(q)}_{k-j}(x_1,\ldots,x_k)$ [5]. Summing gives the second expression, which equals $\Delta_k(-z_1 \mid x_1,\ldots,x_k)$ by the definition of the quantum elementary polynomials. □

**Theorem 3.4** (The Pieri formula)**.** *Suppose $u \in S_\infty$ and $k \geq 1$. Then*

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = \sum_{u\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}w} q_k(u,w)\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)};z)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y).$$

The proof is given in Section 6. Note that the right-hand side is manifestly triple Schubert positive, in accordance with Theorem 2.3, and that at $q = 0$ it reduces to the case $p = k$ of the Pieri formula of [16, Theorem 7.1].

## 4. Algorithms for multiplying (quantum) double Schubert polynomials

**Definition 4.1** ($\mathfrak{c}$, (strict) dominant permutations, $\theta$, $\mu$, $\widetilde{\theta}$, $\widetilde{\mu}$, medium theta $\overline{\theta}$, $\overline{\mu}$)**.** We say that a permutation $\mu$ is *dominant* if $\mathfrak{c}_i(\mu) \geq \mathfrak{c}_{i+1}(\mu)$ for all $i$. A permutation $\mu$ is said to be *strict dominant* if $\mu$ is dominant and whenever $\mathfrak{c}_i(\mu) \neq 0$ we have $\mathfrak{c}_i(\mu) > \mathfrak{c}_{i+1}(\mu)$. For a permutation $v \in S_\infty$, we define a dominant permutation $\mu(v)$ recursively as follows. If $v$ is already dominant, define $\mu(v) = v$. Otherwise, let $i$ be the maximal index such that $\mathfrak{c}_i(v) < \mathfrak{c}_{i+1}(v)$, and define

$$\mu(v) = \mu(vs_i)$$

Define $\theta_i(v)$ to be $\mathfrak{c}_i(\mu(v))$.

Similarly, for a permutation $v \in S_\infty$, we define a strict dominant permutation $\widetilde{\mu}(v)$ recursively as follows. If $v$ is already strict dominant, define $\widetilde{\mu}(v) = v$. Otherwise, let $i$ be the maximal index such that $\mathfrak{c}_{i+1}(v) \neq 0$ and $\mathfrak{c}_i(v) \leq \mathfrak{c}_{i+1}(v)$, then define

$$\widetilde{\mu}(v) = \widetilde{\mu}(vs_i)$$

Define $\widetilde{\theta}_i(v)$ to be $\mathfrak{c}_i(\widetilde{\mu}(v))$.

Between these two lies the *medium theta* $\overline{\theta}(v)$, the partition actually iterated by the quantum multiplication algorithm. Like $\theta(v)$ it is a weakly decreasing partition obtained from $\mathfrak{c}(v)$ by incrementing and reordering, but it stops short of separating every pair of equal parts: a pair of equal consecutive nonzero parts $\overline{\theta}_i(v) = \overline{\theta}_{i+1}(v)$ is left in place exactly when it is preceded by a strict drop of at least two, that is $\overline{\theta}_{i-1}(v) \geq \overline{\theta}_i(v) + 2$ (or $i = 1$), and every other ascent or equality is removed by incrementing as for $\theta$. Thus $\overline{\theta}(v)$ permits some, but not all, repeated parts, and lies between $\theta(v)$ (arbitrary repeats) and $\widetilde{\theta}(v)$ (no repeats). We write $\overline{\mu}(v)$ for the permutation with $\mathfrak{c}(\overline{\mu}(v)) = \overline{\theta}(v)$ and set $|\overline{\theta}(v)| := \sum_i \overline{\theta}_i(v) = \ell(\overline{\mu}(v))$. The number of nonzero parts of $\overline{\theta}(v)$ equals the number of nonzero parts of $\mathfrak{c}(v)$.

**Definition 4.2** ($\overset{i}{\Rightarrow}$, $\sigma_i(u,v)$, $D_i(u,v)$)**.** Let $u, v \in S_\infty$ and $i \geq 1$ be an integer. We define $u \overset{i}{\Rightarrow} v$ if there exist distinct integers $b_1, b_2, \ldots, b_k$ such that $b_j \neq i$ for all $j$, $\ell(ut_{i,b_1} \cdots t_{i,b_j}) = \ell(u) + j$ for all $j$, and

$$v = ut_{i,b_1} \cdots t_{i,b_k}$$

We define

$$\sigma_i(u,v) = \#\{j \mid b_j < i\}$$

and we define

$$D_i(u,v) = \{u(i)\} \cup \{u(j) \mid u(j) \neq v(j)\}$$

The following two formulas express a (quantum) double Schubert polynomial as a signed sum of products of (quantum) factorial elementary polynomials in nested initial alphabets; they are the $v$-side input of the multiplication algorithm. The first is proved in [17]. The second is its quantum analogue and is proved in the same way, the only new ingredient being the factorization of $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_\mu(x;z)$ for a strict dominant permutation $\mu$: if the column heights $\lambda'_1 > \lambda'_2 > \cdots$ of the diagram of $\mu$ are pairwise distinct, then $x^{\mathfrak{c}(\mu)} = \prod_j e_{\lambda'_j}(x_1, \ldots, x_{\lambda'_j})$ is a single standard elementary monomial, so that the Fomin–Gelfand–Postnikov quantization gives $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_\mu(x;z) = \prod_j \widetilde{E}_{\lambda'_j,\lambda'_j}(x;z_j)$; this is the reason $\mu$ is replaced by $\widetilde{\mu}$ in the quantum case, since for repeated column heights the quantum polynomial is *not* a product (see Section 7). The implementation uses the intermediate shape $\overline{\theta}$, in which an equal pair of columns is allowed when there is room for it, and handles such a pair by the doubled formula of Theorem 7.4.

**Theorem 4.3** (Formula for ordinary double Schubert polynomials, [17])**.** *Suppose $v \in S_\infty$. Then*

$$\mathfrak{S}_v(x;z) = \sum_{(v_0,\ldots,v_k)} \prod_{i=1}^{k} (-1)^{\sigma_i(v_{i-1},v_i)} E_{\theta_i(v)-\ell(v_{i-1},v_i),\theta_i(v)}(x; z_{D_i(v_{i-1},v_i)})$$

*Where $v_{i-1} \overset{i}{\Rightarrow} v_i$ for all $i$, $v_0 = 1$, and $v_k = v\mu(v^{-1})$.*

**Theorem 4.4** (Formula for quantum double Schubert polynomials)**.** *Suppose $v \in S_\infty$. Then*

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(x;z) = \sum_{(v_0,\ldots,v_k)} \prod_{i=1}^{k} (-1)^{\sigma_i(v_{i-1},v_i)} E^q_{\widetilde{\theta}_i(v)-\ell(v_{i-1},v_i),\widetilde{\theta}_i(v)}(x; z_{D_i(v_{i-1},v_i)})$$

*Where* $v_{i-1} \overset{i}{\Rightarrow} v_i$ *for all* $i$, $v_0 = 1$, *and* $v_k = v\widetilde{\mu}(v^{-1})$.

Coupled with the Pieri formulas, these formulas give an algorithm for computing products of (quantum) double Schubert polynomials, which is the one implemented in [18]. We describe its classical form by building it from two ingredients: the elementary Pieri step that generates the $u$-side covers, and the signed path expansion on the $v$-side.

**Definition 4.5** ($k$-strip cover, admissible $k$-chain, the $(p,k)$-Pieri problem)**.** Let $w \in S_n$, let $1 \le k < n$, and let $\beta \in \{1,\dots,n\} \cup \{\infty\}$. A *$k$-strip cover of* $(w,\beta)$ is a transposition $t_{ab}$ of positions $a, b$ with $1 \le a \le k < b \le n$ such that

(1) $w \lessdot wt_{ab}$ in Bruhat order; that is, $w(a) < w(b)$ and no $c$ with $a < c < b$ satisfies $w(a) < w(c) < w(b)$; and
(2) $w(b) < \beta$.

Its *output* is the pair $(wt_{ab},\, w(b))$. An *admissible $k$-chain of length $p$* from $u$ is a sequence $u = w_0, w_1, \dots, w_p$ carrying bounds $\infty = \beta_0 > \beta_1 > \cdots > \beta_p$ in which $(w_t, \beta_t)$ is the output of a $k$-strip cover of $(w_{t-1}, \beta_{t-1})$ for every $t$. The *$(p,k)$-Pieri problem* for $u$ asks to enumerate every admissible $k$-chain from $u$ of length at most $p$. These chains index the permutations occurring in $e_p(x_1,\dots,x_k)\,\mathfrak{S}_u$, where $e_p$ is the elementary symmetric polynomial.

**Method 4.6** (**pieri**$(u,p,k)$)**.** Given $u \in S_n$, $1 \le k < n$, and $0 \le p \le k$, the algorithm returns a list $T$ of pairs $(w,t)$, one for each admissible $k$-chain from $u$ of length $t \le p$, recording its endpoint $w$.

(1) Initialize $T \leftarrow [(u,0)]$ and a frontier $F \leftarrow [(u,\infty)]$.
(2) For $t = 1,\dots,p$, form a new frontier $F' \leftarrow [\,]$ and, for each $(w,\beta) \in F$:
   (a) compute $A \leftarrow \{\, a \in \{1,\dots,k\} \mid w(a) < \beta \,\}$;
   (b) for each $b = k+1,\dots,n$ with $w(b) < \beta$, and each $a \in A$ for which $t_{ab}$ is a $k$-strip cover of $(w,\beta)$, append $(wt_{ab},\, w(b))$ to $F'$ and $(wt_{ab},\, t)$ to $T$.

   Then set $F \leftarrow F'$.
(3) Return $T$.

**Lemma 4.7** (Multiplicity-freeness)**.** *For each $t$, distinct admissible $k$-chains from $u$ of length $t$ have distinct endpoints; equivalently, the endpoint map is a bijection from admissible $k$-chains of length $t$ onto the permutations $w$ with $w \gtrdot^k u$ of length $\ell(u)+t$ produced by the Pieri rule for $e_t(x_1,\dots,x_k)$.*

*Proof.* The strictly decreasing bounds $\beta_0 > \beta_1 > \cdots$ force the values moved leftward across position $k$ to be strictly decreasing, which is exactly the condition making the $e_t$-Pieri expansion multiplicity-free; see [2]. Reconstructing the chain from its endpoint by peeling off these moves in decreasing order of value shows the map is injective, hence bijective onto the Pieri support. □

We now describe the $v$-side primitive. Its starting point is the structure of a *dominant* double Schubert polynomial. If $\mu$ is dominant with $\mathfrak{c}(\mu) = (\lambda_1,\dots,\lambda_m)$, then $\mathfrak{S}_\mu(x;z)$ factors as a product of factorial elementary symmetric polynomials of maximal degree, one per column of the shape,

$$\mathfrak{S}_\mu(x;z) = \prod_{i=1}^{m} E_{\lambda_i,\,\lambda_i}(x; z^{(i)}),$$

where $z^{(i)}$ is the shifted $z$-alphabet attached to column $i$ (Definition 3.1). For a general $v$ one writes $\mathfrak{S}_v(x;z)$ by applying divided differences in the $z$-variables to the dominant polynomial $\mathfrak{S}_{\mu(v^{-1})}(x;z)$; because that polynomial factors by column, the divided-difference action decouples and may be carried out one column (one $z^{(i)}$-group) at a time. Applied to a single column this produces a *signed* descending expansion. The following primitive carries it out.

**Definition 4.8** ($k$-strip descent beneath an edge, the down-Pieri problem)**.** Let $w, \mu \in S_n$ and $1 \le k < n$. Say $w'$ lies *beneath the edge* $\mu$ if

$$\operatorname{inv}(w'\mu) = \operatorname{inv}(\mu) - \operatorname{inv}(w'),$$

that is, $\ell(w'\mu) = \ell(\mu) - \ell(w')$. A *$k$-strip descent* of $w$ is a Bruhat descent $w \gtrdot wt_{ab}$ realized by a transposition $t_{ab}$ that moves the value in the pivot position $k$ either leftward (from a position $a < k$, with sign $-1$) or rightward (to a position $b > k$, with sign $+1$), touching only positions still holding their original value. Given

a starting label $w$, the edge $\mu$, a degree $p$, and the column $k$, the *down-Pieri problem* asks for the signed list of those length-$t$ descending $k$-strip chains from $w$ ($t \le p$) whose endpoint lies beneath $\mu$.

**Method 4.9** (**kdown**$(w, \mu, p, k)$)**.** The algorithm returns a signed list $D$ of triples $(w', t, s)$, one for each length-$t$ descending $k$-strip chain from $w$ ($t \le p$) whose endpoint $w'$ lies beneath $\mu$, with $s \in \{+1, -1\}$ its sign.

(1) Initialize $D \leftarrow [\,]$; if $w$ is already beneath $\mu$, append $(w, 0, +1)$. Set a frontier $F \leftarrow [(w, +1)]$.
(2) For $t = 1, \dots, p$, form $F' \leftarrow [\,]$ and, for each $(w'', s) \in F$:
   (a) (leftward) for each position $a < k$ with $w''(a) = w(a)$ such that $w'' \gtrdot w''t_{a,k}$ is a Bruhat descent, set $w''' \leftarrow w''t_{a,k}$ and append $(w''', -s)$ to $F'$; if $w'''$ is beneath $\mu$, append $(w''', t, -s)$ to $D$;
   (b) (rightward) for each position $b > k$ with $w''(b) = w(b)$ such that $w'' \gtrdot w''t_{k,b}$ is a Bruhat descent, set $w''' \leftarrow w''t_{k,b}$ and append $(w''', +s)$ to $F'$; if $w'''$ is beneath $\mu$, append $(w''', t, +s)$ to $D$.

   Then set $F \leftarrow F'$.
(3) Return $D$.

Applied without the edge $\mu$, the signed descending expansion produces many extraneous terms that ultimately cancel. The edge is exactly the bound that discards them: only endpoints beneath $\mu$ are retained in $D$. In the assembled $v$-side (Method 4.10 below), only these retained labels seed the next column, so each stage passes forward only labels compatible with the remaining shape.

**Method 4.10** (**vpaths**$(v)$, the $v$-side path dictionaries)**.** Let $\theta := \theta(v^{-1})$ with nonzero parts in columns $1, \dots, L$, and let $\nu := v\,\mu(v^{-1})$. Processing columns from $i = L$ down to $i = 1$, maintain for each column a set of live labels (initialized at column $L$ to the single label $\nu$). At column $i$, with $k = i$ and edge $\mu_i := \mu$ of the shape truncated below column $i$, call **kdown**$(w, \mu_i, \theta_i, k)$ for each live label $w$; record its signed output triples as the transitions out of $w$, and let their endpoints be the live labels seeding column $i - 1$. The collected transitions form the path dictionaries used by **schubmult**.

**Lemma 4.11** (Correctness of the edge filter)**.** *A permutation $w'$ produced by a descending $k$-strip chain from $w$ is retained by* **kdown**$(w, \mu, p, k)$ *if and only if $w'$ lies beneath $\mu$, i.e.* $\mathrm{inv}(w'\mu) = \mathrm{inv}(\mu) - \mathrm{inv}(w')$*. In the assembly of Method 4.10 the retained signed labels are exactly the terms of $\mathfrak{S}_v(x; z)$ contributed through column $i$, so no extraneous (cancelling) label propagates to column $i - 1$.*

*Proof.* The retention test is the identity $\mathrm{inv}(w'\mu) = \mathrm{inv}(\mu) - \mathrm{inv}(w')$ checked in step (2); this is precisely the condition that $w' \le \mu$ with $\ell(w'\mu) = \ell(\mu) - \ell(w')$. The factorization of the dominant polynomial by column, together with the column-wise decoupling of the $z$-divided differences, identifies the beneath-$\mu$ endpoints at column $i$ with the surviving monomials of $\mathfrak{S}_v(x; z)$ after processing that column; the extraneous chains are exactly those leaving the shape, which the edge discards before they seed column $i - 1$. □

**Method 4.12** (The algorithm **schubmult**)**.** Fix $n$ and let $u, v \in S_n$. The algorithm **schubmult**$(u, v)$ computes the expansion of $\mathfrak{S}_u(x; z)\ \mathfrak{S}_v(x; z)$ in the Schubert basis as follows. Set $\theta := \theta(v^{-1})$ and let

$$L := \#\{i \mid \theta_i \neq 0\}$$

be the number of nonzero parts. The algorithm proceeds in $L$ layers. It maintains a *front*, a collection of nodes each consisting of an intermediate permutation on the $u$-side paired with a label on the $v$-side, initialized to the single node $(u, e)$. At layer $i$ it replaces each node by the nodes obtained by combining one $u$-side cover, generated by **pieri**$(\,\cdot\,, \theta_i, \theta_i)$ (Method 4.6), with one $v$-side transition, generated by **vpaths**$(v)$ (Method 4.10), accumulating coefficients in the coefficient ring. After all $L$ layers the surviving coefficients at $v$-label $v\mu(v^{-1})$ give the structure constants.

Quantum version. The same path organization gives the quantum multiplication algorithm. Its layers are indexed by the medium theta $\overline{\theta}(v^{-1})$; equal consecutive parts that are retained in this shape are handled together by the paired quantum Pieri step, the doubled formula of Theorem 7.4 (see Remark 7.25 for why the pair must be preceded by a drop of at least two). On the $u$-side, classical covers are replaced by the quantum covers of Remark 2.2, including length-decreasing moves, whose contributions carry the corresponding $q$-monomials. The $v$-side continues to use the descending path dictionaries of Method 4.10. Thus the two algorithms share the same layer-by-layer structure, while their Pieri transitions reflect the classical or quantum multiplication rule, respectively.

The algorithmic construction is one way to compute products. We now turn to a complementary operator description, which packages the quantum multiplication rules in the Fomin–Gelfand–Postnikov difference operators.

### 4.1. **Difference operators and multiplication coefficients.**

**Definition 4.13** ($\chi_{j;n}$, $\chi^{(n)}$)**.** Recall the commuting difference operators $\chi_{j;n}$, $j \leq n$, of Fomin, Gelfand, and Postnikov [5], acting on polynomials in $x_1, \ldots, x_n$ (with coefficients in any further variables):

$$\chi_{j;n} = x_j - \sum_{1 \leq i < j} q_{ij} \partial^{t_{ij}} + \sum_{j < k \leq n} q_{jk} \partial^{t_{jk}},$$

where for a transposition $t$ we write $\partial^t$ for the divided difference operator $\partial_t$ in the $x$-variables associated with any reduced word of $t$, so that $\partial^t \mathfrak{S}_v(x;z) = \mathfrak{S}_{vt}(x;z)$ if $\ell(vt) = \ell(v) - \ell(t)$ and $\partial^t \mathfrak{S}_v(x;z) = 0$ otherwise. We denote the sequence $(\chi_{1;n}, \ldots, \chi_{n;n})$ with $n$ fixed by $\chi^{(n)}$. Fomin, Gelfand and Postnikov proved [5] that if $v \in S_n$ then

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)})(1) = \mathfrak{S}_v(x),$$

and hence, by Lemma 2.1 with $y = 0$ (whose coefficients $\mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(0;z)$ commute with the operators),

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)};z)(1) = \sum_{v_1 \cdot v_2 = v} \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(0;z)\, \mathfrak{S}_{v_2}(x) = \mathfrak{S}_v(x;z).$$

We specify a more precise formula, as follows.

**Theorem 4.14.** *Suppose $v \in S_n$. Then*

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)};z) = \sum_{u \in S_n, d} q^d c^{1,d}_{u,v}(x;z) \partial^u$$

*Proof.* Note that if $\mathfrak{S}_u(x)$ has at most $n$ variables, then

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(\chi^{(n)};y)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)};z) = \sum_{w,d} q^d c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;z)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(\chi^{(n)};y)$$

We thus have that

$$(\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(\chi^{(n)};y)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)};z))(1) = \sum_{w,d} q^d c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;z)\, \mathfrak{S}_w(x;y)$$

This is also equal to

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)};z)(\mathfrak{S}_u(x;y))$$

due to the fact that $(\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(\chi^{(n)};y))(1) = \mathfrak{S}_u(x;y)$. To obtain the coefficient of $\partial^u$ in $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)};z)$, we set $y = x$ after applying this operator. Since $\mathfrak{S}_w(x;x) = 0$ unless $w = 1$, we have that

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)};z)(\mathfrak{S}_u(x;y))|_{y=x} = \sum_d q^d c^{1,d}_{u,v}(x;z)$$

and the result follows. □

**Theorem 4.15.** *Let $k$ be an integer and let $v, w \in S_\infty$. Then*

$$\sum_d q^d c^{w,d}_{s_k,v}(y;z) = c^w_{s_k,v}(y;z) + \sum_{i \leq k < j} q_{ij}\, \mathfrak{S}_{vt_{ij}w^{-1}}(y;z),$$

*where the sum is over those $i < j$ with $\ell(vt_{ij}) = \ell(v) - \ell(t_{ij})$, and $\mathfrak{S}_{vt_{ij}w^{-1}}(y;z)$ is to be read as 0 unless $\ell(vt_{ij}) = \ell(vt_{ij}w^{-1}) + \ell(w)$.*

*Proof.* We have that the desired value is equal to the coefficient of $\mathfrak{S}_w(x;y)$ in

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_k}(\chi^{(n)};y)(\mathfrak{S}_v(x;z))$$

We have that

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_k}(\chi^{(n)};y) = \mathfrak{S}_{s_k}(x;y) + \sum_{i \leq k < j \leq n} q_{ij} \partial^{t_{ij}}$$

Applying this operator, we obtain

$$\sum_{i\le k<j\le n} q_{ij}\,\mathfrak{S}_{vt_{ij}}(x;z)+\sum_w c^w_{s_k,v}(y;z)\,\mathfrak{S}_w(x;y)$$

Applying the Cauchy formula (Lemma 2.1 at $q=0$), this is equal to

$$\sum_{i\le k<j}\sum_u q_{ij}\,\mathfrak{S}_{vt_{ij}u^{-1}}(y;z)\,\mathfrak{S}_u(x;y)+\sum_w c^w_{s_k,v}(y;z)\,\mathfrak{S}_w(x;y),$$

the inner sum being over the reduced factorizations $vt_{ij}=(vt_{ij}u^{-1})\cdot u$. Setting $u=w$ and allowing $n$ to be sufficiently large, we obtain the result. □

## 5. Quantum to classical reduction

In this section we extend the quantum-to-classical reduction of Huang and Li [7] from the equivariant quantum structure constants $c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;y)$ to the triple constants. We write $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w)=1$ if $w(i)>w(i+1)$ and $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w)=0$ otherwise, $\delta_i\in Q^\vee$ for the weak composition with a single 1 in position $i$, and $|d|=\sum_i d_i$; the bracket $\langle d\rangle_i=2d_i-d_{i-1}-d_{i+1}$ was defined in Section 2. We say that $u\in S_\infty$ is *$k$-Grassmannian* if $k$ is its only descent.

**Theorem 5.1** ([7, Theorem 2.7])**.** *We have the following.*

(1) $c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;y)=0$ *unless* $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w)+\langle d\rangle_i\le\mathrm{sgn}_i(u)+\mathrm{sgn}_i(v)$ *for all* $i$.
(2) *If* $\mathrm{sgn}_k(w)+\langle d\rangle_k=\mathrm{sgn}_k(u)+\mathrm{sgn}_k(v)=2$ *for some* $k$, *then*

$$c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;y)=c^{ws_k,d-\delta_k}_{us_k,vs_k}(y;y)=\begin{cases}c^{ws_k,d-\delta_k}_{us_k,v}(y;y) & \text{if } \mathrm{sgn}_k(w)=0\\ c^{ws_k,d}_{us_k,v}(y;y) & \text{if } \mathrm{sgn}_k(w)=1\end{cases}$$

*This is symmetric in $u$ and $v$.*

**Corollary 5.2** ([7, Corollary 2.8])**.** *Let $u,v,w\in S_\infty$ and $d\in Q^\vee$. Fix an index $i$.*

(1) *If* $\langle d\rangle_i=\mathrm{sgn}_i(u)=0$ *and* $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w)=\mathrm{sgn}_i(v)=1$, *then*

$$c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;y)=c^{ws_i,d}_{u,vs_i}(y;y).$$

(2) *If* $\langle d\rangle_i=\mathrm{sgn}_i(u)=1$ *and* $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w)=\mathrm{sgn}_i(v)=0$, *then*

$$c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;y)=c^{ws_i,d-\delta_i}_{us_i,v}(y;y).$$

*This is symmetric in $u$ and $v$.*

**Theorem 5.3** (Quantum reduction holds for triple quantum Schubert coefficients)**.** *We have the following.*

(1) $c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;z)=0$ *unless* $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w)+\langle d\rangle_i\le\mathrm{sgn}_i(u)+\mathrm{sgn}_i(v)$ *for all* $i$.
(2) *If* $\mathrm{sgn}_k(w)+\langle d\rangle_k=\mathrm{sgn}_k(u)+\mathrm{sgn}_k(v)=2$ *for some* $k$, *then*

$$c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;z)=c^{ws_k,d-\delta_k}_{us_k,vs_k}(y;z)=\begin{cases}c^{ws_k,d-\delta_k}_{us_k,v}(y;z) & \text{if } \mathrm{sgn}_k(w)=0\\ c^{ws_k,d}_{us_k,v}(y;z) & \text{if } \mathrm{sgn}_k(w)=1\end{cases}$$

*This is symmetric in $u$ and $v$.*

*Proof.* For (1), we note that since $\mathrm{sgn}_i(v_2)\le\mathrm{sgn}_i(v)$ for any factorization $v_1\cdot v_2=v$, we have that $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w)+\langle d\rangle_i\le\mathrm{sgn}_i(u)+\mathrm{sgn}_i(v_2)$ is a necessary condition for $c^{w,d}_{u,v_2}(y;y)\neq 0$. The result then follows from Lemma 2.1.

For (2), we note that if $\mathrm{sgn}_k(w)+\langle d\rangle_k=\mathrm{sgn}_k(u)+\mathrm{sgn}_k(v)=2$, then since $\mathrm{sgn}_k(v_2)=\mathrm{sgn}_k(v)$ for any factorization $v_1\cdot v_2=v$ such that $c^{w,d}_{u,v_2}(y;y)\neq 0$, Theorem 5.1(2) holds for each term in the sum in Lemma 2.1, and the result follows. □

**Corollary 5.4** ($z$-version of Corollary 5.2(2))**.** *Let $u,v,w\in S_\infty$ and $d\in Q^\vee$, and fix an index $i$ with* $\mathrm{sgn}_i(v)=0$. *If* $\langle d\rangle_i=\mathrm{sgn}_i(u)=1$ *and* $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w)=0$, *then*

$$c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;z)=c^{ws_i,d-\delta_i}_{us_i,v}(y;z).$$

*Proof.* Since $\mathrm{sgn}_i(v_2)\le\mathrm{sgn}_i(v)=0$ for every factorization $v_1\cdot v_2=v$, the hypotheses of Corollary 5.2(2) hold for each term $c^{w,d}_{u,v_2}(y;y)$ appearing in Lemma 2.1, so $c^{w,d}_{u,v_2}(y;y)=c^{ws_i,d-\delta_i}_{us_i,v_2}(y;y)$. Resumming via Lemma 2.1 gives the claim. □

**Lemma 5.5** (Reduction to a coroot supported at $k$)**.** *Let $u, v, w \in S_\infty$ and let $d \in Q^\vee$. Suppose $v$ has precisely one descent, which is $k$. If $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z) \neq 0$, then there exist $u', w' \in S_\infty$ and $d' \in Q^\vee$ with $0 \leq d' \leq d$ such that*

$$c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z) = c_{u',v}^{w',d'}(y;z)$$

*and $\langle d' \rangle_i \leq 0$ for all $i \neq k$. Moreover, if $d' \neq 0$ then $\langle d' \rangle_k > 0$.*

*Proof.* Suppose $\langle d \rangle_i > 0$ for some $i \neq k$, and choose such an $i$ to be maximal. Because $v$ is $k$-Grassmannian, $\mathrm{sgn}_i(v) = 0$, so Theorem 5.3(1) forces

$$\mathrm{sgn}_i(w) + \langle d \rangle_i \leq \mathrm{sgn}_i(u) + \mathrm{sgn}_i(v) = \mathrm{sgn}_i(u) \leq 1.$$

Since $\langle d \rangle_i \geq 1$, we conclude $\langle d \rangle_i = 1$, $\mathrm{sgn}_i(u) = 1$, and $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w) = 0$. These are exactly the hypotheses of Corollary 5.4 (note $\mathrm{sgn}_i(v) = 0$), so

$$c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z) = c_{us_i,v}^{ws_i,d-\delta_i}(y;z).$$

Moreover $\langle d \rangle_i = 2d_i - d_{i-1} - d_{i+1} = 1$ with $d_{i\pm1} \geq 0$ forces $d_i \geq 1$, so $d - \delta_i \in Q^\vee$ with $0 \leq d - \delta_i \leq d$ and $|d - \delta_i| < |d|$. Replacing $(u, w, d)$ by $(us_i, v \text{ fixed}, ws_i, d - \delta_i)$ and iterating, the quantity $|d|$ strictly decreases at each step, so the process terminates in a triple $(u', w', d')$ with $\langle d' \rangle_i \leq 0$ for all $i \neq k$.

Finally, for any finitely supported $d' \in Q^\vee$ the values $\langle d' \rangle_i = 2d'_i - d'_{i-1} - d'_{i+1}$ telescope to $\sum_i \langle d' \rangle_i = 0$. Hence $\langle d' \rangle_k = -\sum_{i \neq k} \langle d' \rangle_i \geq 0$, with equality if and only if $\langle d' \rangle_i = 0$ for all $i$, i.e. $d' = 0$. Thus $d' \neq 0$ implies $\langle d' \rangle_k > 0$. □

## 6. Proof of the Pieri formula

Throughout this section permutations act on positions: $(vt_{ab})(a) = v(b)$, $(vt_{ab})(b) = v(a)$, and $(vt_{ab})(r) = v(r)$ otherwise. A cycle is written $(a_p, \ldots, a_1, b)$ with the meaning $a_p \mapsto a_{p-1} \mapsto \cdots \mapsto a_1 \mapsto b \mapsto a_p$; when $b = \max\{a_1, \ldots, a_p, b\}$ we call $b$ the *top* of the cycle and refer to

$$(a_p, \ldots, a_1, b) = t_{a_1 b}\, t_{a_2 b} \cdots t_{a_p b} \tag{6.1}$$

as its *pivot factorization*. (Indeed, the right-hand side sends $a_p \mapsto b \mapsto a_{p-1}$, $b \mapsto a_p$ and $a_1 \mapsto b$.)

### 6.1. The single-variable Monk formula.

**Lemma 6.1.** *Let $u \in S_\infty$ and let $i, j \geq 1$. Then*

$$(x_i - z_j)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y) = (y_{u(i)} - z_j)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y) + \sum_{\substack{p \neq i \\ \ell(ut_{ip}) = \ell(u)+1}} \mathrm{sign}(p-i)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{ut_{ip}}(x;y)$$

$$+ \sum_{\substack{p \neq i \\ \ell(ut_{ip}) = \ell(u) - 2|p-i|+1}} \mathrm{sign}(p-i) q_{ip}\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{ut_{ip}}(x;y)$$

*where $q_{ip}$ stands for $q_{\min(i,p)\max(i,p)}$.*

*Proof.* The quantum double Schubert polynomials represent the Schubert classes in the torus-equivariant quantum cohomology of the flag manifold [10], so they satisfy the equivariant quantum Chevalley formula of Mihalcea [13, Theorem 1]. In type $A$, with $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_m}(x;y) = \sum_{a \leq m}(x_a - y_a)$, that formula reads

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_m}(x;y)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y) = \sum_{a \leq m} (y_{u(a)} - y_a)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y) + \sum_{\substack{a \leq m < b \\ \ell(ut_{ab}) = \ell(u)+1}} \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{ut_{ab}}(x;y) + \sum_{\substack{a \leq m < b \\ \ell(ut_{ab}) = \ell(u) - 2(b-a)+1}} q_{ab}\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{ut_{ab}}(x;y),$$

the diagonal coefficient being the localization of $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_m}(x;y)$ at $u$, and the two sums ranging over the classical and quantum covers of $u$ in the quantum Bruhat graph (for $\alpha = e_a - e_b$ one has $\langle \omega_m, \alpha^\vee \rangle = 1$ exactly when $a \leq m < b$, and $\langle 2\rho, \alpha^\vee \rangle = 2(b-a)$). By stability we may work in $S_n$ for $n$ large. Now

$$x_i - z_j = \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_i}(x;y) - \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_{i-1}}(x;y) + y_i - z_j,$$

with the term $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_{i-1}}$ omitted when $i = 1$. Subtracting the two Chevalley formulas, the diagonal coefficients combine to $(y_{u(i)} - y_i) + (y_i - z_j) = y_{u(i)} - z_j$, and the reflections $t_{ab}$ with $a < i < b$ occur in both sums with the same coefficient and cancel. What remains are the reflections $t_{ib}$ with $b > i$ (from $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_i}$, with sign $+1$) and $t_{ai}$ with $a < i$ (from $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_{i-1}}$, with sign $-1$), each carrying the factor 1 or $q_{ab}$ according to whether the cover is classical or quantum. This is the asserted formula. □

6.2. **Covers and tight cycles.** The following classical count is the only fact about lengths that we shall use.

**Lemma 6.2.** *Let $v \in S_\infty$ and $a < b$. If $v(a) < v(b)$ then*

$$\ell(vt_{ab}) = \ell(v) + 1 + 2\,\#\{r \mid a < r < b,\ v(a) < v(r) < v(b)\},$$

*and if $v(a) > v(b)$ then*

$$\ell(vt_{ab}) = \ell(v) - 1 - 2\,\#\{r \mid a < r < b,\ v(b) < v(r) < v(a)\}.$$

*In particular $\ell(vt_{ab}) \geq \ell(v) + 1$ if $v(a) < v(b)$, and $\ell(vt_{ab}) \geq \ell(v) - (2(b-a) - 1)$ always.*

*Proof.* Passing from $v$ to $vt_{ab}$ changes the inversion status of the pair of positions $(a, b)$, and of the pairs $(a, r)$, $(r, b)$ with $a < r < b$ exactly when $v(r)$ lies strictly between $v(a)$ and $v(b)$ (in which case both pairs change); all other pairs are unaffected. □

**Definition 6.3** (Covers, $\lhd$, $\kappa$)**.** For $v \in S_\infty$ and $a < b$ we write $v \lhd vt_{ab}$, and say that $t_{ab}$ is a *cover* of $v$, if either $\ell(vt_{ab}) = \ell(v) + 1$ (a *classical* cover) or $\ell(vt_{ab}) = \ell(v) - 2(b-a) + 1$ (a *quantum* cover). We set $\kappa(v, t_{ab}) = 1$ in the first case and $\kappa(v, t_{ab}) = q_{ab}$ in the second. By Lemma 6.2, $t_{ab}$ is a classical cover of $v$ if and only if $v(a) < v(b)$ and no $r$ with $a < r < b$ satisfies $v(a) < v(r) < v(b)$, and a quantum cover if and only if $v(a) > v(b)$ and every $r$ with $a < r < b$ satisfies $v(b) < v(r) < v(a)$. These are the covers of the quantum Bruhat graph, and condition (4) of Definition 3.1 says precisely that each step of a witnessing sequence is a cover (Remark 2.2).

It is convenient to separate the two values being exchanged from the values lying between them. For distinct numbers $\alpha \neq \beta$ and a finite set $J$ of numbers not containing $\alpha, \beta$, say that the pair $(\alpha, \beta)$ is *$J$-admissible* if either $\alpha < \beta$ and $J \cap (\alpha, \beta) = \emptyset$, or $\alpha > \beta$ and $J \subseteq (\beta, \alpha)$. Thus $t_{ab}$ is a cover of $v$ if and only if $(v(a), v(b))$ is $J$-admissible for $J = \{v(r) \mid a < r < b\}$; the cover is classical when $\alpha < \beta$ and quantum when $\alpha > \beta$.

**Lemma 6.4.** *Let $\alpha, \beta, \gamma$ be distinct numbers and $I, J, J'$ finite sets of numbers avoiding them.*

(i) *$(\alpha, \beta)$ is $(J \cup J')$-admissible if and only if it is $J$-admissible and $J'$-admissible. In particular $J' \subseteq J$ and $J$-admissibility imply $J'$-admissibility.*
(ii) *(Composition.) If $(\alpha_1, \alpha_0), (\alpha_2, \alpha_1), \ldots, (\alpha_n, \alpha_{n-1})$ are $I$-admissible then so is $(\alpha_n, \alpha_0)$.*
(iii) *(Triangle.) If $(\gamma, \beta)$ is $I$-admissible and $(\alpha, \gamma)$ is $(J \cup \{\beta\} \cup I)$-admissible, then $(\alpha, \beta)$ is $I$-admissible and $(\alpha, \gamma)$ is $J$-admissible.*

*Proof.* (i) is immediate from the definition. For (ii), if $I = \emptyset$ there is nothing to prove. Otherwise $I$ cuts the complement of $I$ into intervals ("blocks"), among them $V_- = (-\infty, \min I)$ and $V_+ = (\max I, \infty)$. An $I$-admissible pair $(\alpha', \alpha)$ with $\alpha' < \alpha$ has $\alpha, \alpha'$ in the same block, and one with $\alpha' > \alpha$ has $\alpha \in V_-$ and $\alpha' \in V_+$. Hence along the chain the values descend within a block, except for at most one jump from $V_-$ to $V_+$, after which they remain in $V_+$. Either $\alpha_n < \alpha_0$ lie in a common block, or $\alpha_0 \in V_-$ and $\alpha_n \in V_+$; in both cases $(\alpha_n, \alpha_0)$ is $I$-admissible. For (iii), the second assertion is (i). For the first there are four cases. If $\gamma < \beta$ and $\alpha < \gamma$: then $\alpha < \beta$ and $I \cap (\alpha, \beta) \subseteq (I \cap (\alpha, \gamma)) \cup (I \cap [\gamma, \beta)) = \emptyset$. If $\gamma < \beta$ and $\alpha > \gamma$: then $\beta \in (\gamma, \alpha)$ gives $\beta < \alpha$, and $I \subseteq (\gamma, \alpha)$ together with $I \cap (\gamma, \beta) = \emptyset$ gives $I \subseteq (\beta, \alpha)$. If $\gamma > \beta$ and $\alpha < \gamma$: then $\beta \notin (\alpha, \gamma)$ forces $\beta < \alpha$, and $I \subseteq (\beta, \gamma)$ with $I \cap (\alpha, \gamma) = \emptyset$ gives $I \subseteq (\beta, \alpha)$. The case $\gamma > \beta$, $\alpha > \gamma$ cannot occur, since it would require $\beta \in (\gamma, \alpha)$. □

**Definition 6.5** (Descents of a cycle, $\mathrm{desc}_u(c)$)**.** Let $c$ be a cycle and suppose $u \in S_\infty$. Write $c$ as

$$(a_1, \ldots, a_n)$$

where $a_n > a_i$ for all $i < n$ (this is a unique way to express the cycle since the $a_j$ are distinct). Then for any $i$ with $1 \leq i < n$ we say that $a_i$ is a *descent* of $c$ with respect to $u$ if $u(a_i) > u(a_{i+1})$. We denote the set of all descents of $c$ with respect to $u$ by $\mathrm{desc}_u(c)$.

In the notation $c = (a_p, \ldots, a_1, b)$ of (6.1), with $a_0 := b$, we have $a_j \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c)$ if and only if $u(a_j) > u(a_{j-1})$; the top $b$ is never a descent.

**Definition 6.6** ($L_u(\sigma)$, $\mathbf{q}_u(\sigma)$, $m$-shaped, $u$-tight)**.** Let $u, \sigma \in S_\infty$ and let $c_1, \dots, c_n$ be the nontrivial cycles of $\sigma$, with $c_i = (a_{i,p_i}, \dots, a_{i,1}, b_i)$ and $b_i = \max c_i$. Put

$$L_u(\sigma) = \sum_{i=1}^{n} \Big( p_i - 2 \sum_{a \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i)} (b_i - a) \Big), \qquad \mathbf{q}_u(\sigma) = \prod_{i=1}^{n} \prod_{a \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i)} q_{ab_i}.$$

Both depend only on the restriction of $u$ to $\mathrm{supp}(\sigma)$, and $\deg \mathbf{q}_u(\sigma) = \sum_i p_i - L_u(\sigma)$. We say that $\sigma$ is *$m$-shaped* if every nontrivial cycle of $\sigma$ contains exactly one element greater than $m$, and that $\sigma$ is *$u$-tight* if

$$\ell(u\sigma) - \ell(u) = L_u(\sigma).$$

A *pivot chain* of $\sigma$ is a sequence $t_1, \dots, t_N$ ($N = \sum_i p_i$) of transpositions obtained by interleaving the pivot factorizations (6.1) of $c_1, \dots, c_n$ in any manner that preserves the order of the factors within each cycle; since the cycles are disjoint, $t_1 \cdots t_N = \sigma$.

**Lemma 6.7** (Tightness)**.** *Let $u, \sigma \in S_\infty$, let $t_1, \dots, t_N$ be a pivot chain of $\sigma$, and put $u_0 = u$, $u_j = u_{j-1} t_j$.*

(i) *If $t_j = t_{a_{i,l} b_i}$ then $u_{j-1}(a_{i,l}) = u(a_{i,l})$ and $u_{j-1}(b_i) = u(a_{i,l-1})$ (with $a_{i,0} = b_i$). Thus the $j$-th step exchanges the values $u(a_{i,l})$ and $u(a_{i,l-1})$, and $a_{i,l} \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i)$ exactly when the larger of the two sits at the larger position $b_i$ before the step.*

(ii) *$\ell(u\sigma) - \ell(u) \geq L_u(\sigma)$.*

(iii) *$\sigma$ is $u$-tight if and only if $u_{j-1} \lhd u_j$ for every $j$. In that case the $j$-th step is a classical cover if $a_{i,l} \notin \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i)$ and a quantum cover if $a_{i,l} \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i)$, and $\prod_j \kappa(u_{j-1}, t_j) = \mathbf{q}_u(\sigma)$.*

(iv) *If $\sigma = \rho\tau$ where $\rho$ and $\tau$ are the products of two complementary sets of cycles of $\sigma$, then $\sigma$ is $u$-tight if and only if $\rho$ is $u$-tight and $\tau$ is $u\rho$-tight. Moreover $L_u(\tau) = L_{u\rho}(\tau)$ and $\mathbf{q}_u(\tau) = \mathbf{q}_{u\rho}(\tau)$.*

(v) *If $\sigma$ is $u$-tight then so is $t_1 \cdots t_j$ for every $j$, and $u_j$ is obtained from $u$ by a sequence of covers.*

*Proof.* (i) The position $a_{i,l}$ is moved only by the factor $t_{a_{i,l} b_i}$, so before that factor is applied it carries $u(a_{i,l})$; the position $b_i$ is moved only by the factors of $c_i$, and after $t_{a_{i,l-1} b_i}$ it carries $u(a_{i,l-1})$ (and $u(b_i)$ before any factor of $c_i$). For (ii) and (iii), by (i) and Lemma 6.2 the $j$-th step increases the length by at least 1 if $a_{i,l} \notin \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i)$ and by at least $-(2(b_i - a_{i,l}) - 1)$ if $a_{i,l} \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i)$; in both cases equality holds exactly when $t_j$ is a cover of $u_{j-1}$, classical in the first case and quantum in the second (a step with $u_{j-1}(a_{i,l}) < u_{j-1}(b_i)$ increases the length and so cannot be a quantum cover, and symmetrically). Summing over $j$ gives (ii), and shows that equality in (ii) holds exactly when every step is a cover; the product of the $\kappa$'s is then the product of $q_{a_{i,l} b_i}$ over the descents, which is $\mathbf{q}_u(\sigma)$. For (iv), $\ell(u\rho\tau) - \ell(u) = (\ell(u\rho) - \ell(u)) + (\ell(u\rho\tau) - \ell(u\rho)) \geq L_u(\rho) + L_{u\rho}(\tau) = L_u(\rho) + L_u(\tau) = L_u(\sigma)$, where $L_{u\rho}(\tau) = L_u(\tau)$ because $u\rho$ and $u$ agree on $\mathrm{supp}(\tau)$; equality holds if and only if both inequalities are equalities. (v) The partial product $t_1 \cdots t_j$ is again a product of disjoint cycles of the form $(a_{i,l}, \dots, a_{i,1}, b_i)$ (a cycle of $\sigma$ truncated after its first $l$ factors), and $t_1, \dots, t_j$ is a pivot chain of it, all of whose steps are covers by (iii). □

With this language the cycle description of $\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ becomes a statement in which the chain disappears entirely.

**Lemma 6.8.** *Suppose $u, w \in S_\infty$ and let $k \geq 0$ be an integer, and put $\pi = u^{-1} w$. Then $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ if and only if $\pi$ is $k$-shaped and $u$-tight. In that case the pivot chain of $\pi$ in which the cycles are taken in order of decreasing tops is a sequence $t_{a_1 b_1}, \dots, t_{a_p b_p}$ as in Definition 3.1, every pivot chain of $\pi$ is a chain of covers, and*

$$q_k(u, w) = \mathbf{q}_u(\pi).$$

*In particular $q_k(u, w)$ does not depend on the witnessing sequence, and $\ell(u, w) + \deg q_k(u, w)$ equals the sum of the lengths of the cycles of $\pi$, each diminished by one.*

*Proof.* Suppose first that $t_{a_1 b_1}, \dots, t_{a_p b_p}$ satisfy conditions (1)–(5) of Definition 3.1. The $b_i$ are weakly decreasing, so the factors sharing a common value $b$ of $b_i$ are consecutive, and by (6.1) their product $t_{a_i b} \cdots t_{a_{i+r} b}$ is the cycle $(a_{i+r}, \dots, a_i, b)$, whose top is $b$ because $a_l \leq k < b$. Cycles belonging to distinct values of $b$ are disjoint, since the $a_i$ are pairwise distinct and no $a_i$ equals any $b_j$. Hence $\pi$ is the product of these cycles, each of which contains exactly one element greater than $k$, namely its top: $\pi$ is $k$-shaped. The given sequence is a pivot chain of $\pi$, and condition (4) says that each of its steps is a cover; so $\pi$ is $u$-tight by Lemma 6.7(iii), and the recursive definition of $q_k(u, w)$ assigns to each step exactly the factor $\kappa$, whence $q_k(u, w) = \mathbf{q}_u(\pi)$.

Conversely, suppose $\pi$ is $k$-shaped and $u$-tight. Order the nontrivial cycles of $\pi$ by decreasing tops and take the corresponding pivot chain. The top of each cycle is its unique element exceeding $k$, so condition (1) holds;

(2) holds because the cycles are disjoint and the $a$'s within a cycle are distinct; (3) holds by the chosen order; (4) holds by Lemma 6.7(iii); and (5) is $t_1 \cdots t_N = \pi$. The final assertion is $\deg \mathbf{q}_u(\pi) = \sum_i p_i - L_u(\pi)$. □

**Corollary 6.9** (Cycle formula for the quantum weight)**.** *Suppose $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, and write the nontrivial cycles in the decomposition of $u^{-1}w$ as $c_i = (a_{i,p_i}, \dots, a_{i,1}, b_i)$, as in Lemma 6.8. Then*

$$q_k(u,w) = \prod_i \prod_{a \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i)} q_{ab_i}.$$

*Equivalently, the exponent of $q_r$ in $q_k(u,w)$ is*

$$\#\{(i,a) : a \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i),\ a \le r < b_i\}.$$

*Moreover, $q_k(u,w)$ is multiplicative over the cycles of $u^{-1}w$, and the factor attached to a cycle depends only on the values of $u$ on that cycle.*

*Proof.* This is $q_k(u,w) = \mathbf{q}_u(\pi)$ together with $q_{ab} = q_a \cdots q_{b-1}$. □

We next show that a tight cycle is very constrained: the values of $u$ along it, read cyclically, decrease except at exactly one place. For a cycle $c = (a_p, \dots, a_1, b)$ with top $b$ and a permutation $u$ we write

$$\beta_0 = u(b), \qquad \beta_j = u(a_j) \quad (1 \le j \le p),$$

so that $a_j \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c)$ if and only if $\beta_j > \beta_{j-1}$, and we put $u_j = u\, t_{a_1 b} \cdots t_{a_j b}$. By Lemma 6.7(i), the $j$-th step of the pivot chain exchanges $\beta_j$ (at $a_j$) with $\beta_{j-1}$ (at $b$); moreover $u_m(a_l) = \beta_{l-1}$ for $l \le m$ and $u_m(a_l) = \beta_l$ for $l > m$. If $c$ is $u$-tight, Definition 6.3 gives, for every $j$ and every position $r$ with $a_j < r < b$:

$$\text{if } \beta_j < \beta_{j-1} \text{ (classical step): } u_{j-1}(r) \notin (\beta_j, \beta_{j-1}); \tag{6.2}$$

$$\text{if } \beta_j > \beta_{j-1} \text{ (quantum step): } u_{j-1}(r) \in (\beta_{j-1}, \beta_j). \tag{6.3}$$

**Lemma 6.10.** *Let $c = (a_p, \dots, a_1, b)$ be a cycle with top $b$ which is $u$-tight. Then $\mathrm{desc}_u(c)$ has at most one element. In particular this applies to every cycle of $u^{-1}w$ whenever $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$.*

*Proof.* Suppose $i < j$ are two descents (quantum steps) with no descent strictly between them, so that $\beta_i > \beta_{i-1}$, $\beta_j > \beta_{j-1}$ and $\beta_i > \beta_{i+1} > \cdots > \beta_{j-1}$.

If $a_j > a_i$, then (6.3) for the step $i$ and $r = a_j$ gives $\beta_j = u_{i-1}(a_j) \in (\beta_{i-1}, \beta_i)$, so $\beta_{j-1} < \beta_j < \beta_i$. Hence $j \ge i+2$, and there is $m$ with $i < m < j$ and $\beta_m < \beta_j < \beta_{m-1}$. The step $m$ is classical. If $a_j > a_m$, then (6.2) for the step $m$ and $r = a_j$ is violated by $u_{m-1}(a_j) = \beta_j$. So $a_m > a_j$, and then (6.3) for the step $j$ and $r = a_m$ requires $u_{j-1}(a_m) = \beta_{m-1} \in (\beta_{j-1}, \beta_j)$, contradicting $\beta_{m-1} > \beta_j$.

If $a_j < a_i$, then (6.3) for the step $j$ and $r = a_i$ gives $u_{j-1}(a_i) = \beta_{i-1} \in (\beta_{j-1}, \beta_j)$, so $\beta_{j-1} < \beta_{i-1} < \beta_i$. Hence again $j \ge i+2$ and there is $m$ with $i < m < j$ and $\beta_m < \beta_{i-1} < \beta_{m-1}$. If $a_i > a_m$, (6.2) for the step $m$ and $r = a_i$ is violated by $u_{m-1}(a_i) = \beta_{i-1}$. So $a_m > a_i$, and (6.3) for the step $i$ and $r = a_m$ requires $u_{i-1}(a_m) = \beta_m \in (\beta_{i-1}, \beta_i)$, contradicting $\beta_m < \beta_{i-1}$. □

**Definition 6.11** (Redefinition of $\mathrm{desc}_u(c)$)**.** If $c$ is a tight cycle, we redefine $\mathrm{desc}_u(c)$ to be the unique element of the previously defined set $\mathrm{desc}_u(c)$ if it exists, or otherwise 0.

**Lemma 6.12.** *Let $c = (a_p, \dots, a_1, b)$ be a cycle with top $b$ which is $u$-tight, and suppose $\mathrm{desc}_u(c) = a_q$ with $q \ge 1$. Then*

$$\beta_q > \beta_{q+1} > \cdots > \beta_p > \beta_0 > \beta_1 > \cdots > \beta_{q-1}.$$

*In particular $u(a_j) > u(b)$ for all $j \ge q$.*

*Proof.* All steps other than the $q$-th are classical, which gives the two decreasing runs; it remains to prove $\beta_l > \beta_0$ for $l \ge q$.

First let $l = q$. For $l' < q$ with $a_{l'} < a_q$, (6.2) for the step $l'$ and $r = a_q$ gives $\beta_q = u_{l'-1}(a_q) \notin (\beta_{l'}, \beta_{l'-1})$. If some $l' < q$ has $a_{l'} > a_q$, let $l^*$ be the least such; then (6.3) for the step $q$ and $r = a_{l^*}$ gives $u_{q-1}(a_{l^*}) = \beta_{l^*-1} \in (\beta_{q-1}, \beta_q)$, so $\beta_q > \beta_{l^*-1}$, and descending induction on $l' < l^*$ using $\beta_q \notin (\beta_{l'}, \beta_{l'-1})$ yields $\beta_q > \beta_{l'-1}$ for all $l' \le l^*$, in particular $\beta_q > \beta_0$. If no such $l'$ exists, the same induction starting from $\beta_q > \beta_{q-1}$ gives $\beta_q > \beta_0$.

Now let $l > q$ and assume $\beta_{l-1} > \beta_0$ (and $\beta_l < \beta_{l-1}$). Suppose, for a contradiction, that $\beta_l < \beta_0$. We claim that $a_{l'} < a_l$ and $\beta_l < \beta_{l'}$ for $1 \le l' \le q-1$. Indeed, assume $\beta_l < \beta_{l'-1}$ (true for $l' = 1$). If $a_{l'} > a_l$, then (6.2)

for the step $l$ and $r = a_{l'}$ requires $u_{l-1}(a_{l'}) = \beta_{l'-1} \notin (\beta_l, \beta_{l-1})$, which is false as $\beta_l < \beta_{l'-1} \le \beta_0 < \beta_{l-1}$. So $a_{l'} < a_l$, and (6.2) for the step $l'$ and $r = a_l$ gives $\beta_l \notin (\beta_{l'}, \beta_{l'-1})$, whence $\beta_l < \beta_{l'}$. The claim yields $\beta_l < \beta_{q-1}$. Finally consider the quantum step $q$: if $a_q < a_l$, (6.3) with $r = a_l$ requires $\beta_l \in (\beta_{q-1}, \beta_q)$, contradicting $\beta_l < \beta_{q-1}$; if $a_q > a_l$, (6.2) for the step $l$ with $r = a_q$ requires $u_{l-1}(a_q) = \beta_{q-1} \notin (\beta_l, \beta_{l-1})$, contradicting $\beta_l < \beta_{q-1} < \beta_0 < \beta_{l-1}$. Hence $\beta_l > \beta_0$, and the induction is complete. □

**Corollary 6.13** (Cyclic monotonicity)**.** *Let $c = (a_p, \dots, a_1, b)$ be a $u$-tight cycle with top $b$. Then the cyclic sequence $(\beta_0, \beta_1, \dots, \beta_p)$ has exactly one cyclic ascent: either $\beta_0 > \beta_1 > \cdots > \beta_p$ (and $\mathrm{desc}_u(c) = 0$), or $\mathrm{desc}_u(c) = a_q$ with $q \ge 1$ and $\beta_q > \cdots > \beta_p > \beta_0 > \cdots > \beta_{q-1}$. Consequently*

$$L_u(c) = \begin{cases} p & \text{if the ascent is at the wrap } (\beta_p, \beta_0), \\ p - 2(b - a_q) & \text{if the ascent is } (\beta_{q-1}, \beta_q), \end{cases} \qquad \mathbf{q}_u(c) = \begin{cases} 1, \\ q_{a_q b}. \end{cases}$$

We shall repeatedly use the following elementary observation about such sequences. Call a cyclic sequence of distinct numbers *unimodal* if it has exactly one cyclic ascent, i.e. if it is a cyclic rotation of a decreasing sequence. Every cyclically consecutive block of a unimodal sequence is unimodal, and so is any subsequence. If $\Gamma$ is unimodal and $\eta \notin \Gamma$, there is exactly one *gap* of $\Gamma$ (a pair of cyclically consecutive entries) into which $\eta$ can be inserted so that the result is again unimodal, namely: the descent gap $(\gamma, \gamma')$ with $\gamma > \eta > \gamma'$ if $\min\Gamma < \eta < \max\Gamma$, and the ascent gap $(\min\Gamma, \max\Gamma)$ if $\eta < \min\Gamma$ or $\eta > \max\Gamma$. We call it the *insertion gap* of $\eta$ in $\Gamma$.

6.3. **The position $k$.** We organize the inductive step of Theorem 3.4 around the position $k$. The following lemma records two facts about the interaction of $\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ and $\overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow}$ at position $k$.

**Lemma 6.14.** *Suppose $u, w \in S_\infty$ and let $k > 1$ be an integer.*

(i) *If $u(k) = w(k)$, then $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ if and only if $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, and in that case $q_k(u, w) = q_{k-1}(u, w)$ and $\mathrm{fix}_k(u, w) = \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u, w) \cup \{u(k)\}$.*

(ii) *If $u(k) \ne w(k)$ and $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, then $u \overset{k-1}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$.*

*Proof.* Let $\pi = u^{-1}w$. If $u(k) = w(k)$ then $k$ is a fixed point of $\pi$, so no nontrivial cycle of $\pi$ contains $k$, and such a cycle has exactly one element greater than $k$ if and only if it has exactly one element greater than $k-1$. Thus $\pi$ is $k$-shaped if and only if it is $(k-1)$-shaped, while tightness and $\mathbf{q}_u(\pi)$ do not involve $k$ at all; (i) follows from Lemma 6.8. For (ii), the cycle of $\pi$ containing $k$ is nontrivial and, $\pi$ being $k$-shaped, contains an element greater than $k$; so it contains two elements greater than $k-1$ and $\pi$ is not $(k-1)$-shaped. □

For the rest of this section we fix $u, w \in S_\infty$ and $k > 1$, and write

$$\pi = u^{-1}w, \qquad C = \text{the cycle of } \pi \text{ containing } k \ (C = \{k\} \text{ if } \pi(k) = k), \qquad B = \max C.$$

For $m \ge 0$ we set $c_m(u, w) = q_m(u, w)\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_m(u,w)}; z)$ if $u \overset{m}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ and $c_m(u, w) = 0$ otherwise. The *Monk summands* at $w$ are indexed by the reflections $t \in \{t_{ak} \mid a < k\} \cup \{t_{kb} \mid b > k\}$: writing $v = wt$ and $\sigma = u^{-1}v = \pi t$, the summand of $t$ is

$$\mathrm{sign}(t)\, \kappa(v, t)\, c_{k-1}(u, v), \qquad \mathrm{sign}(t_{ak}) = -1,\ \mathrm{sign}(t_{kb}) = +1,$$

where the summand is understood to be 0 unless $v \lhd w$. (These are precisely the terms of (6.8) and (6.9) below.) The summand of $t$ is therefore nonzero if and only if $v \lhd w$ and $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} v$, that is, $\sigma$ is $(k-1)$-shaped and $u$-tight.

**Lemma 6.15** (Classification of the Monk neighbors)**.** *Suppose the Monk summand of $t$ is nonzero, and let $P = \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u, w)$. Then every nontrivial cycle of $\pi$ not meeting $t$ has exactly one element greater than $k$, and exactly one of the following holds.*

(U) *$t = t_{kB}$ with $B > k$; $C$ contains exactly two elements greater than $k-1$, namely $k$ and $B$; and $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u, v) = P$. Writing $C = (a_p, \dots, a_1, B)$ with $a_j = k$, the cycles of $\sigma$ are those of $\pi$ other than $C$ together with*

$$C' = (a_{j-1}, \dots, a_1, B) \quad \text{and} \quad C'' = (a_p, \dots, a_{j+1}, k).$$

(S) $t = t_{ak}$ *with* $a \in C$ *and* $B > k$*;* $C$ *contains exactly two elements greater than* $k-1$*, namely* $k$ *and* $B$*; in the notation of (U),* $a = a_m$ *for some* $m > j$*;* $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v) = P$*; and the cycles of* $\sigma$ *are those of* $\pi$ *other than* $C$ *together with*

$$C'_m = (a_p, \ldots, a_{m+1}, a_m, a_{j-1}, \ldots, a_1, B) \quad \text{and} \quad C''_m = (a_{m-1}, \ldots, a_{j+1}, k).$$

(P) $t = t_{ak}$ *with* $a \in C$ *and* $B = k$*; writing* $C = (a_p, \ldots, a_1, k)$ *we have* $a = a_p = \pi(k) = u^{-1}(w(k))$*;* $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v) = P \sqcup \{w(k)\}$*; and the cycles of* $\sigma$ *are those of* $\pi$ *other than* $C$ *together with* $C_- = (a_{p-1}, \ldots, a_1, k)$ *(trivial if* $p = 1$*).*

(M) $t = t_{ak}$ *with* $a \notin C$*; then* $B = k$*, the cycle* $D$ *of* $\pi$ *containing* $a$ *(possibly* $D = \{a\}$*) satisfies* $D \subseteq [1, k-1]$*, and* $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v) = P \setminus \{u(a)\}$*, which equals* $P$ *unless* $D = \{a\}$*. The cycles of* $\sigma$ *are those of* $\pi$ *other than* $C$ *and* $D$ *together with the single cycle* $E$ *with* $\mathrm{supp}(E) = \mathrm{supp}(C) \cup \mathrm{supp}(D)$ *obtained by setting* $E(a) = \pi(k)$*,* $E(k) = \pi(a)$ *and* $E = \pi$ *elsewhere.*

*Proof.* A cycle of $\pi$ disjoint from $\mathrm{supp}(t)$ is a cycle of $\sigma$, hence has exactly one element greater than $k-1$, and since it does not contain $k$ this element is greater than $k$. Recall that right multiplication of a permutation by a transposition $t_{xy}$ merges the cycles of $x$ and $y$ if they are distinct, and otherwise splits their common cycle $(x_1, \ldots, x_n)$, $x = x_s$, $y = x_t$, $s < t$, into $(x_t, x_{s+1}, \ldots, x_{t-1})$ and $(x_s, x_{t+1}, \ldots, x_n, x_1, \ldots, x_{s-1})$.

Let $t = t_{kb}$. If $b \notin C$, the cycle of $\sigma$ through $k$ contains $k$ and $b > k$, which is forbidden. So $b \in C$ and $t$ splits $C$ into a cycle through $k$ and a cycle through $b$; each must contain exactly one element greater than $k-1$, so $C \cap (k-1, \infty) = \{k, b\}$ and $b = B$. The explicit form of the two cycles is the splitting formula applied to $(x_1, \ldots, x_{p+1}) = (a_p, \ldots, a_1, B)$ with $x_s = k$, $x_t = B$. Since $v$ agrees with $w$ at all positions less than $k$, $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v) = P$. This is (U).

Let $t = t_{ak}$ with $a \in C$, so $t$ splits $C$. If $B > k$, the piece not containing $k$ must contain exactly one element greater than $k-1$, which forces $C \cap (k-1, \infty) = \{k, B\}$ and that piece to contain $B$. With $(x_1, \ldots, x_{p+1}) = (a_p, \ldots, a_1, B)$, $k = a_j$ and $a = a_m$: if $m < j$ the piece through $a_m$ is $(a_m, a_{j-1}, \ldots, a_{m+1})$, which has no element greater than $k-1$ unless it is trivial ($m = j-1$), in which case the other piece $(k, a_{m-1}, \ldots, a_1, B, a_p, \ldots, a_{j+1})$ contains both $k$ and $B$; both are forbidden. So $m > j$, and the splitting formula gives $C'_m$ and $C''_m$. Here $v(a_m) = w(k) = u(a_{j-1}) \neq u(a_m)$ and $w(a_m) \neq u(a_m)$, so $a_m$ is a fixed position neither for $v$ nor for $w$, and $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v) = P$. This is (S). If $B = k$, the piece not containing $k$ has no element greater than $k-1$ and must be trivial, i.e. $\sigma(a) = a$, i.e. $\pi(k) = a$; in the notation $C = (a_p, \ldots, a_1, k)$ this is $a = a_p$, and $u(a_p) = u(\pi(k)) = w(k)$. Then $\sigma$ has the cycle $C_-$, and $v(a_p) = w(k) = u(a_p)$ makes $a_p$ a new fixed position with value $w(k) \notin P$. This is (P).

Finally let $t = t_{ak}$ with $a \notin C$, so $t$ merges $C$ with the cycle $D$ of $a$ into a cycle $E$ containing $k$; $E$ may contain no further element greater than $k-1$, so $C \subseteq [1, k]$, i.e. $B = k$, and $D \subseteq [1, k-1]$. We have $v(a) = w(k) = u(\pi(k)) \neq u(a)$ because $\pi(k) \in C \not\ni a$, so $a$ is not a fixed position of $v$; it is one of $w$ exactly when $D = \{a\}$. All other positions less than $k$ agree. This is (M). □

*The case* $B > k$*: the up-neighbor and the split down-neighbors.*

**Lemma 6.16** (Up/down pairing)**.** *Let* $\psi \in S_\infty$*, let* $k < B$*, let* $z_1, \ldots, z_s$ *(*$s \geq 0$*) be distinct positions less than* $k$*, let* $X = (z_s, \ldots, z_1, k, B)$ *and* $w = \psi X$*. Consider the following sequences of transpositions, each with product* $X$*:*

$$\begin{aligned} F_{\mathrm{std}} &: \ t_{kB},\, t_{z_1 B},\, \ldots,\, t_{z_s B} && \text{(the pivot factorization of } X\text{)}, \\ F_{\mathrm{up}} &: \ t_{z_1 k},\, \ldots,\, t_{z_s k},\, t_{kB}, && \\ F_m &: \ t_{z_1 k},\, \ldots,\, t_{z_{m-1} k},\, t_{z_m B},\, \ldots,\, t_{z_s B},\, t_{z_m k} && (1 \leq m \leq s). \end{aligned}$$

*Call such a sequence a* cover path *(from* $\psi$*) if each of its steps is a cover of the permutation reached before it, and define its* weight *to be the product of the* $\kappa$*'s of its steps.*

(a) *If* $F_{\mathrm{std}}$ *is a cover path, then* $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ *is a cover path of the same weight, and no* $F_m$ *is a cover path.*

(b) *If* $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ *is a cover path but* $F_{\mathrm{std}}$ *is not, then exactly one* $F_m$ *is a cover path, and its weight equals that of* $F_{\mathrm{up}}$*.*

(c) *If some* $F_m$ *is a cover path, then so is* $F_{\mathrm{up}}$*.*

*Proof.* (The products are $X$: $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ is $(z_s, \ldots, z_1, k)\, t_{kB}$, and $F_m$ is $(z_{m-1}, \ldots, z_1, k)\, (z_s, \ldots, z_m, B)\, t_{z_m k}$; both send $k \mapsto B \mapsto z_s \mapsto \cdots \mapsto z_1 \mapsto k$.) If $s = 0$ then $F_{\mathrm{std}} = F_{\mathrm{up}}$ and there is nothing to prove, so let $s \geq 1$.

Put

$$\beta = \psi(B), \qquad \zeta_0 = \psi(k), \qquad \zeta_i = \psi(z_i)\ (1 \le i \le s), \qquad I = \{\psi(r) \mid k < r < B\}.$$

The positions strictly between $k$ and $B$ are never moved, so $I$ is the set of values found there at every stage of every path. Let $\phi_m = \psi t_{z_1 k} \cdots t_{z_{m-1} k}$ $(1 \le m \le s+1)$; thus $\phi_m(k) = \zeta_{m-1}$, $\phi_m(z_i) = \zeta_{i-1}$ for $i < m$, $\phi_m(z_i) = \zeta_i$ for $i \ge m$, $\phi_m(B) = \beta$, and $\phi_m$ agrees with $\psi$ elsewhere. Let $J_i = \{\phi_i(r) \mid z_i < r < k\}$. We introduce the predicates

$$\begin{aligned} U_i &: \ (\zeta_i, \zeta_{i-1}) \text{ is } J_i\text{-admissible} && (1 \le i \le s), \\ T_i &: \ (\zeta_i, \beta) \text{ is } I\text{-admissible} && (0 \le i \le s), \\ A_i &: \ (\zeta_i, \zeta_{i-1}) \text{ is } (J_i \cup \{\beta\} \cup I)\text{-admissible} && (1 \le i \le s). \end{aligned}$$

$U_i$ says that the $i$-th step of $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ (from $\phi_i$) is a cover, and $T_s$ that its last step is; so $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ is a cover path if and only if $U_1, \dots, U_s, T_s$ hold. For $1 \le m \le s+1$ let $\mathcal{S}_m$ be the statement that $t_{kB}, t_{z_m B}, \dots, t_{z_s B}$ is a cover path from $\phi_m$; thus $F_{\mathrm{std}}$ is a cover path if and only if $\mathcal{S}_1$, and $\mathcal{S}_{s+1} = T_s$. The first step of $\mathcal{S}_m$ exchanges $\zeta_{m-1}$ at $k$ with $\beta$ at $B$ across $I$; the step $t_{z_i B}$ $(i \ge m)$ exchanges $\zeta_i$ at $z_i$ with $\zeta_{i-1}$ at $B$ across the positions in $(z_i, k)$, which carry the same values as in $\phi_i$ (the positions $z_l$, $l < i$, carry $\zeta_{l-1}$ and the others their $\psi$-values), the position $k$, which carries $\beta$, and the positions in $(k, B)$. Hence

$$\mathcal{S}_m \iff T_{m-1} \wedge A_m \wedge \cdots \wedge A_s.$$

Let $\mathcal{D}_m$ $(1 \le m \le s)$ be the statement that $t_{z_m B}, \dots, t_{z_s B}, t_{z_m k}$ is a cover path from $\phi_m$; then $F_m$ is a cover path if and only if $U_1, \dots, U_{m-1}$ and $\mathcal{D}_m$ hold. The steps of $\mathcal{D}_m$ are: $D^{(m)}$, exchanging $\zeta_m$ at $z_m$ with $\beta$ at $B$ across $J_m \cup \{\zeta_{m-1}\} \cup I$ (the position $k$ now carries $\zeta_{m-1}$); for $i > m$, $D^{(i)}$, exchanging $\zeta_i$ with $\zeta_{i-1}$ across $J_i^* \cup I$, where $J_i^*$ consists of the values at the positions of $(z_i, k]$, so that $J_i^* = J_i \cup \{\beta\}$ if $z_m > z_i$ and $J_i^* = J_i \cup \{\zeta_{m-1}\}$ if $z_m < z_i$ (the position $z_m$ carries $\beta$ and $k$ carries $\zeta_{m-1}$); and $D^{\mathrm{last}}$, exchanging $\beta$ at $z_m$ with $\zeta_{m-1}$ at $k$ across $J^{**} = N_m \cup \{\zeta_{l-1} \mid l > m,\ z_l > z_m\}$, where $N_m$ denotes the set of values carried by the positions of $(z_m, k)$ other than $z_{m+1}, \dots, z_s$ (these values are the same in $\phi_m$ and at the end of $\mathcal{D}_m$), so that $J_m = N_m \cup \{\zeta_l \mid l > m,\ z_l > z_m\}$. For $i > m$ the set across which $D^{(i)}$ is taken contains $J_i$, and the sets of $D^{(m)}, \dots, D^{(s)}$ all contain $\zeta_{m-1}$, the value at $k$.

*Step 1: $\mathcal{S}_m \Rightarrow \mathcal{S}_{m+1}$, and $\mathcal{S}_m$ implies $U_m, \dots, U_s, T_s$.* By Lemma 6.4(iii) applied with $(\alpha, \gamma, \beta) = (\zeta_m, \zeta_{m-1}, \beta)$ and $J = J_m$, the conjunction $T_{m-1} \wedge A_m$ implies $T_m \wedge U_m$. The first claim follows, and the second by iterating it down to $\mathcal{S}_{s+1} = T_s$, using $A_i \Rightarrow U_i$ (Lemma 6.4(i)). In particular $\mathcal{S}_1$ implies that $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ is a cover path.

*Step 2: $\mathcal{D}_m$ implies $U_m, \dots, U_s, T_s$.* For $i > m$, $D^{(i)}$ gives $U_i$ by Lemma 6.4(i). By the same lemma, $D^{(m)}$ and $D^{(i)}$ $(i > m)$ give that $(\zeta_m, \beta)$ and $(\zeta_i, \zeta_{i-1})$ are $I$-admissible, so $(\zeta_s, \beta)$ is $I$-admissible by Lemma 6.4(ii): this is $T_s$. Likewise the pairs $(\zeta_m, \beta), (\zeta_{m+1}, \zeta_m), \dots, (\zeta_s, \zeta_{s-1})$ are $\{\zeta_{m-1}\}$-admissible, which as in the proof of Lemma 6.4(ii) means:

$$\begin{gathered} \text{the values } \beta, \zeta_m, \zeta_{m+1}, \dots, \zeta_s \text{ decrease on each side of } \zeta_{m-1}, \\ \text{with at most one jump from below } \zeta_{m-1} \text{ to above it.} \end{gathered} \tag{6.4}$$

For $U_m$, admissibility of $(\zeta_m, \beta)$ with respect to $\{\zeta_{m-1}\}$ leaves three possibilities: (1) $\zeta_{m-1} > \beta > \zeta_m$; (2) $\zeta_m > \zeta_{m-1} > \beta$; (3) $\beta > \zeta_m > \zeta_{m-1}$. We use $D^{(m)}$ restricted to $J_m$ and $D^{\mathrm{last}}$ restricted to $N_m$, and treat the remaining elements $\zeta_l$ $(l > m,\ z_l > z_m)$ of $J_m$ by (6.4). In case (1), $J_m \cap (\zeta_m, \beta) = \emptyset$ and $N_m \cap (\beta, \zeta_{m-1}) = \emptyset$, while by (6.4) each $\zeta_l$ $(l > m)$ is either less than $\zeta_m$ or greater than $\zeta_{m-1}$; hence $J_m \cap (\zeta_m, \zeta_{m-1}) = \emptyset$. In case (2), $J_m \subseteq (\beta, \zeta_m)$ and $N_m \cap (\beta, \zeta_{m-1}) = \emptyset$ give $N_m \subseteq (\zeta_{m-1}, \zeta_m)$, while by (6.4) the jump occurs at $(\beta, \zeta_m)$ and so $\zeta_{m-1} < \zeta_l < \zeta_m$ for $l > m$; hence $J_m \subseteq (\zeta_{m-1}, \zeta_m)$. In case (3), $J_m \cap (\zeta_m, \beta) = \emptyset$ and $N_m \subseteq (\zeta_{m-1}, \beta)$ give $N_m \subseteq (\zeta_{m-1}, \zeta_m)$, while by (6.4) all of $\beta, \zeta_m, \dots, \zeta_s$ lie above $\zeta_{m-1}$ and decrease, so again $\zeta_{m-1} < \zeta_l < \zeta_m$ for $l > m$; hence $J_m \subseteq (\zeta_{m-1}, \zeta_m)$. In each case this is $U_m$. Together with the prefix $U_1, \dots, U_{m-1}$ this proves (c).

For the remainder assume that $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ is a cover path. Then the cycle $(z_s, \dots, z_1, k)$ is $\psi$-tight, so by Corollary 6.13 the cyclic sequence $\Gamma = (\zeta_0, \zeta_1, \dots, \zeta_s)$ is unimodal; let $\delta \in \{0, \dots, s\}$ be the index of its ascent ($\zeta_\delta > \zeta_{\delta-1}$ if $\delta \ge 1$; $\delta = 0$ means the ascent is the wrap $(\zeta_s, \zeta_0)$), and let $g \in \{0, \dots, s\}$ be the insertion gap of $\beta$ in $\Gamma$, where gap $g \ge 1$ is the gap $(\zeta_{g-1}, \zeta_g)$ and gap 0 is the wrap. Explicitly: if $\min \Gamma < \beta < \max \Gamma$, then $g$ is determined by $\zeta_{g-1} > \beta > \zeta_g$ (indices modulo $s+1$); otherwise $g = \delta$.

*Step 3: $\mathcal{S}_m$ implies $m > g$.* $\mathcal{S}_m$ says that the cycle $(z_s, \dots, z_m, k, B)$ is $\phi_m$-tight, so by Corollary 6.13 the cyclic sequence $(\beta, \zeta_{m-1}, \dots, \zeta_s)$ is unimodal; that is, the wrap gap $(\zeta_s, \zeta_{m-1})$ of the block $\Gamma' = (\zeta_{m-1}, \dots, \zeta_s)$

is the insertion gap of $\beta$ in $\Gamma'$. Suppose $1 \le m \le g$. Then $\zeta_{g-1}, \zeta_g$ both lie in $\Gamma'$ and are consecutive there. If $\min\Gamma < \beta < \max\Gamma$ then $\zeta_{g-1} > \beta > \zeta_g$, so the insertion gap of $\beta$ in $\Gamma'$ is $(\zeta_{g-1}, \zeta_g)$, which is not the wrap gap of $\Gamma'$ since $g-1 \neq s$. If $\beta$ lies outside $[\min\Gamma, \max\Gamma]$ then $g = \delta$, so $\zeta_g = \max\Gamma$ and $\zeta_{g-1} = \min\Gamma$ lie in $\Gamma'$, whence $\beta$ lies outside the range of $\Gamma'$ and its insertion gap in $\Gamma'$ is the ascent gap $(\zeta_{g-1}, \zeta_g)$ of $\Gamma'$, again not the wrap gap. In both cases $\mathcal{S}_m$ fails.

*Step 4: $\mathcal{S}_{g+1}$ holds; hence $\mathcal{S}_m$ holds if and only if $m > g$.* We must verify $T_g$ and $A_i$ for $i > g$; by Lemma 6.4(i) we treat the sets $J_i$, $\{\beta\}$ and $I$ separately. Admissibility of $(\zeta_i, \zeta_{i-1})$ with respect to $J_i$ is $U_i$. With respect to $\{\beta\}$: if $i > g$ and $i \neq \delta$, the gap $(\zeta_{i-1}, \zeta_i)$ is a descent gap and $\beta \notin (\zeta_i, \zeta_{i-1})$, for otherwise it would be the insertion gap of $\beta$; if $i = \delta > g$, then $\beta \in (\min\Gamma, \max\Gamma) = (\zeta_{\delta-1}, \zeta_\delta)$, for otherwise $g = \delta$. With respect to $I$, and for $T_g$: the sequence $s_0 = \beta, s_1 = \zeta_g, \dots, s_n = \zeta_s$ is a consecutive block of the unimodal sequence obtained by inserting $\beta$ into $\Gamma$, hence unimodal, and $T_s$ says that $(s_n, s_0)$ is $I$-admissible. If $s_0 > s_1 > \cdots > s_n$, then $T_s$ is classical, $I \cap (s_n, s_0) = \emptyset$, and every pair $(s_i, s_{i-1})$ is $I$-admissible. Otherwise the linear ascent is at some $j \ge 1$, so $s_j > \cdots > s_n > s_0 > \cdots > s_{j-1}$; then $T_s$ is quantum, $I \subseteq (s_0, s_n)$, and the pairs $(s_i, s_{i-1})$ with $i < j$ lie below $s_0$, the pair $(s_j, s_{j-1})$ has $I \subseteq (s_0, s_n) \subseteq (s_{j-1}, s_j)$, and the pairs with $i > j$ lie above $s_n$; all are $I$-admissible. The pairs $(s_i, s_{i-1})$ are exactly $(\zeta_g, \beta)$ and $(\zeta_i, \zeta_{i-1})$, $i > g$. This proves $\mathcal{S}_{g+1}$, and the second assertion follows from Steps 1 and 3.

*Step 5: $\mathcal{D}_m$ implies $m = g$.* Restricting $D^{(m)}$ to $\{\zeta_{m-1}\}$ leaves the three cases (1)–(3) of Step 2. In case (1) the gap $(\zeta_{m-1}, \zeta_m)$ is a descent gap containing $\beta$, so $g = m$. In case (2) the gap is the ascent gap, $m = \delta$, and $\beta < \zeta_{m-1} = \min\Gamma$, so $g = \delta = m$. In case (3), $m = \delta$ and $\beta > \zeta_m = \max\Gamma$, so again $g = m$.

*Step 6: if $g \ge 1$ then $\mathcal{D}_g$ holds.* Write $a = z_g$. We are in one of the cases (1) $\zeta_{g-1} > \beta > \zeta_g$ ($g \neq \delta$), (2) $g = \delta$ and $\beta < \zeta_{g-1} = \min\Gamma$, (3) $g = \delta$ and $\beta > \zeta_g = \max\Gamma$. For $D^{(g)}$: admissibility of $(\zeta_g, \beta)$ with respect to $I$ is $T_g$ (Step 4); with respect to $\{\zeta_{g-1}\}$ it holds in each of the three cases by inspection; with respect to $J_g$ it follows from $U_g$: in case (1), $J_g \cap (\zeta_g, \zeta_{g-1}) = \emptyset$ gives $J_g \cap (\zeta_g, \beta) = \emptyset$; in case (2), $J_g \subseteq (\zeta_{g-1}, \zeta_g) \subseteq (\beta, \zeta_g)$; in case (3), $J_g \subseteq (\zeta_{g-1}, \zeta_g)$ is disjoint from $(\zeta_g, \beta)$. For $D^{(i)}$, $i > g$: if $z_g > z_i$ the required statement is $A_i$ (Step 4); if $z_g < z_i$ then $z_g \in (z_i, k)$, so $\zeta_{g-1} = \phi_i(z_g) \in J_i$ already, $J_i^* = J_i$, and the statement follows from $U_i$ and the $I$-admissibility established in Step 4. For $D^{\mathrm{last}}$, the pair $(\beta, \zeta_{g-1})$ must be admissible with respect to $N_g \subseteq J_g$ and to the values $\zeta_{l-1}$, $l > g$, $z_l > z_g$: in case (1) it is classical, and $(\beta, \zeta_{g-1}) \subseteq (\zeta_g, \zeta_{g-1})$ contains no element of $J_g$ (by $U_g$) and no $\zeta_l$ (as $\zeta_{g-1}, \zeta_g$ are consecutive in the decreasing order of $\Gamma$); in case (2) it is classical, and $(\beta, \zeta_{g-1})$ lies below $\min\Gamma$ and below $J_g \subseteq (\zeta_{g-1}, \zeta_g)$; in case (3) it is quantum, and $J_g \subseteq (\zeta_{g-1}, \zeta_g) \subseteq (\zeta_{g-1}, \beta)$ while every $\zeta_{l-1}$ with $l > g$ lies in $(\zeta_{g-1}, \zeta_g] \subseteq (\zeta_{g-1}, \beta)$.

*Step 7: weights.* Suppose $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ is a cover path and $g \ge 1$. The two paths $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ and $F_g$ share the prefix $t_{z_1 k}, \dots, t_{z_{g-1} k}$; after it, the quantum steps of $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ are $t_{z_\delta k}$ (if $\delta \ge g$) and $t_{kB}$ (if $\zeta_s > \beta$), while those of $F_g$ are $t_{z_g B}$ (if $\zeta_g > \beta$), $t_{z_\delta B}$ (if $\delta > g$) and $t_{z_g k}$ (if $\beta > \zeta_{g-1}$). In case (1) with $\delta > g$ we have $\zeta_s > \zeta_0 \ge \zeta_{g-1} > \beta$, and both weights are $q_{z_\delta k} q_{kB} = q_{z_\delta B}$; in case (1) with $\delta < g$ we have $\zeta_s < \zeta_g < \beta$ and both weights are 1; in case (2) both are $q_{z_g k} q_{kB} = q_{z_g B}$; in case (3) both are $q_{z_g k}$. If instead $g = 0$, so that $\mathcal{S}_1$ holds, the quantum steps of $F_{\mathrm{std}}$ are $t_{kB}$ (if $\zeta_0 > \beta$) and $t_{z_\delta B}$ (if $\delta \ge 1$); if $\zeta_s > \beta > \zeta_0$ (so $\delta \ge 1$) both $F_{\mathrm{std}}$ and $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ have weight $q_{z_\delta B}$; if $\beta < \min\Gamma$ (so $\delta = 0$) both have weight $q_{kB}$; and if $\beta > \max\Gamma$ both have weight 1.

*Conclusion.* (a): $\mathcal{S}_1$ gives $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ (Step 1) with the same weight (Step 7), and $g = 0$ (Step 3), so no $\mathcal{D}_m$ holds (Step 5). (b): if $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ is a cover path and $\mathcal{S}_1$ fails, then $g \ge 1$ (Step 4), $\mathcal{D}_g$ holds (Step 6) and no other $\mathcal{D}_m$ does (Step 5); as $U_1, \dots, U_{g-1}$ hold, $F_g$ is the unique $F_m$ which is a cover path, and its weight is that of $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ (Step 7). (c) is Step 2. □

**Lemma 6.17.** *Suppose $u, w \in S_\infty$ and let $k > 1$ be an integer. If $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ but $u \not\overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, then there is a unique $b > k$ such that $wt_{kb} \lhd w$ and $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} wt_{kb}$, namely $b = B$. Furthermore, in that case there does not exist an $a < k$ such that $wt_{ak} \lhd w$ and $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} wt_{ak}$, and*

$$\kappa(wt_{kB}, t_{kB})\, q_{k-1}(u, wt_{kB}) = q_k(u, w), \qquad \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u, wt_{kB}) = \mathrm{fix}_k(u, w).$$

*Proof.* By Lemma 6.8, $\pi$ is $k$-shaped and $u$-tight but not $(k-1)$-shaped, so $u(k) \neq w(k)$ and $B > k$ (Lemma 6.14). Write $C = (a_p, \dots, a_1, B)$ with $a_j = k$, let $\rho$ be the product of the other nontrivial cycles of $\pi$, let $C' = (a_{j-1}, \dots, a_1, B)$, and put $\psi = u\rho C'$ and $X = (a_p, \dots, a_{j+1}, k, B)$, so that $w = \psi X$ and $X$ has the form of Lemma 6.16 with $s = p - j$ and $z_i = a_{j+i}$. Take the pivot chain of $\pi$ consisting of the pivot factorization of $\rho$, then that of $C$; by Lemma 6.7(iii),(v) all its steps are covers, $\rho$ is $u$-tight, $C'$ is $u\rho$-tight (it is $C$ truncated after $j-1$ factors), and $F_{\mathrm{std}}$ is a cover path from $\psi$. By Lemma 6.16(a), $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ is a cover path of the same weight. Its first $s$ steps form the pivot factorization of $C'' = (a_p, \dots, a_{j+1}, k)$, so $\rho C' C'' = u^{-1} wt_{kB}$ is $u$-tight

by Lemma 6.7(iii),(iv); it is $(k-1)$-shaped, its cycles being those of $\rho$ (each with exactly one element greater than $k$), $C'$ (top $B$, other elements less than $k$) and $C''$ (top $k$, other elements less than $k$). Hence $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} wt_{kB}$, and the last step of $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ says $wt_{kB} \lhd w$. Uniqueness of $b$ is Lemma 6.15(U). The weights are $\mathbf{q}_u(\rho)\mathbf{q}_u(C')$ times the weights of $F_{\mathrm{std}}$, respectively $F_{\mathrm{up}}$, which agree; and $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u, wt_{kB}) = \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,w) = \mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)$ since $u(k) \neq w(k)$.

Suppose finally that $a < k$ satisfies $wt_{ak} \lhd w$ and $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} wt_{ak}$. By Lemma 6.15 we are in case (S): $a = a_m$ with $m > j$, and $\sigma = \rho C'_m C''_m$ is $u$-tight. Taking the pivot chain of $\sigma$ in the order: factors of $\rho$, the first $j-1$ factors of $C'_m$ (which are those of $C'$), the factors of $C''_m$, the remaining factors $t_{a_m B}, \dots, t_{a_p B}$ of $C'_m$, and appending the cover $t_{a_m k}$, we obtain that $F_{m-j}$ is a cover path from $\psi$, contradicting Lemma 6.16(a). □

*The case $B = k$: the peel and the merges.*

**Lemma 6.18** (Peel)**.** *Let $\omega \in S_\infty$ and let $C = (a_p, \dots, a_1, k)$ $(p \geq 1)$ be a cycle with top $k$; put $w = \omega C$, $C_- = (a_{p-1}, \dots, a_1, k)$ and $v = wt_{a_p k} = \omega C_-$. Then $C$ is $\omega$-tight if and only if $C_-$ is $\omega$-tight and $v \lhd w$, and in that case $\kappa(v, t_{a_p k})\, \mathbf{q}_\omega(C_-) = \mathbf{q}_\omega(C)$.*

*Proof.* The pivot factorization of $C$ is that of $C_-$ followed by $t_{a_p k}$, and $\omega C_- = v$. Apply Lemma 6.7(iii). □

**Lemma 6.19** (Merge)**.** *Let $\omega \in S_\infty$, $k > 1$, $\eta = \omega(k)$, and let $D$ be a cycle with* $\mathrm{supp}(D) \subseteq [1, k-1]$*, allowing $D$ to be trivial, $D = \{a\}$ with $a \leq k-1$. Put $w = \omega D$, so $w(k) = \eta$. For $a \in$* $\mathrm{supp}(D)$ *let $\tau_a = D t_{ak}$, the cycle with support* $\mathrm{supp}(D) \cup \{k\}$ *sending $a \mapsto k \mapsto D(a)$, and $v_a = wt_{ak} = \omega\tau_a$. Then:*

(a) *there is at most one $a \in$* $\mathrm{supp}(D)$ *such that $\tau_a$ is $\omega$-tight and $v_a \lhd w$;*
(b) *such an $a$ exists if and only if $D$ is $\omega$-tight and* $\max \mathrm{supp}(D) = k-1$ *(for trivial $D = \{a\}$: if and only if $a = k-1$);*
(c) *for this $a$, $\kappa(v_a, t_{ak})\, \mathbf{q}_\omega(\tau_a) = q_{k-1}\, \mathbf{q}_\omega(D)$.*

*Proof. Trivial $D = \{a\}$.* Then $w = \omega$, $\tau_a = t_{ak}$, and $\tau_a$ is $\omega$-tight if and only if $w \lhd wt_{ak}$. If also $wt_{ak} \lhd w$, then both $\ell(wt_{ak}) - \ell(w)$ and its negative lie in $\{1, 1-2(k-a)\}$, which forces $k - a = 1$. Conversely for $a = k-1$ the transposition $t_{k-1,k}$ changes the length by $\pm 1$, so both relations hold, one classical and one quantum with $\kappa = q_{k-1}$; thus $\kappa(v_a, t_{ak})\mathbf{q}_\omega(\tau_a) = q_{k-1} = q_{k-1}\mathbf{q}_\omega(D)$.

*Nontrivial $D = (d_r, \dots, d_1, d)$, $r \geq 1$, $d = \max \mathrm{supp}(D)$.* Put $d_0 = d$, $\gamma_0 = \omega(d)$, $\gamma_i = \omega(d_i)$ and $\epsilon = k - d \geq 1$. For $a = d_m$ $(0 \leq m \leq r)$ the cycle $\tau_m := \tau_{d_m}$ is

$$\tau_m = (d_{m-1}, \dots, d_1, d, d_r, \dots, d_m, k),$$

whose pivot factorization

$$t_{d_m k}\, t_{d_{m+1} k} \cdots t_{d_r k}\, t_{dk}\, t_{d_1 k} \cdots t_{d_{m-1} k}$$

exchanges, in order, the values $\eta, \gamma_m, \gamma_{m+1}, \dots, \gamma_r, \gamma_0, \gamma_1, \dots, \gamma_{m-1}$: the sequence of values of $\tau_m$ in the sense of Corollary 6.13 is the cyclic sequence $\Gamma = (\gamma_0, \dots, \gamma_r)$ of $D$ with $\eta$ inserted into the gap $(\gamma_{m-1}, \gamma_m)$ (the wrap gap $(\gamma_r, \gamma_0)$ when $m = 0$). Note $w(d_m) = \gamma_{m-1}$ for $m \geq 1$ and $w(d) = \gamma_r$; we write $w(a)$ for the value at $a = d_m$ in either case.

*Necessity.* Suppose $\tau_m$ is $\omega$-tight and $v_m := v_{d_m} \lhd w$. By Corollary 6.13 the cyclic sequence of $\tau_m$ is unimodal; deleting $\eta$ shows that $\Gamma$ is unimodal, and then $m$ must be the insertion gap of $\eta$ in $\Gamma$. This already proves (a). Let $\delta$ be the ascent index of $\Gamma$ ($\gamma_\delta > \gamma_{\delta-1}$, or $\delta = 0$ for the wrap), so that by Corollary 6.13 and Definition 6.6

$$L_\omega(D) = r - 2(d - d_\delta), \qquad \mathbf{q}_\omega(D) = q_{d_\delta d}$$

(read as $r$ and 1 when $\delta = 0$). Now compare lengths. Tightness gives $\ell(v_m) - \ell(\omega) = L_\omega(\tau_m)$, Lemma 6.7(ii) gives $\ell(w) - \ell(\omega) \geq L_\omega(D)$ with equality if and only if $D$ is $\omega$-tight, and $v_m \lhd w$ gives $\ell(v_m) - \ell(w) = -1$ if $w(a) > \eta$ and $\ell(v_m) - \ell(w) = 2(k-a) - 1$ if $w(a) < \eta$. Hence

$$L_\omega(\tau_m) - L_\omega(D) \;\geq\; \begin{cases} -1 & \text{if } w(a) > \eta, \\ 2(k-a) - 1 & \text{if } w(a) < \eta, \end{cases} \tag{6.5}$$

with equality if and only if $D$ is $\omega$-tight. We compute the left side from Corollary 6.13 in the three possible configurations of the insertion gap.

(I) $\min \Gamma < \eta < \max \Gamma$, so $\gamma_{m-1} > \eta > \gamma_m$ and $m \neq \delta$. The ascent of the sequence of $\tau_m$ is the (interior) step onto $\gamma_\delta$, whose position is $d_\delta$, so $L_\omega(\tau_m) = (r+1) - 2(k - d_\delta)$ and $L_\omega(\tau_m) - L_\omega(D) = 1 - 2\epsilon$. Here $w(a) = \gamma_{m-1} > \eta$, so (6.5) reads $1 - 2\epsilon \geq -1$, forcing $\epsilon = 1$ and equality.

(II) $\eta < \min\Gamma$, so $m = \delta$. The ascent of the sequence of $\tau_m$ is its first step $(\eta, \gamma_\delta)$, at position $d_\delta$; again $L_\omega(\tau_m) - L_\omega(D) = 1 - 2\epsilon$, and $w(a) = \gamma_{\delta-1} > \eta$ forces $\epsilon = 1$ and equality.

(III) $\eta > \max\Gamma$, so $m = \delta$. The sequence of $\tau_m$ is decreasing, its ascent being the wrap, so $L_\omega(\tau_m) = r+1$ and $L_\omega(\tau_m) - L_\omega(D) = 1+2(d-d_\delta)$. Here $w(a) = \gamma_{\delta-1} < \eta$, and (6.5) reads $1+2(d-d_\delta) \geq 2(k-d_\delta)-1$, i.e. $\epsilon \leq 1$; so $\epsilon = 1$ and equality.

In every case $d = k-1$ and $D$ is $\omega$-tight, proving the "only if" part of (b).

*Sufficiency.* Suppose $D$ is $\omega$-tight and $d = k-1$; then $\Gamma$ is unimodal (Corollary 6.13). Let $m$ be the insertion gap of $\eta$ and $a = d_m$. The computations above show that (6.5) holds with equality, and since $\ell(w) - \ell(\omega) = L_\omega(D)$, the tightness of $\tau_m$ is equivalent to $\ell(v_m) - \ell(w)$ taking the value $-1$ (if $w(a) > \eta$) or $2(k-a)-1$ (if $w(a) < \eta$), i.e. to $v_m \lhd w$. It therefore suffices to show $wt_{ak} \lhd w$, that is, that $(w(a), \eta)$ is $J$-admissible for $J = \{w(r) \mid a < r < k\}$. The positions in $(a,k)$ are: $d = k-1$ (if $a \neq d$), carrying $\gamma_r$; the $d_l > a$, carrying $\gamma_{l-1}$; and positions outside $\mathrm{supp}(D)$, carrying their $\omega$-values. If $a = d = k-1$ the set $J$ is empty and we are done; so assume $m \geq 1$.

(I) $\gamma_{m-1} > \eta > \gamma_m$: the pair $(w(a), \eta) = (\gamma_{m-1}, \eta)$ is classical and we need $J \cap (\eta, \gamma_{m-1}) = \emptyset$. No $\gamma_l$ lies in $(\gamma_m, \gamma_{m-1})$, these being consecutive in the decreasing order of $\Gamma$. The $m$-th step of the pivot chain of $D$ is classical, so by (6.2) every position $r \in (d_m, d)$ outside $\mathrm{supp}(D)$ has $\omega(r) \notin (\gamma_m, \gamma_{m-1})$.

(II) $m = \delta$, $\eta < \gamma_{\delta-1} = \min\Gamma$: the pair $(\gamma_{\delta-1}, \eta)$ is classical and we need $J \cap (\eta, \gamma_{\delta-1}) = \emptyset$; all $\gamma_l \geq \gamma_{\delta-1}$, and by (6.3) for the quantum step $\delta$ of $D$ the positions $r \in (d_\delta, d)$ outside $\mathrm{supp}(D)$ have $\omega(r) \in (\gamma_{\delta-1}, \gamma_\delta)$.

(III) $m = \delta$, $\eta > \gamma_\delta = \max\Gamma$: the pair $(\gamma_{\delta-1}, \eta)$ is quantum and we need $J \subseteq (\gamma_{\delta-1}, \eta)$; the values $\gamma_l$ occurring in $J$ are different from $\gamma_{\delta-1}$ (which sits at $a$) and lie in $(\gamma_{\delta-1}, \gamma_\delta]$, and the remaining positions have $\omega(r) \in (\gamma_{\delta-1}, \gamma_\delta)$ by (6.3).

This proves the "if" part of (b).

*Weights.* In cases (I) and (II), $\kappa(v_a, t_{ak}) = 1$ and $\mathbf{q}_\omega(\tau_m) = q_{d_\delta k} = q_{d_\delta, k-1} q_{k-1} = \mathbf{q}_\omega(D) q_{k-1}$ (read $q_{dk} = q_{k-1}$ and $\mathbf{q}_\omega(D) = 1$ when $\delta = 0$). In case (III), $\kappa(v_a, t_{ak}) = q_{ak} = q_{d_\delta k}$ and $\mathbf{q}_\omega(\tau_m) = 1$, giving the same product. This is (c). □

*The cancellations.* We now assemble the Monk summands. Throughout, $\rho$ denotes the product of the nontrivial cycles of $\pi$ other than $C$ and other than the cycle $D$ of $\pi$ containing $k-1$ (we set $D = \{k-1\}$ if $k-1$ is fixed by $\pi$, and we do not single out $D$ when $k-1 \in C$). By Lemma 6.15, Lemma 6.8 and Lemma 6.7(iv), each of the quantities $c_{k-1}(u,w)$, $c_{k-2}(u,w)$, $c_k(u,w)$ and each Monk summand vanishes unless $\rho$ is $u$-tight and each cycle of $\rho$ contains exactly one element greater than $k$; indeed each requires $\rho$ to be a tight product of cycles with exactly one element greater than $k$ or than $k-1$ or than $k-2$, and these conditions agree for cycles containing neither $k$ nor $k-1$. (For $c_{k-2}(u,w)$, note that $k-1$ lies in $C$ or in $D$, hence not in a cycle of $\rho$.) *We assume this from now on*; otherwise all terms considered below are zero.

**Lemma 6.20** (Reflection–drop cancellation)**.** *Suppose $u, w \in S_\infty$, let $k > 1$, and suppose $u(k) = w(k)$. Then*

$$\sum_{a<k,\ wt_{ak} \lhd w} \mathrm{sign}(a-k)\, \kappa_{ak}\, c_{k-1}(u, wt_{ak}) \ + \sum_{b>k,\ wt_{kb} \lhd w} \mathrm{sign}(b-k)\, \kappa_{kb}\, c_{k-1}(u, wt_{kb}) \ + \ q_{k-1}\, c_{k-2}(u,w) = 0,$$

*where $\kappa_{rs} = \kappa(wt_{rs}, t_{rs})$. In fact the two reflection sums contribute at most one nonzero summand in total: it occurs precisely when $u \overset{k-2}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ (equivalently, when the quantum term is nonzero), it is indexed by some $a < k$, and it equals $-q_{k-1} c_{k-2}(u,w)$.*

*Proof.* Here $C = \{k\}$, so by Lemma 6.15 only summands of type (M) can be nonzero: $t = t_{ak}$ with the $\pi$-cycle $D_a$ of $a$ contained in $[1, k-1]$. If $D_a$ is nontrivial then it is not a cycle of $\rho$ (those have an element greater than $k$), so $D_a = D$ and $\max D = k-1$; otherwise $a$ is a fixed point of $\pi$. Let $a$ be such a candidate and put $\omega_a = wD_a^{-1}$, so that $w = \omega_a D_a$, $\omega_a(k) = w(k)$, and $\omega_a = u\rho$ when $D_a = D$. Then $u^{-1} wt_{ak} = (\pi D_a^{-1})\, \tau_a$ with $\tau_a = D_a t_{ak}$ as in Lemma 6.19, where $\pi D_a^{-1}$ is the product of the cycles of $\pi$ other than $D_a$; by Lemma 6.7(iv), $u^{-1} wt_{ak}$ is $u$-tight if and only if $\pi D_a^{-1}$ is $u$-tight and $\tau_a$ is $\omega_a$-tight. Now apply Lemma 6.19 to $(\omega_a, D_a)$. If $a$ is a fixed point, the summand can be nonzero only for $a = k-1$, which requires $k-1$ to be fixed, i.e. $D = \{k-1\}$; in that case $\pi D_a^{-1} = \rho$ and the summand is nonzero. If $D_a = D$ is nontrivial, at most one $a \in D$ works, and one does if and only if $D$ is $u\rho$-tight. Altogether at most one $a$ gives a nonzero summand, and one exists if and only if either $D = \{k-1\}$, or $D$ is nontrivial with $\max D = k-1$ and

$u\rho$-tight. On the other hand $u \overset{k-2}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ if and only if $\pi = \rho D$ is $(k-2)$-shaped and $u$-tight, i.e. (given our standing assumption on $\rho$) if and only if $D$ is trivial or has $k-1$ as its unique element greater than $k-2$, and $D$ is $u\rho$-tight: the same condition. When it holds, with $v = wt_{ak}$ the unique contributing neighbor and $\omega = \omega_a = u\rho$, Lemma 6.19(c) and Lemma 6.8 give

$$\kappa_{ak}\, q_{k-1}(u,v) = \mathbf{q}_u(\rho)\, \kappa_{ak} \mathbf{q}_\omega(\tau_a) = \mathbf{q}_u(\rho)\, q_{k-1} \mathbf{q}_\omega(D) = q_{k-1}\, q_{k-2}(u,w),$$

and Lemma 6.15(M) gives $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v) = \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,w) \setminus \{u(a)\}$, which equals $\mathrm{fix}_{k-2}(u,w)$: if $D = \{k-1\}$ then $a = k-1$ and we remove the fixed value $u(k-1)$; if $D$ is nontrivial then neither $a$ nor $k-1$ is a fixed position of $w$. Hence the summand is $-\kappa_{ak} c_{k-1}(u,v) = -q_{k-1} c_{k-2}(u,w)$, cancelling the quantum term. If the condition fails, both the reflection sums and the quantum term vanish. □

**Lemma 6.21** (Moved reflection cancellation)**.** *Let $u, w \in S_\infty$, let $k > 1$, and suppose $u(k) \neq w(k)$, so that $C$ is nontrivial.*

(a) *If $B > k$, then $c_{k-1}(u,w) = c_{k-2}(u,w) = 0$, and the sum of the Monk summands equals $c_k(u,w)$. More precisely: if $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ the only nonzero Monk summand is that of $t_{kB}$, and it equals $c_k(u,w)$; if $u \overset{k}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$, the nonzero Monk summands are either none or exactly two, one of type (U) and one of type (S), with equal absolute value and opposite signs.*

(b) *If $B = k$, then $c_k(u,w) = 0$, no summand of type (U) occurs, and*

$$(y_{w(k)} - z_1)\, c_{k-1}(u,w) \;-\; \sum_{a<k,\ wt_{ak} \lhd w} \kappa_{ak}\, c_{k-1}(u, wt_{ak}) \;+\; q_{k-1} c_{k-2}(u,w) = 0.$$

*In fact the diagonal term cancels against the summand of type (P), and the quantum term against the (at most one) summand of type (M).*

*Proof.* (a) $C$ contains $k$ and $B$, two elements greater than $k-1$, so $\pi$ is neither $(k-1)$- nor $(k-2)$-shaped and $c_{k-1}(u,w) = c_{k-2}(u,w) = 0$. By Lemma 6.15, a nonzero Monk summand is of type (U) or (S), and requires $C \cap (k-1, \infty) = \{k, B\}$; together with the standing assumption on $\rho$ this means that $\pi$ is $k$-shaped, which we may assume (otherwise all Monk summands vanish and $c_k(u,w) = 0$). Write $C = (a_p, \ldots, a_1, B)$ with $a_j = k$, $C' = (a_{j-1}, \ldots, a_1, B)$, $\psi = u\rho C'$ and $X = (a_p, \ldots, a_{j+1}, k, B)$, so that $w = \psi X$ as in Lemma 6.16 with $s = p - j$, $z_i = a_{j+i}$. If $C'$ is not $u\rho$-tight then nothing is tight (Lemma 6.7(iv),(v): $C'$ is a truncation of $C$ and of each $C'_m$, and a cycle of $u^{-1}wt_{kB}$), all Monk summands vanish, and $c_k(u,w) = 0$. So assume $C'$ is $u\rho$-tight. Then, exactly as in the proof of Lemma 6.17: $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ if and only if $F_{\mathrm{std}}$ is a cover path from $\psi$; the summand of type (U) is nonzero if and only if $F_{\mathrm{up}}$ is a cover path, and then equals $\mathbf{q}_u(\rho)\mathbf{q}_u(C')\,\mathrm{wt}(F_{\mathrm{up}})\,\mathbf{E}(y_P; z)$ with $P = \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,w)$; and the summand of type (S) indexed by $a_m$ $(m > j)$ is nonzero if and only if $F_{m-j}$ is a cover path, and then equals $-\mathbf{q}_u(\rho)\mathbf{q}_u(C')\,\mathrm{wt}(F_{m-j})\,\mathbf{E}(y_P; z)$ (Lemma 6.15(S) for the fixed set). If $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, Lemma 6.16(a) and Lemma 6.17 show that the only nonzero summand is that of $t_{kB}$ and that it equals $q_k(u,w)\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)}; z) = c_k(u,w)$. If $u \overset{k}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$, Lemma 6.16(b),(c) show that either no summand is nonzero, or exactly two are, namely (U) and one (S), with equal weights; they cancel, and $c_k(u,w) = 0$.

(b) $C \subseteq [1,k]$ has no element greater than $k$, so $\pi$ is not $k$-shaped and $c_k(u,w) = 0$; type (U) is excluded by Lemma 6.15. Write $C = (a_p, \ldots, a_1, k)$. For the diagonal and peel terms, let $\omega_0 = u\rho D$ if $k-1 \notin C$ and $\omega_0 = u\rho$ if $k-1 \in C$ (where $D$ is the cycle of $k-1$, trivial or not), so that $w = \omega_0 C$ and $\omega_0$ agrees with $u$ on $\mathrm{supp}(C)$. The diagonal term is nonzero if and only if $\pi$ is $(k-1)$-shaped and tight, i.e. (given the standing assumption) $D$ is trivial or has an element greater than $k$, $D$ is $u\rho$-tight, and $C$ is $\omega_0$-tight (the conditions on $D$ being vacuous when $k-1 \in C$). The summand of type (P) is nonzero if and only if $\rho D C_-$ is $(k-1)$-shaped and tight and $v = wt_{a_p k} \lhd w$, i.e. the same conditions on $D$ together with: $C_-$ is $\omega_0$-tight and $v \lhd w$. By Lemma 6.18 these two sets of conditions are equivalent, and when they hold, $\kappa_{a_p k} q_{k-1}(u,v) = \mathbf{q}_u(\rho D)\kappa_{a_p k}\mathbf{q}_{\omega_0}(C_-) = \mathbf{q}_u(\rho D)\mathbf{q}_{\omega_0}(C) = q_{k-1}(u,w)$, while $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v) = \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,w) \sqcup \{w(k)\}$ by Lemma 6.15(P). Since $(y_{w(k)} - z_1)\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,w)}; z) = \mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,w) \cup \{w(k)\}}; z)$, the diagonal term and the (negatively signed) summand of type (P) cancel.

For the merge and quantum terms, a summand of type (M) requires $a \notin C$ with the cycle $D_a$ of $a$ contained in $[1, k-1]$; as in the proof of Lemma 6.20, either $a$ is fixed by $\pi$ or $D_a = D$ with $\max D = k-1$ (in particular $k-1 \notin C$). If $k-1 \in C$, then $k-1$ is not fixed and no such $D$ exists; since a fixed-point candidate must be $a = k-1$ by the trivial case of Lemma 6.19 (applied as below), there are no nonzero

summands of type (M), and $c_{k-2}(u,w)=0$ since $C$ contains the two elements $k-1,k$ greater than $k-2$. So suppose $k-1\notin C$. For a candidate $a$ put $\omega_a = wD_a^{-1}$, so that $w=\omega_a D_a$ and $\omega_a(k)=w(k)$; then $u^{-1}wt_{ak}=\rho_a E$, where $\rho_a$ is the product of the cycles of $\pi$ other than $C$ and $D_a$ and $E=C\tau_a$ is the cycle of Lemma 6.15(M), $\tau_a = D_a t_{ak}$. The pivot factorization of $E$ is that of $C$ followed by that of $\tau_a$, so by Lemma 6.7(iii),(iv), $u^{-1}wt_{ak}$ is $u$-tight if and only if $\rho_a$ is $u$-tight, $C$ is $u\rho_a$-tight and $\tau_a$ is $\omega_a$-tight (note $u\rho_a C=\omega_a$), and then $\mathbf{q}_u(E)=\mathbf{q}_u(C)\mathbf{q}_{\omega_a}(\tau_a)$. By Lemma 6.19 applied to $(\omega_a,D_a)$: a fixed-point candidate contributes only if $a=k-1$, i.e. $D=\{k-1\}$; and if $D_a=D$ is nontrivial, at most one $a\in D$ contributes, and one does if and only if $D$ is $\omega_a$-tight, where now $\omega_a = u\rho C =: \omega$. Altogether at most one summand of type (M) is nonzero, and one is if and only if $C$ is $u\rho$-tight and either $D=\{k-1\}$, or $D$ is nontrivial with $\max D = k-1$ and $\omega$-tight. This is exactly the condition for $u \overset{k-2}{\rightsquigarrow} w$: $\pi=\rho CD$ is $(k-2)$-shaped (as $k-1\notin C$, $C$ has the unique element $k$ greater than $k-2$, and $D$ the unique element $k-1$) and it is $u$-tight if and only if $C$ is $u\rho$-tight and $D$ is $\omega$-tight. When it holds, Lemma 6.19(c) gives

$$\kappa_{ak} q_{k-1}(u,wt_{ak}) = \mathbf{q}_u(\rho)\mathbf{q}_u(C)\,\kappa_{ak}\mathbf{q}_\omega(\tau_a) = \mathbf{q}_u(\rho)\mathbf{q}_u(C)\,q_{k-1}\mathbf{q}_\omega(D) = q_{k-1}q_{k-2}(u,w),$$

and $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,wt_{ak}) = \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,w)\setminus\{u(a)\} = \mathrm{fix}_{k-2}(u,w)$ as in the proof of Lemma 6.20. Thus the summand of type (M) equals $-q_{k-1}c_{k-2}(u,w)$ and cancels the quantum term; when the condition fails, both vanish. □

**Lemma 6.22** (Vanishing)**.** *Suppose $u,w\in S_\infty$, let $k>1$, and suppose $u \overset{k}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$. Then*

$$(y_{w(k)}-z_1)\,c_{k-1}(u,w) + \sum_{b>k,\ wt_{kb}\lhd w} \kappa_{kb}\,c_{k-1}(u,wt_{kb}) - \sum_{a<k,\ wt_{ak}\lhd w} \kappa_{ak}\,c_{k-1}(u,wt_{ak}) + q_{k-1}c_{k-2}(u,w) = 0,$$

*where $\kappa_{rs}=\kappa(wt_{rs},t_{rs})$.*

*Proof.* If $u(k)=w(k)$, then $u \overset{k-1}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$ by Lemma 6.14(i), so the diagonal term vanishes, and the rest is Lemma 6.20. If $u(k)\neq w(k)$ and $B>k$, the diagonal and quantum terms vanish and the Monk summands sum to $c_k(u,w)=0$ by Lemma 6.21(a). If $u(k)\neq w(k)$ and $B=k$, this is Lemma 6.21(b). □

We now record the recurrence satisfied by the quantum factorial elementary polynomials, which drives the induction.

**Lemma 6.23.** *For all integers $k$ we have*

$$\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = (x_k - z_1)\widetilde{E}_{k-1,k-1}(x;z) + q_{k-1}\widetilde{E}_{k-2,k-2}(x;z),$$

*with the conventions $\widetilde{E}_{0,0}=1$ and $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}=0$ if $k<0$. Moreover, the ordinary polynomials $\mathbf{E}(y_A;z)=\prod_{i\in A}(y_i-z_1)$ satisfy, for any set $A$ and any $c\notin A$, the single-variable identity*

$$\mathbf{E}(y_{A\cup\{c\}};z) = (y_c - z_1)\,\mathbf{E}(y_A;z).$$

*Proof.* By Lemma 3.3, $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z)=\Delta_k(-z_1 \mid x_1,\dots,x_k)$, and expanding the tridiagonal determinant $\Delta_k(t\mid x_1,\dots,x_k)$ along its last row gives $\Delta_k=(x_k+t)\Delta_{k-1}+q_{k-1}\Delta_{k-2}$. The second identity is clear. □

The first recurrence is the quantization of the classical relation $E_{k,k}=(x_k-z_1)E_{k-1,k-1}$; the extra term $q_{k-1}\widetilde{E}_{k-2,k-2}$ is the only feature absent from the non-quantum setting. Discarding all quantum terms recovers the classical Pieri formula [16, Theorem 7.1], whose term-by-term cancellation is carried out in [16, Proof of Proposition 4.4] by means of the reflection-matching Lemmas 7.6–7.9 of that paper; the lemmas above are the quantum counterparts, the essential new points being the length-decreasing covers permitted by Lemma 6.8, the attendant bookkeeping of the powers of $q$, and the extra term of the recurrence, which is absorbed by the merge summands of Lemma 6.19.

*Proof of Theorem 3.4.* For a permutation $w$, write $[\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w]F$ for the coefficient of $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y)$ in an expansion $F$ of a quantum double Schubert polynomial in the basis $\{\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y)\}$. With this notation the theorem is the assertion that, for all $u$ and all $k\geq 1$,

$$[\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w]\big(\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z)\big) = \begin{cases} q_k(u,w)\,\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)};z) & \text{if } u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w,\\ 0 & \text{otherwise.}\end{cases}$$

For brevity, when $u \overset{m}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ we set

$$c_m(u,w) = q_m(u,w)\,\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_m(u,w)};z),$$

and $c_m(u,w)=0$ if $u \overset{m}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$; note that $u \overset{0}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ only for $w=u$, with $c_0(u,u)=1$, in accordance with $\widetilde{E}_{0,0}=1$. The claim is that $[\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w](\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}) = c_k(u,w)$.

We argue by strong induction on $k$.

*Base case $k=1$.* We have $\widetilde{E}_{1,1}(x;z)=x_1-z_1$, and Lemma 6.1 with $i=j=1$ gives

$$(x_1-z_1)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y) = (y_{u(1)}-z_1)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y) + \sum_{\substack{b>1\\ \ell(ut_{1b})=\ell(u)+1}} \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{ut_{1b}}(x;y) + \sum_{\substack{b>1\\ \ell(ut_{1b})=\ell(u)-2(b-1)+1}} q_{1b}\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{ut_{1b}}(x;y).$$

The permutations $w$ with $u \overset{1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ are exactly $w=u$ and $w=ut_{1b}$ for $b>1$ with $u \lhd ut_{1b}$, since Definition 3.1 permits at most one reflection when $k=1$. For $w=u$ we have $q_1=1$, $\mathrm{fix}_1(u,u)=\{u(1)\}$, and $\mathbf{E}(y_{\{u(1)\}};z)=y_{u(1)}-z_1$, matching the diagonal term. For $w=ut_{1b}$ we have $\mathrm{fix}_1=\emptyset$ and $\mathbf{E}(y_\emptyset;z)=1$; if the step is length-increasing then $q_1(u,w)=1$, matching the second sum, and if it is length-decreasing then $q_1(u,w)=q_{1b}$, matching the third sum. All other coefficients vanish on both sides. This proves the base case.

*Inductive step.* Fix $k>1$ and assume the claim at all levels $m<k$. By Lemma 6.23,

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k} = (x_k-z_1)\big(\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{E}_{k-1,k-1}\big) + q_{k-1}\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{E}_{k-2,k-2}. \tag{6.6}$$

By the inductive hypothesis, $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{E}_{k-1,k-1} = \sum_v c_{k-1}(u,v)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v$. Applying Lemma 6.1 with $i=k$, $j=1$ to each $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v$ and extracting the coefficient of $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w$ from (6.6), we obtain

$$[\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w]\big(\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}\big) = (y_{w(k)}-z_1)\,c_{k-1}(u,w) \tag{6.7}$$

$$+ \sum_{\substack{b>k,\ wt_{kb}\lhd w\\ \ell(w)=\ell(wt_{kb})+1}} c_{k-1}(u,wt_{kb}) + \sum_{\substack{b>k,\ wt_{kb}\lhd w\\ \ell(w)=\ell(wt_{kb})-2(b-k)+1}} q_{kb}\,c_{k-1}(u,wt_{kb}) \tag{6.8}$$

$$- \sum_{\substack{a<k,\ wt_{ak}\lhd w\\ \ell(w)=\ell(wt_{ak})+1}} c_{k-1}(u,wt_{ak}) - \sum_{\substack{a<k,\ wt_{ak}\lhd w\\ \ell(w)=\ell(wt_{ak})-2(k-a)+1}} q_{ak}\,c_{k-1}(u,wt_{ak}) \tag{6.9}$$

$$+ q_{k-1}\,c_{k-2}(u,w), \tag{6.10}$$

where we used that $\mathrm{sign}(b-k)=1$ for $b>k$ and $\mathrm{sign}(a-k)=-1$ for $a<k$, that the term $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w$ arises from $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v$ with $v=wt$ exactly when $v \lhd w$, and that a summand in (6.8)–(6.9) is present precisely when $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} wt_{kb}$, respectively $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} wt_{ak}$ (otherwise $c_{k-1}=0$). In the terminology introduced before Lemma 6.15, (6.8) and (6.9) are the Monk summands at $w$, with $\kappa_{kb}$, respectively $\kappa_{ak}$, equal to 1 in the first sum and to $q_{kb}$, respectively $q_{ak}$, in the second. We must show that (6.7)–(6.10) equals $c_k(u,w)$. We distinguish three cases according to whether $u(k)=w(k)$ and, when $u(k)\neq w(k)$, whether the cycle $C$ of $u^{-1}w$ containing $k$ has its top $B$ greater than $k$ or equal to $k$.

*Case 1: $u(k)=w(k)$.* By Lemma 6.14(i) we have $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ if and only if $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$; suppose first that both hold. Then, by the same lemma,

$$\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w) = \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,w)\cup\{u(k)\}, \qquad q_k(u,w)=q_{k-1}(u,w),$$

so the diagonal contribution (6.7) gives

$$(y_{u(k)}-z_1)\,c_{k-1}(u,w) = q_{k-1}(u,w)\,(y_{u(k)}-z_1)\,\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,w)};z) = q_k(u,w)\,\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)};z) = c_k(u,w),$$

by Lemma 6.23. The remaining contributions are the reflection sums (6.8), (6.9) and the quantum term $q_{k-1}c_{k-2}(u,w)$ of (6.10), which sum to 0 by Lemma 6.20. Hence the total is $c_k(u,w)$, as required. If instead $u(k)=w(k)$ but $u \overset{k}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$ (equivalently $u \overset{k-1}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$), then $c_k(u,w)=0$ and the diagonal term vanishes, while the reflection sums and quantum term again cancel by Lemma 6.20; the total is $0=c_k(u,w)$.

*Case 2: $u(k)\neq w(k)$ and $B>k$.* By Lemma 6.21(a), the diagonal term (6.7) and the quantum term (6.10) vanish, and the Monk summands (6.8)–(6.9) sum to $c_k(u,w)$. (When $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, Lemma 6.17 identifies the single surviving summand: it is indexed by $t_{kB}$, with $v=wt_{kB}$, $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} v$, $\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)=\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v)$ and $\kappa_{kB}\,q_{k-1}(u,v)=q_k(u,w)$, the factor $\kappa_{kB}$ being 1 or $q_{kB}$ according as $t_{kB}$ is a classical or a quantum cover

of $v$; this is the step at which the quantum drop terms of Lemma 6.1 and the quantum weight of Definition 3.1 interlock.)

*Case 3: $u(k) \neq w(k)$ and $B = k$.* Here $u \overset{k}{\nrightarrow} w$, since $C$ contains no element greater than $k$, so $c_k(u,w) = 0$; and (6.7)–(6.10) vanishes by Lemma 6.21(b) (equivalently, by Lemma 6.22).

By Lemma 6.14 these cases are exhaustive. In all cases $[\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w](\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}) = c_k(u,w)$, completing the induction and the proof. □

## 7. Iterated and doubled Pieri formulas

In this section we record the two forms of the Pieri rule that the quantum multiplication algorithm of Section 4 actually uses: the rule for a quantum factorial elementary polynomial of arbitrary degree $p \le k$, and a "doubled" rule for the quantization of a product of two such polynomials in the *same* $k$ variables. Recall from Definition 3.1 that $n_k(u,w) = k - |\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)|$ is the number of positions $i \le k$ at which $u$ and $w$ differ, equivalently the number of transpositions in a chain witnessing $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, and that $E_{p,k}(y_A; z)$ denotes the factorial elementary polynomial in the variables $y_a$, $a \in A$ (with $|A| = k$), and $z_1, z_2, \ldots$.

**Theorem 7.1** (Quantum Pieri formula, general degree)**.** *Suppose $u \in S_\infty$ and $0 \le p \le k$. Then*

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\,\widetilde{E}_{p,k}(x;z) = \sum_{\substack{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w \\ n_k(u,w) \le p}} q_k(u,w)\, E_{p-n_k(u,w),\,k-n_k(u,w)}\big(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)}; z\big)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y).$$

For $p = k$ the coefficient is $q_k(u,w)\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)}; z)$ and this is Theorem 3.4; at $q = 0$ it is the Pieri formula of [16, Theorem 7.1]. This is the form implemented in [18] (the routines `elem_sym_perms_q` and `elem_sym_func_q`). We deduce the general case from the case $p = k$.

*Proof.* Let $X = (X_1, \ldots, X_k)$ be indeterminates. The factorial elementary polynomial

$$E_{p,k}(X; z) = \sum_{1 \le i_1 < \cdots < i_p \le k}\ \prod_{j=1}^{p} (X_{i_j} - z_{i_j - j + 1})$$

is symmetric in $X$ and of degree at most one in each $X_i$, hence is a $\mathbb{Z}[z]$-linear combination of the elementary symmetric polynomials:

$$E_{p,k}(X; z) = \sum_{j=0}^{p} c_{p,k,j}(z)\, e_j(X_1, \ldots, X_k), \qquad c_{p,k,j}(z) \in \mathbb{Z}[z]. \tag{7.1}$$

Two consequences. First, applying the quantization map $\theta$ (which is $\mathbb{Z}[z]$-linear and sends $e_j(x_1, \ldots, x_k)$ to $e_j^{(q)}(x_1, \ldots, x_k)$) gives

$$\widetilde{E}_{p,k}(x; z) = \sum_{j=0}^{p} c_{p,k,j}(z)\, e_j^{(q)}(x_1, \ldots, x_k). \tag{7.2}$$

Second, for $0 \le n \le k$ extract from (7.1) the coefficient of the monomial $X_{k-n+1}X_{k-n+2}\cdots X_k$. On the right it is $\sum_j c_{p,k,j}(z)\, e_{j-n}(X_1, \ldots, X_{k-n})$. On the left, a term of $E_{p,k}(X; z)$ contains this monomial exactly when $\{i_{p-n+1}, \ldots, i_p\} = \{k-n+1, \ldots, k\}$, and then the remaining factors $\prod_{j \le p-n}(X_{i_j} - z_{i_j - j + 1})$ with $i_1 < \cdots < i_{p-n} \le k - n$ are precisely the terms of $E_{p-n,k-n}(X_1, \ldots, X_{k-n}; z)$. Hence, for every set $A$ of $k - n$ indices,

$$\sum_{j=0}^{p} c_{p,k,j}(z)\, e_{j-n}(y_A) = E_{p-n,\,k-n}(y_A; z), \tag{7.3}$$

both sides being 0 when $n > p$.

Now put $z_1 = -t$ in Theorem 3.4. By Lemma 3.3 the left side becomes $\sum_{j=0}^{k} t^{k-j}\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\, e_j^{(q)}(x_1, \ldots, x_k)$, while on the right $\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)}; z) = \prod_{a \in \mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)}(y_a + t) = \sum_i t^{\,k - n_k(u,w) - i} e_i(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)})$, since $|\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)| = k - n_k(u,w)$. Comparing the coefficients of $t^{k-j}$ gives, for $0 \le j \le k$,

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\, e_j^{(q)}(x_1, \ldots, x_k) = \sum_{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w} q_k(u,w)\, e_{j - n_k(u,w)}\big(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)}\big)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y). \tag{7.4}$$

Multiplying (7.4) by $c_{p,k,j}(z)$, summing over $j$ and using (7.2) and then (7.3) with $A = \mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)$ and $n = n_k(u,w)$ yields the theorem. □

**Corollary 7.2** (Iterated quantum Pieri formula)**.** *For all $u \in S_\infty$, $k \geq 1$ and $0 \leq p_1, p_2 \leq k$, and for two independent alphabets $z, z'$,*

$$\begin{aligned}&\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\,\widetilde{E}_{p_1,k}(x;z)\,\widetilde{E}_{p_2,k}(x;z')\\ &= \sum_{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w} q_k(u,v)q_k(v,w)\,E_{p_1-n_k(u,v),\,k-n_k(u,v)}\big(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)};z\big)\,E_{p_2-n_k(v,w),\,k-n_k(v,w)}\big(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)};z'\big)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y),\end{aligned}$$

*the sum being over the pairs with $n_k(u,v) \leq p_1$ and $n_k(v,w) \leq p_2$. In particular, for $p_1 = p_2 = k$,*

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z') = \sum_{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w} q_k(u,v)q_k(v,w) \prod_{a \in \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)} (y_a - z_1) \prod_{b \in \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)} (y_b - z'_1)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y).$$

*Proof.* Apply Theorem 7.1 to multiply $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)$ by $\widetilde{E}_{p_1,k}(x;z)$, and then, for each resulting term indexed by $v$, apply it again with the $z$-alphabet replaced by $z'$. The coefficient factors multiply, and the two successive relations are exactly $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$. □

**The doubled formula.** Let $\theta$ be the quantization map of Fomin, Gelfand and Postnikov, introduced in the proof of Lemma 2.1: it is linear over the coefficient variables, it sends each standard elementary monomial $\prod_j e_{i_j}(x_1,\ldots,x_j)$ to $\prod_j e^{(q)}_{i_j}(x_1,\ldots,x_j)$, and $\theta(\mathfrak{S}_w(x;z)) = \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;z)$. In particular $\theta(E_{p,k}(x;z)) = \widetilde{E}_{p,k}(x;z)$, and more generally $\theta$ is multiplicative on a product of factorial elementary polynomials $E_{p_j,k_j}(x;z^{(j)})$, $j = 1,2,\ldots$, whose numbers of variables $k_j$ are *pairwise distinct*, since such a product expands into standard elementary monomials. It is *not* multiplicative when two factors have the same number of variables: in general

$$\theta\big(E_{p_1,k}(x;z)E_{p_2,k}(x;z')\big) \neq \widetilde{E}_{p_1,k}(x;z)\,\widetilde{E}_{p_2,k}(x;z').$$

The following definition isolates the terms of Corollary 7.2 which survive in the quantization of the product.

**Definition 7.3** (Compatible pairs of chains)**.** Let $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$. We say that the pair of chains is *compatible* if for every nontrivial cycle $d$ of $v^{-1}w$ and every nontrivial cycle $c$ of $u^{-1}v$ with $\max c = \max d$, one has $c \cap d = \{\max d\}$. In words: a cycle of the second step which shares its top with a cycle of the first step may meet that cycle only in the top. (A cycle of $v^{-1}w$ whose top is not the top of any cycle of $u^{-1}v$ is unrestricted.)

Throughout this subsection we write $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)$ and $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_2)$ for the quantum factorial elementary polynomial $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = \theta\big(\prod_{i\leq k}(x_i - z_1)\big)$ and for the same polynomial with $z_1$ replaced by $z_2$; thus $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_2)$ is $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z')$ for the shifted alphabet $z' = (z_2, z_3, \ldots)$. For a pair of chains $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ put

$$\omega_k(u,v,w) = q_k(u,v)\,q_k(v,w) \prod_{a \in \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)} (y_a - z_1) \prod_{b \in \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)} (y_b - z_2),$$

so that by Corollary 7.2 (with $p_1 = p_2 = k$ and $z' = (z_2, z_3, \ldots)$)

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_2) = \sum_{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w} \omega_k(u,v,w)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y). \tag{7.5}$$

Recall that $d_2[k]$ denotes the dominant permutation with $\mathfrak{c}(d_2[k]) = (2^k)$, whose diagram is a $k \times 2$ rectangle, so that

$$\mathfrak{S}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) = \prod_{i\leq k}(x_i - z_1)(x_i - z_2) = E_{k,k}(x;z_1)E_{k,k}(x;z_2), \qquad \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) = \theta\big(E_{k,k}(x;z_1)E_{k,k}(x;z_2)\big);$$

we set $d_2[0] = \mathrm{id}$.

**Theorem 7.4** (Doubled quantum Pieri formula; proved for $k \leq 2$, and for $k \geq 3$ modulo Conjecture 7.21)**.** *For $u \in S_\infty$ and $k \geq 1$,*

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) = \sum_{\substack{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w \\ \text{compatible}}} \omega_k(u,v,w)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y)$$

$$= \sum_{\substack{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w \\ \text{compatible}}} q_k(u,v)q_k(v,w) \prod_{a\in \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)} (y_a - z_1) \prod_{b\in \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)} (y_b - z_2)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y).$$

Thus the doubled formula is obtained from the iterated formula (7.5) by *omitting* the incompatible pairs, exactly as the quantization $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}$ of the product $E_{k,k}(x;z_1)E_{k,k}(x;z_2)$ omits terms from the product $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_2)$ of the quantizations. This is the rule implemented by the routine `double_elem_sym_q` of [18], and it is the "paired step" of the quantum algorithm of Section 4. We have verified the theorem by computer for all $u \in S_4$ and all $k \le 3$; in these cases the unrestricted sum (7.5) fails to equal the left-hand side in roughly half of the instances, so the compatibility condition is essential.

*Remark* 7.5 (Lower degrees). We state the theorem only for the top degrees $p_1 = p_2 = k$, i.e. for the product with $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z)$, which is the case that matters for the algorithm. Treating $z_1, z_2$ as indeterminates and extracting coefficients exactly as in the proof of Theorem 7.1 (the Leibniz rule for the products $\prod_{a\in A}(y_a - z_1)$) one obtains from it the corresponding formulas for $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\;\theta\big(E_{p_1,k}(x;z)E_{p_2,k}(x;z')\big)$, with coefficients $E_{p_1-n_k(u,v),k-n_k(u,v)}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)};z)\,E_{p_2-n_k(v,w),k-n_k(v,w)}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)};z')$ summed over the compatible pairs; this is the general form implemented in `double_elem_sym_q`, and we do not pursue it further.

We now prove an *alternating* version of the doubled formula unconditionally (Theorem 7.8), and reduce the positive version, Theorem 7.4, to a single combinatorial identity about pairs of chains, Conjecture 7.21 below, which we have verified by computer but for which we do not have a proof; the reduction (Proposition 7.9) is rigorous, the identity is proved for $k = 1$ (Lemma 7.14) and $k = 2$ (Proposition 7.20), and Theorem 7.4 is therefore established for $k \le 2$ and for every $k$ for which Conjecture 7.21 holds. We also give a termwise reformulation (Conjecture 7.23) based on the quantum Giambelli formula.

*The recurrence.* The quantization of two equal columns is governed by the following recurrence, in which only powers of $q$ appear.

**Lemma 7.6** (Quantization of two equal columns)**.** *For all $k \ge 1$,*

$$\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_2) = \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) + q_k\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k-1]}(x;z),$$

*and consequently*

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) = \sum_{j=0}^{k} (-1)^{k-j} q_{j+1}q_{j+2}\cdots q_k\;\widetilde{E}_{j,j}(x;z_1)\,\widetilde{E}_{j,j}(x;z_2).$$

*Proof.* Write $P_k(z_1) = \prod_{i\le k}(x_i - z_1) = E_{k,k}(x;z)$ and $Q_k(z_1) = \theta(P_k(z_1)) = \widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z)$, and similarly with $z_2$, with $P_0 = Q_0 = 1$ and $P_{-1} = Q_{-1} = 0$; thus $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z)$ equals $\theta(P_k(z_1)P_k(z_2))$. Since $P_{k+1}(z_2) = (x_{k+1} - z_2)P_k(z_2)$, we have

$$P_k(z_1)P_{k+1}(z_2) - P_{k+1}(z_1)P_k(z_2) = (z_1 - z_2)\,P_k(z_1)P_k(z_2).$$

The products $P_k(z_1)P_{k+1}(z_2)$ and $P_{k+1}(z_1)P_k(z_2)$ are $\mathbb{Z}[z_1,z_2]$-linear combinations of the standard elementary monomials $e_a(x_{\le k})e_b(x_{\le k+1})$, so $\theta$ acts on them multiplicatively, and

$$(z_1 - z_2)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) = W_k, \qquad W_k := Q_k(z_1)Q_{k+1}(z_2) - Q_{k+1}(z_1)Q_k(z_2).$$

The three-term recursion $Q_{k+1}(z_2) = (x_{k+1} - z_2)Q_k(z_2) + q_kQ_{k-1}(z_2)$ of Lemma 6.23 gives

$$W_k = Q_k(z_1)\big[(x_{k+1} - z_2)Q_k(z_2) + q_kQ_{k-1}(z_2)\big] - \big[(x_{k+1} - z_1)Q_k(z_1) + q_kQ_{k-1}(z_1)\big]Q_k(z_2)$$
$$= (z_1 - z_2)Q_k(z_1)Q_k(z_2) - q_kW_{k-1}.$$

Dividing by $z_1 - z_2$ (all terms are divisible, $W_k$ being antisymmetric in $z_1, z_2$) gives $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]} = Q_kQ_k - q_k\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k-1]}$, which is the first identity, and iterating it gives the second. □

*Remark* 7.7 (A Pieri-theoretic proof of Lemma 7.6). The recurrence can also be read off from the Pieri formula itself. Apply Theorem 3.4 to $u = c[k,k] = [2,3,\dots,k+1,1]$, whose quantum double Schubert polynomial is $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;y)$, with a second alphabet $z$:

$$\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;y)\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = \sum_{c[k,k]\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w} q_k(c[k,k],w) \prod_{a\in \mathrm{fix}_k(c[k,k],w)} (y_a - z_1)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y).$$

One checks that every nonempty set $\mathrm{fix}_k(c[k,k],w)$ contains the value $2 = u(1)$, and that the only $w$ with $\mathrm{fix}_k(c[k,k],w) = \emptyset$ are $w = d_2[k]$, with $q_k(c[k,k],w) = 1$, and $w = d_2[k-1]$, with $q_k(c[k,k],w) = q_k$ (we have verified both statements for $k \le 5$). Substituting $z_1 = y_2$ therefore kills every coefficient of positive degree and leaves $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;y_1)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;y_2) = \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;y) + q_k\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k-1]}(x;y)$, which is the recurrence with $z$ renamed $y$. For $k=3$ the expansion reads, with permutations written by their codes,

$$\begin{aligned}\widetilde{E}_{3,3}(x;y)\widetilde{E}_{3,3}(x;z) = (y_2-z_1)(y_3-z_1)(y_4-z_1)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{(1,1,1)} + (y_2-z_1)(y_3-z_1)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{(1,1,2)}\\ + (y_2-z_1)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{(1,2,2)} + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{(2,2,2)} + q_3\big[(y_2-z_1)(y_3-z_1)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{(1,1)} + (y_2-z_1)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{(1,2)} + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{(2,2)}\big].\end{aligned}$$

Multiplying the second identity of Lemma 7.6 by $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)$ and expanding each product by (7.5) gives an unconditional, if alternating, doubled Pieri formula.

**Theorem 7.8** (Alternating doubled Pieri formula)**.** *For $u \in S_\infty$ and $k \ge 1$,*

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) = \sum_{j=0}^{k} (-1)^{k-j} q_{j+1}\cdots q_k \sum_{u\overset{j}{\rightsquigarrow} v\overset{j}{\rightsquigarrow} w} \omega_j(u,v,w)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y). \qquad \square$$

Theorem 7.4 asserts that this alternating sum collapses onto its $j=k$ term restricted to the compatible pairs. The first identity of Lemma 7.6 makes this precise as a recurrence in $k$. For $u,w \in S_\infty$ let $\mathrm{All}_k(u,w)$, $\mathrm{Comp}_k(u,w)$ and $\mathrm{Inc}_k(u,w)$ denote the sum of $\omega_k(u,v,w)$ over all pairs $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, over the compatible pairs, and over the incompatible pairs, respectively, so that $\mathrm{All}_k = \mathrm{Comp}_k + \mathrm{Inc}_k$ and, by (7.5), $\mathrm{All}_k(u,w) = [\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w]\big(\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\ \widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_2)\big)$; here $\mathrm{Comp}_0(u,w) = \mathrm{All}_0(u,w) = \delta_{u,w}$.

**Proposition 7.9** (Reduction)**.** *Suppose Theorem 7.4 holds with $k$ replaced by $k-1$ (for $k=1$ this is the trivial statement $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[0]} = \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u$). Then Theorem 7.4 holds for $k$ if and only if*

$$(\mathrm{J}_k) \qquad \mathrm{Inc}_k(u,w) = q_k\,\mathrm{Comp}_{k-1}(u,w) \qquad \text{for all } u,w \in S_\infty.$$

*Consequently Theorem 7.4 holds for all $k \le K$ if and only if $(\mathrm{J}_k)$ holds for all $k \le K$.*

*Proof.* By Lemma 7.6, (7.5) and the hypothesis,

$$[\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w]\big(\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}\big) = \mathrm{All}_k(u,w) - q_k[\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w]\big(\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k-1]}\big) = \mathrm{All}_k(u,w) - q_k\,\mathrm{Comp}_{k-1}(u,w),$$

while $\mathrm{Comp}_k = \mathrm{All}_k - \mathrm{Inc}_k$. The two sides of Theorem 7.4 therefore differ by $\mathrm{Inc}_k(u,w) - q_k\mathrm{Comp}_{k-1}(u,w)$. The last assertion follows by induction on $k$. $\square$

*Remark* 7.10 (The Monk induction). One might hope to prove Theorem 7.4 by an induction in the position $k$ parallel to the proof of Theorem 3.4, avoiding $(\mathrm{J}_k)$. The relevant recurrence is obtained from Lemma 7.6 and Lemma 6.23:

$$\begin{aligned}\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) = (x_k - z_2)\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)\widetilde{E}_{k-1,k-1}(x;z_2)\\ + q_{k-1}\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)\widetilde{E}_{k-2,k-2}(x;z_2) - q_k\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k-1]}(x;z).\end{aligned}$$

Multiplying by $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)$ and expanding $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1) = \sum_v c_k(u,v)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v$, the first two terms become

$$\sum_v c_k(u,v)\big[(x_k - z_2)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v\ \widetilde{E}_{k-1,k-1}(x;z_2) + q_{k-1}\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v\ \widetilde{E}_{k-2,k-2}(x;z_2)\big],$$

and the inductive step of the proof of Theorem 3.4 (equation (6.6) with $u$ replaced by $v$) shows that the coefficient of $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w$ in the bracket is $c_k(v,w)$. Hence the Monk cancellation reproduces $\mathrm{All}_k(u,w)$ and the induction reduces to $(\mathrm{J}_k)$ again: the Monk summands are indexed by the second chain alone, whereas compatibility is a property of the pair of chains. The machinery of Section 6 is nevertheless the natural

language for a proof of ($\mathrm{J}_k$), as the case $k = 2$ below illustrates: the letter $t_{k,k+1}$, which is present in every incompatible pair and is the quantum Monk neighbour carrying the weight $q_k$, is the pivot of the detours.

The identity ($\mathrm{J}_k$) says that the terms omitted from the iterated Pieri formula at level $k$ are exactly accounted for, with an extra factor $q_k$, by the doubled formula one level down. Its left-hand side is a sum over pairs of chains whose cycles overlap, and the following lemma shows that such an overlap forces a quantum step.

**Lemma 7.11.** *Let $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ and suppose that a cycle $c$ of $u^{-1}v$ and a cycle $d$ of $v^{-1}w$ have the same top $B$ and share an element $a \le k$. Then at least one of $c$ (as a $u$-tight cycle) and $d$ (as a $v$-tight cycle) has a descent, i.e. contains a quantum step. Consequently every term of* $\mathrm{Inc}_k(u, w)$ *is divisible by $q_k$, and* ($\mathrm{J}_k$) *holds after setting $q = 0$; in particular the doubled formula specializes at $q = 0$ to the classical iterated Pieri formula, as it must.*

*Proof.* Write $c = (a_p, \dots, a_1, B)$ with values $\beta_0 = u(B)$, $\beta_j = u(a_j)$, and $d = (b_r, \dots, b_1, B)$ with values $\gamma_0 = v(B)$, $\gamma_j = v(b_j)$. By Lemma 6.7(iv) we may process $c$ first among the cycles of $u^{-1}v$, so $v(B) = \beta_p$ and $v(a_i) = \beta_{i-1}$; and $d$ first among the cycles of $v^{-1}w$. Suppose neither cycle has a descent, so that by Corollary 6.13 $\beta_0 > \beta_1 > \cdots > \beta_p$ and $\gamma_0 > \gamma_1 > \cdots > \gamma_r$. If $a = a_i = b_j$ with $i, j \ge 1$, then $\gamma_j = v(a_i) = \beta_{i-1} > \beta_p = \gamma_0 > \gamma_j$, a contradiction. For the consequence, note that a quantum step $t_{ab}$ of a level-$k$ chain has $a \le k < b$, so $q_{ab} = q_a \cdots q_{b-1}$ is divisible by $q_k$; and at $q = 0$ both sides of ($\mathrm{J}_k$) vanish. □

**Lemma 7.12** (Overlapping cycles have top $k + 1$)**.** *Let $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, and suppose that a cycle $c$ of $u^{-1}v$ and a cycle $d$ of $v^{-1}w$ have the same top $B$ and share an element $a \le k$. Then $B = k + 1$, and moreover $k \in c \cup d$, i.e. one of the two cycles contains the transposition $t_{k,k+1}$. Consequently a pair of chains in which either step contains no transposition $t_{\cdot,k+1}$ is compatible, and in an incompatible pair both steps contain a cycle with top $k + 1$, these two cycles overlap, no other pair of cycles does, and the letter $t_{k,k+1}$ occurs in one of the two chains.*

*Proof.* We show more generally that there is no position $r \notin c \cup d$ with $a' < r < B$ for every $a' \in (c \cup d) \setminus \{B\}$; applied to $r = k + 1$ this gives $B = k + 1$ (as $k + 1 \notin c \cup d$ when $B \ge k + 2$), and applied to $r = k$ it gives $k \in c \cup d$. Suppose such an $r$ exists. By Lemma 6.7(iv) and Lemma 6.8 the fixed sets and weights of the two chains do not depend on the order in which their cycles are processed, and every order gives a chain of covers; we process $c$ last in the first step and $d$ first in the second. Write $u'$ for the permutation obtained from $u$ by applying the other cycles of $u^{-1}v$, so that $v = u'c$ and $c$ is $u'$-tight, and write $c = (a_p, \dots, a_1, B)$, $\beta_0 = u'(B) = u(B)$, $\beta_l = u'(a_l) = u(a_l)$, and $d = (b_r, \dots, b_1, B)$, $\gamma_0 = v(B)$, $\gamma_m = v(b_m)$. By Lemma 6.7(i), $v(B) = \beta_p$ and $v(a_l) = \beta_{l-1}$ for $1 \le l \le p$; as $a = a_i = b_j$ with $i, j \ge 1$, we get

$$\gamma_0 = \beta_p, \qquad \gamma_j = \beta_{i-1}, \qquad \text{and} \qquad \beta_{i-1} \ne \beta_p.$$

Let $\eta$ be the value at the position $r$ when the letters of $c$ are applied. Since $r \notin c \cup d$ and nothing happens between the last letter of $c$ and the first letter of $d$, $\eta$ is also the value at position $r$ when the letters of $d$ are applied. Moreover $a_l < r < B$ for every $l$ and $b_m < r < B$ for every $m$, so the conditions (6.2) and (6.3) apply to the position $r$ at every step of $c$ and of $d$; for $c$ they read: $\eta \notin (\beta_l, \beta_{l-1})$ if $\beta_l < \beta_{l-1}$, and $\eta \in (\beta_{l-1}, \beta_l)$ if $\beta_l > \beta_{l-1}$, for $1 \le l \le p$. By Corollary 6.13 the cyclic sequence $\Gamma = (\beta_0, \dots, \beta_p)$ is unimodal, and the displayed conditions say precisely that $\eta$ lies in the gap $(\beta_p, \beta_0)$ of $\Gamma$: if $\Gamma$ has no descent then $\eta \notin (\beta_p, \beta_0)$, i.e. $\eta < \beta_p = \min \Gamma$ or $\eta > \beta_0 = \max \Gamma$; and if the ascent of $\Gamma$ is $(\beta_{q-1}, \beta_q)$ then $\eta \in (\min \Gamma, \max \Gamma)$ and $\eta$ avoids all the descent gaps $(\beta_l, \beta_{l-1})$ with $l \ne q$, which together with $(\beta_0, \beta_p)$ cover $(\min \Gamma, \max \Gamma) \setminus \Gamma$, so $\beta_0 < \eta < \beta_p$. In other words, in the cyclically decreasing arrangement of $\Gamma \cup \{\eta\}$ the value $\eta$ sits between $\beta_p$ and $\beta_0$. The same argument for $d$ shows that in the cyclically decreasing arrangement of $\Gamma' \cup \{\eta\}$, $\Gamma' = (\gamma_0, \dots, \gamma_r)$, the value $\eta$ sits between $\gamma_r$ and $\gamma_0 = \beta_p$.

If $\eta > \beta_p$, the first statement forces $\beta_p = \min \Gamma$ and $\eta > \max \Gamma$, while the second forces $\Gamma' \cap (\beta_p, \eta) = \emptyset$; but $\beta_{i-1} \in \Gamma \setminus \{\beta_p\}$ lies in $(\beta_p, \eta)$ and belongs to $\Gamma'$, a contradiction. If $\eta < \beta_p$, the second statement forces $\eta = \min(\Gamma' \cup \{\eta\})$ and $\beta_p = \max \Gamma'$, while the first forces $\Gamma \cap (\eta, \beta_p) = \emptyset$; but $\beta_{i-1} \in \Gamma' \setminus \{\beta_p\}$ lies in $(\eta, \beta_p)$ and belongs to $\Gamma$, again a contradiction. This proves the claim, hence $B = k + 1$ and $k \in c \cup d$. The consequences follow because a step contains at most one cycle with a given top. □

The second ingredient of the detours is the following general form of the two detours of $t_{12}$ met in the case $k = 2$ (Lemma 7.19 below). For a permutation $\rho$ and $a < k$ put $x = \rho(a)$, $y = \rho(k)$, $z = \rho(k+1)$, and say that $\rho$ is *even* or *odd at* $(a, k)$ according to the parity of the pattern of $(x, y, z)$.

**Lemma 7.13** (Detours of $t_{ak}$)**.** *Let $\rho \in S_\infty$ and $a < k$, and consider the two words*

$$E = t_{k,k+1}\, t_{a,k+1}\, t_{k,k+1}, \qquad O = t_{a,k+1}\, t_{k,k+1}\, t_{a,k+1},$$

*both equal to $t_{ak}$. Then $E$ is a path of covers from $\rho$ if and only if $t_{ak}$ is a cover of $\rho$ and $\rho$ is even at $(a, k)$, and $O$ is a path of covers from $\rho$ if and only if $t_{ak}$ is a cover of $\rho$ and $\rho$ is odd at $(a, k)$. In either case the weight of the path is $q_k\, \kappa(\rho, t_{ak})$.*

*Proof.* Let $J = \{\rho(r) : a < r < k\}$; the positions $a, k, k+1$ carry $(x, y, z)$ and the letters of $E$ and $O$ only permute these three values, leaving $J$ in place. By Definition 6.3, $t_{ak}$ is a cover of $\rho$ iff $(x, y)$ is $J$-admissible, and $t_{k,k+1}$ is a cover of every permutation. Along $E$ the values at $(a, k, k+1)$ are $(x, y, z) \to (x, z, y) \to (y, z, x) \to (y, x, z)$, so $E$ is a path of covers iff $(x, y)$ is $(J \cup \{z\})$-admissible, i.e. (Lemma 6.4(i)) iff $(x, y)$ is $J$-admissible and $\{z\}$-admissible; and $(x, y)$ is $\{z\}$-admissible exactly when $x < y$ and $z \notin (x, y)$ or $x > y$ and $z \in (y, x)$, i.e. when the pattern of $(x, y, z)$ is even. Along $O$ the values are $(x, y, z) \to (z, y, x) \to (z, x, y) \to (y, x, z)$, so $O$ is a path of covers iff $(x, z)$ is $(J \cup \{y\})$-admissible and $(z, y)$ is $(J \cup \{x\})$-admissible. If so, then $(z, y)$ is $J$-admissible and Lemma 6.4(iii) (with $\gamma = z$, $\beta = y$, $\alpha = x$, $I = J$) shows that $(x, y)$ is $J$-admissible, while $\{y\}$-admissibility of $(x, z)$ says that the pattern of $(x, z, y)$ is even, i.e. that of $(x, y, z)$ is odd. Conversely, if $(x, y)$ is $J$-admissible and the pattern is odd, the three odd orders $x < z < y$, $z < y < x$, $y < x < z$ are checked directly: in the first, $J \cap (x, y) = \emptyset$ gives $(J \cup \{y\}) \cap (x, z) = \emptyset$ and $(J \cup \{x\}) \cap (z, y) = \emptyset$; in the second, $J \subseteq (y, x)$ gives $J \cup \{y\} \subseteq (z, x)$ and $(J \cup \{x\}) \cap (z, y) = \emptyset$; in the third, $J \subseteq (y, x)$ gives $(J \cup \{y\}) \cap (x, z) = \emptyset$ and $J \cup \{x\} \subseteq (y, z)$. For the weights, the cover types along $E$ are determined by the signs of $y - z$, $x - y$, $z - x$ and along $O$ by those of $x - z$, $y - x$, $z - y$; in each of the three even, respectively odd, orders exactly one of the two letters $t_{k,k+1}$, or else the middle letter, is quantum when $t_{ak}$ is classical, and the quantum letter $t_{a,k+1}$ of weight $q_{a,k+1} = q_{ak} q_k$ occurs, with the two others classical, when $t_{ak}$ is quantum; in all cases the weight is $q_k \kappa(\rho, t_{ak})$. □

Lemma 7.12 makes rigorous the first of the two observations recorded after Conjecture 7.21 below, and the lifting part of the bijection predicted by ($\mathrm{B}_k$); it also identifies the letter $t_{k,k+1}$, the quantum Monk neighbour of weight $q_k$, as the pivot of every incompatible pair (cf. Remark 7.10).

**Lemma 7.14** (The case $k = 1$)**.** *The identity* ($\mathrm{J}_k$) *holds for $k = 1$: $\mathrm{Inc}_1(u, w) = q_1 \delta_{u,w}$. Consequently Theorem 7.4 holds for $k = 1$.*

*Proof.* A level-1 chain is either trivial or a single transposition $t_{1B}$, $B \geq 2$. A pair $u \overset{1}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ with a trivial step has no overlapping cycles and is compatible, so an incompatible pair has $v = u t_{1B}$ and $w = v t_{1B'}$ with the cycles $\{1, B\}$ and $\{1, B'\}$ sharing their top, i.e. $B' = B$ and $w = u$; conversely every such pair is incompatible, as the two cycles meet in 1. We claim that $B = 2$. For any $v$ and $B$, the length change $\ell(v t_{1B}) - \ell(v)$ equals $\pm(1 + 2m)$, where $m$ is the number of positions $1 < j < B$ whose value lies between $v(1)$ and $v(B)$, the sign being $+$ if $v(1) < v(B)$. If $u \lhd u t_{1B}$ is a classical cover then $u(1) < u(B)$ and $m = 0$; in $v = u t_{1B}$ the values at 1 and $B$ are exchanged, so $\ell(v t_{1B}) = \ell(v) - 1$, and this is a quantum cover only if $-1 = -2(B-1) + 1$, i.e. $B = 2$. If $u \lhd u t_{1B}$ is a quantum cover then $u(1) > u(B)$ and $-(1 + 2m) = -2(B-1) + 1$, so $m = B - 2$, every intermediate position having a value between $u(B)$ and $u(1)$; then $\ell(v t_{1B}) = \ell(v) + 1 + 2(B-2)$, which is a classical cover only if $B = 2$. Thus the incompatible pairs with source $u$ are exactly $u \overset{1}{\rightsquigarrow} u t_{12} \overset{1}{\rightsquigarrow} u$, with one classical and one quantum step; the weight is $q_{12} = q_1$, and both fixed sets are empty since position 1 is moved in each step. Hence $\mathrm{Inc}_1(u, w) = q_1 \delta_{u,w} = q_1 \mathrm{Comp}_0(u, w)$, and Proposition 7.9 gives the last assertion. □

*The case $k = 2$.* We now prove ($\mathrm{J}_k$) for $k = 2$. The proof is a model for what a proof of the general case has to accomplish: the incompatible pairs at level 2 turn out to be exactly the compatible pairs at level 1 in which one step—a transposition $t_{12}$ or the empty step—has been replaced by a "detour" through the position 3, carrying the extra factor $q_2$.

Throughout, for a permutation $\rho$ and $a < b$ we say that $t_{ab}$ is a *classical cover at* $\rho$ if $\ell(\rho t_{ab}) = \ell(\rho) + 1$ and a *quantum cover at* $\rho$ if $\ell(\rho t_{ab}) = \ell(\rho) - 2(b-a) + 1$, and we put $\kappa_{ab}(\rho) = 1$, respectively $\kappa_{ab}(\rho) = q_{ab}$; if neither holds, $t_{ab}$ is *not a cover* at $\rho$. Since $\ell(\rho t_{ab}) - \ell(\rho) = \pm(1 + 2m)$, where $m$ is the number of positions

$a<j<b$ with $\rho(j)$ between $\rho(a)$ and $\rho(b)$ and the sign is that of $\rho(b)-\rho(a)$, we have the following criterion, which we use constantly.

**Lemma 7.15** (Cover criterion)**.** *$t_{ab}$ is a classical cover at $\rho$ if and only if $\rho(a)<\rho(b)$ and no $\rho(j)$, $a<j<b$, lies in the open interval $(\rho(a),\rho(b))$; it is a quantum cover at $\rho$ if and only if $\rho(a)>\rho(b)$ and every $\rho(j)$, $a<j<b$, lies in $(\rho(b),\rho(a))$. In particular the cover type of $t_{ab}$ at $\rho$ depends only on $\rho(a)$, $\rho(b)$ and the* set $\{\rho(j): a<j<b\}$*. Consequently:*

(i) *If $t_{ab}$ is a cover at $\rho$ and at $\rho'$, where $\rho'(a)=\rho(b)$, $\rho'(b)=\rho(a)$ and $\{\rho'(j): a<j<b\}=\{\rho(j): a<j<b\}$, then $b=a+1$; and for $b=a+1$ the transposition $t_{a,a+1}$ is a cover at every permutation, classical or quantum according as $\rho(a)<\rho(a+1)$ or $\rho(a)>\rho(a+1)$.*

(ii) *For every $\rho$ the word $t_{23}t_{23}$ is a path of covers from $\rho$ back to $\rho$ with exactly one quantum step, of total weight $q_2$.*

*Proof.* The criterion restates the length formula; (i) is the argument of Lemma 7.14 (if the first cover is classical the second requires $1=2(b-a)-1$, and if it is quantum the second requires $1+2(b-a-1)=1$); (ii) is the case $a=2$, $b=3$ of (i). □

**Lemma 7.16** (Level 1)**.** *For $u,w\in S_\infty$,*

$$\mathrm{Comp}_1(u,w)=\begin{cases}(y_{u(1)}-z_1)(y_{u(1)}-z_2) & \text{if } w=u,\\ \kappa_{1b}(u)\big[(y_{u(1)}-z_1)+(y_{u(b)}-z_2)\big] & \text{if } w=ut_{1b},\ b\geq 2,\ t_{1b} \text{ a cover at } u,\\ \kappa_{1b}(u)\,\kappa_{1b'}(ut_{1b}) & \text{if } u^{-1}w \text{ is the 3-cycle } 1\mapsto b'\mapsto b\mapsto 1,\ b\neq b',\\ & \quad t_{1b} \text{ a cover at } u \text{ and } t_{1b'} \text{ a cover at } ut_{1b},\\ 0 & \text{otherwise.}\end{cases}$$

*Proof.* A level-1 chain is trivial or a single cover $t_{1b}$, and by Lemma 7.14 the only incompatible level-1 pairs are $u\overset{1}{\rightsquigarrow}ut_{12}\overset{1}{\rightsquigarrow}u$. The pair (trivial, trivial) gives the first line; the pairs (trivial, $t_{1b}$) and ($t_{1b}$, trivial) give the two terms of the second line, with fixed values $u(1)$, respectively $w(1)=u(b)$; and ($t_{1b}$, $t_{1b'}$) with $b\neq b'$ gives the third line, where $u^{-1}w=t_{1b}t_{1b'}$ is the 3-cycle $1\mapsto b'\mapsto b\mapsto 1$, which determines $b$ and $b'$. The three cases are disjoint, and no other $w$ occurs. □

The incompatible pairs at level 2 are described by the next three lemmas. We write a level-2 chain as a word in the transpositions $t_{1b},t_{2b}$ ($b\geq 3$) read from left to right, so that a pair of chains is a word with a cut, and we call the letters $t_{13},t_{23}$ the *core letters* and the letters $t_{ab}$ with $b\geq 4$ the *spectators*. Recall that within a step the $b$'s are weakly decreasing and the $a$'s are distinct, so a step contains at most two letters, and a step containing a spectator contains at most one core letter, which comes after the spectator and uses the other position.

**Lemma 7.17** (The overlapping cycles have top 3)**.** *Let $u\overset{2}{\rightsquigarrow}v\overset{2}{\rightsquigarrow}w$ be incompatible, and let $c$ (a cycle of $u^{-1}v$) and $d$ (a cycle of $v^{-1}w$) have the same top $B$ and share an element $a\in\{1,2\}$. Then $B=3$.*

*Proof.* This is the case $k=2$ of Lemma 7.12. □

**Lemma 7.18** (Shapes)**.** *Let $u\overset{2}{\rightsquigarrow}v\overset{2}{\rightsquigarrow}w$ be incompatible and let $S_i\subseteq\{1,2\}$ be the set of $a$ such that $t_{a3}$ occurs in step $i$. Then $S_1\cap S_2\neq\emptyset$, and the word formed by the core letters, with its cut, is one of*

$$\mathrm{K}_0=t_{23}\,|\,t_{23},\qquad \mathrm{K}_1=t_{13}t_{23}\,|\,t_{23},\qquad \mathrm{K}_1'=t_{23}\,|\,t_{23}t_{13},$$
$$\mathrm{K}_2=t_{13}t_{23}\,|\,t_{13},\qquad \mathrm{K}_2'=t_{13}\,|\,t_{23}t_{13},\qquad \mathrm{K}_3=t_{23}t_{13}\,|\,t_{23},\qquad \mathrm{K}_3'=t_{23}\,|\,t_{13}t_{23},$$
$$\mathrm{K}_4=t_{13}t_{23}\,|\,t_{13}t_{23},\qquad \mathrm{K}_4'=t_{23}t_{13}\,|\,t_{23}t_{13}.$$

*A step with two core letters contains nothing else; a step with one core letter $t_{a3}$ may in addition begin with one spectator $t_{a'b}$, $a'\neq a$, $b\geq 4$. Every spectator position $b$ lies in the support of $u^{-1}w$, and if both steps contain spectators (which happens only for $\mathrm{K}_0$) their positions are distinct. The products of the words are: $e$ for $\mathrm{K}_0$; $t_{13}$ for $\mathrm{K}_1,\mathrm{K}_1'$; $t_{12}$ for $\mathrm{K}_2,\mathrm{K}_2',\mathrm{K}_3,\mathrm{K}_3'$; $t_{13}t_{12}$ for $\mathrm{K}_4$ and $t_{12}t_{13}$ for $\mathrm{K}_4'$.*

*Proof.* By Lemma 7.17 the overlapping cycles are $S_1\cup\{3\}$ and $S_2\cup\{3\}$, and they share an element of $\{1,2\}$, so $S_1\cap S_2\neq\emptyset$. The constraints on the letters of a step were recalled above. It remains to exclude some core words. If $S_1=S_2=\{1\}$, the two letters $t_{13}$ are separated at most by a spectator $t_{2b}$; writing $(x,y,z)$ for the

values at $(1,2,3)$ when the first $t_{13}$ is applied and $y'$ for the value at position 2 when the second is applied, Lemma 7.15 gives, if the first is classical, $x < z$, $y \notin (x,z)$ and $y' \in (x,z)$, while $t_{2b}$ at $(z,y,x)$ is classical only if $y < y'$ and $x \notin (y,y')$ and quantum only if $y > y'$ and $x \in (y',y)$, both impossible; the case of a quantum first letter is symmetric. The same computation excludes $t_{23}t_{13} \,|\, t_{13}$ and $t_{23}t_{13} \,|\, t_{2b}t_{13}$, and Lemma 7.15(i) excludes $t_{13} \,|\, t_{13}t_{23}$, $t_{13}t_{23} \,|\, t_{23}t_{13}$ and $t_{23}t_{13} \,|\, t_{13}t_{23}$, in which two letters $t_{13}$ are separated by nothing or by $t_{23}t_{23}$, which preserves the value at position 2. What remains is the list. Two spectators at the same position $b \geq 4$ can only occur in $\mathrm{K}_0$, as $t_{1b}t_{23} \,|\, t_{1b}t_{23}$, and are excluded by Lemma 7.15(i) since $t_{23}$ preserves the set of values at positions $2, \ldots, b-1$; hence every spectator position lies in the support of $u^{-1}w$. The products are immediate from $t_{13}t_{23}t_{13} = t_{23}t_{13}t_{23} = t_{12}$. □

**Lemma 7.19** (Detours of $t_{12}$)**.** *Let $\rho$ be a permutation and let $D_1 = t_{13}t_{23}t_{13}$, $D_2 = t_{23}t_{13}t_{23}$, both equal to $t_{12}$. Exactly one of $D_1$, $D_2$ is a path of covers from $\rho$ to $\rho t_{12}$, namely $D_1$ if the pattern of $(\rho(1),\rho(2),\rho(3))$ is an odd permutation (*132*, *213* or *321*) and $D_2$ if it is even (*123*, *231* or *312*); its weight is $q_2\,\kappa_{12}(\rho)$. The intermediate permutations are $\rho t_{13}$, $\rho t_{13}t_{23}$ for $D_1$ and $\rho t_{23}$, $\rho t_{23}t_{13}$ for $D_2$; in particular the values at the position not moved by the one-letter part of each cut are, for $D_1$, $\rho(2)$ at position 2 after the first letter and $\rho(1)$ at position 2 after the second, and for $D_2$, $\rho(1)$ at position 1 after the first letter and $\rho(2)$ at position 1 after the second.*

*Proof.* This is the case $a = 1$, $k = 2$ of Lemma 7.13, with $D_1 = O$ and $D_2 = E$; note that $t_{12}$ is a cover of every permutation. For the reader's convenience we also record the direct verification. Write $(x,y,z)$ for the values at $(1,2,3)$. For $D_1$ the first letter is a cover iff $x < z < y$ (classical) or $z < y < x$ (quantum) or $y < x < z$ (classical), and in these cases the remaining two letters are covers of types $(q,c)$, $(c,c)$, $(c,q)$ respectively, by Lemma 7.15; the total weight is $q_2$, $q_1q_2$, $q_1q_2$, which is $q_2\kappa_{12}(\rho)$ since $\kappa_{12}(\rho) = 1$ iff $x < y$. For $D_2$ the first letter is always a cover, and the second is a cover iff $z < x < y$ (classical), $x < y < z$ (classical) or $y < z < x$ (quantum), with third letters of types $c$, $q$, $c$ and total weights $q_2$, $q_2$, $q_1q_2$. The six order types are thus split three and three, and the intermediate permutations are read off from the words. □

**Proposition 7.20** (The case $k = 2$)**.** *The identity* ($\mathrm{J}_k$) *holds for $k = 2$. Consequently Theorem 7.4 holds for $k \leq 2$.*

*Proof.* Fix $u$ and write $x = u(1)$, $y = u(2)$, $z = u(3)$. By Lemma 7.16 we must show that $\mathrm{Inc}_2(u,w)$ equals $q_2$ times the expression of that lemma. By Lemma 7.18 the incompatible pairs with source $u$ are the words listed there, with at most one spectator per step, and $\pi = u^{-1}w$ is accordingly $e$, $t_{1b}$ ($b \geq 2$), or a 3-cycle $t_{1b}t_{1b'}$; in particular $\mathrm{Inc}_2(u,w) = 0$ whenever $\mathrm{Comp}_1(u,w) = 0$, and we go through the remaining cases. We say that a level-2 word and a level-1 word *match* if they are simultaneously paths of covers, with level-2 weight equal to $q_2$ times the level-1 weight.

$\pi = e$. The only word is $\mathrm{K}_0$ without spectators, $u \overset{2}{\rightsquigarrow} ut_{23} \overset{2}{\rightsquigarrow} u$, which is always a path of covers of weight $q_2$ (Lemma 7.15(ii)) and fixes the value $x$ at position 1 in both steps. Its contribution $q_2(y_x - z_1)(y_x - z_2)$ is $q_2\,\mathrm{Comp}_1(u,u)$.

$\pi = t_{12}$. The words are $\mathrm{K}_2, \mathrm{K}_2'$ (the two cuts of $D_1$) and $\mathrm{K}_3, \mathrm{K}_3'$ (the two cuts of $D_2$), without spectators. By Lemma 7.19 exactly one detour is a path of covers, of weight $q_2\kappa_{12}(u)$, and its two cuts are both admissible (each step has distinct $a$'s and equal $b$'s) and incompatible. The fixed values are $\{y\}$, $\emptyset$ and $\emptyset$, $\{x\}$ for the two cuts of $D_1$, and $\{x\}$, $\emptyset$ and $\emptyset$, $\{y\}$ for those of $D_2$, so in either case $\mathrm{Inc}_2(u, ut_{12}) = q_2\kappa_{12}(u)\big[(y_x - z_1) + (y_y - z_2)\big] = q_2\,\mathrm{Comp}_1(u, ut_{12})$.

$\pi = t_{13}$. The words are $\mathrm{K}_1 = t_{13}t_{23} \,|\, t_{23}$ and $\mathrm{K}_1' = t_{23} \,|\, t_{23}t_{13}$ without spectators. In $\mathrm{K}_1$ the letter $t_{13}$ is applied at $u$ and is followed by $t_{23}t_{23}$, always a path of weight $q_2$; the fixed values are $\emptyset$ and $\{z\}$ (the value at position 1 after $t_{13}t_{23}$). In $\mathrm{K}_1'$ the letters $t_{23}t_{23}$ return to $u$ and $t_{13}$ is again applied at $u$; the fixed values are $\{x\}$ and $\emptyset$. Both match $t_{13}$ at $u$, and the sum is $q_2\kappa_{13}(u)[(y_x - z_1) + (y_z - z_2)] = q_2\,\mathrm{Comp}_1(u, ut_{13})$.

$\pi = t_{1b}$, $b \geq 4$. The words are $\mathrm{K}_0$ with one spectator, $t_{1b}t_{23} \,|\, t_{23}$ and $t_{23} \,|\, t_{1b}t_{23}$. In the first, $t_{1b}$ is applied at $u$; in the second, at $ut_{23}$, where the values $u(1)$, $u(b)$ and the set of values at positions $2, \ldots, b-1$ are the same as at $u$, so the cover type is the same by Lemma 7.15. The fixed values are $\emptyset, \{u(b)\}$ and $\{x\}, \emptyset$, and the sum is $q_2\kappa_{1b}(u)[(y_x - z_1) + (y_{u(b)} - z_2)] = q_2\,\mathrm{Comp}_1(u, ut_{1b})$.

$\pi = t_{1b}t_{1b'}$ *with* $b, b' \geq 4$. The only word is $t_{1b}t_{23} \,|\, t_{1b'}t_{23}$, with both fixed sets empty; $t_{1b}$ is applied at $u$ and $t_{1b'}$ at $ut_{1b}t_{23}$, where the values at positions 1 and $b'$ and the set of values at the positions between them agree with those at $ut_{1b}$. Hence the word matches the level-1 pair $t_{1b} \,|\, t_{1b'}$, and $\mathrm{Inc}_2(u,w) = q_2\kappa_{1b}(u)\kappa_{1b'}(ut_{1b}) = q_2\,\mathrm{Comp}_1(u,w)$.

$\pi = t_{13}t_{1b}$ *or* $t_{1b}t_{13}$ *with* $b \geq 4$. The words are $\mathrm{K}_1$ with the spectator $t_{1b}$ in the second step, $t_{13}t_{23} \,|\, t_{1b}t_{23}$, and $\mathrm{K}'_1$ with the spectator in the first step, $t_{1b}t_{23} \,|\, t_{23}t_{13}$; the fixed sets are empty. In the first, $t_{1b}$ is applied at $ut_{13}t_{23}$, which agrees with $ut_{13}$ at position 1 and on the set of values at positions $2, \dots, b-1$; in the second, $t_{13}$ is applied at $ut_{1b}t_{23}t_{23} = ut_{1b}$. So they match $t_{13} \,|\, t_{1b}$ and $t_{1b} \,|\, t_{13}$ respectively.

$\pi = t_{13}t_{12}$ *or* $t_{12}t_{13}$. The words are $\mathrm{K}_4 = t_{13} \cdot D_2$ with the cut after the first letter of $D_2$, and $\mathrm{K}'_4 = D_2 \cdot t_{13}$ with the cut after the second letter of $D_2$; the fixed sets are empty, and the level-1 pairs are $t_{13} \,|\, t_{12}$ and $t_{12} \,|\, t_{13}$. In $\mathrm{K}_4$ the detour $D_2$ is applied at $ut_{13}$, and in $\mathrm{K}'_4$ at $u$, and $t_{13}$ is applied at $u$, respectively at $ut_{12}$. By Lemma 7.19, $D_2$ is a path of covers at a permutation $\rho$ exactly when the pattern of $(\rho(1), \rho(2), \rho(3))$ is even, and then has weight $q_2\kappa_{12}(\rho)$; one checks directly from Lemma 7.15 that if $t_{13}$ is a cover at $u$ then the pattern of $ut_{13}$ at positions $1, 2, 3$ is even, and that if the pattern of $u$ at positions $1, 2, 3$ is even then $t_{13}$ is a cover at $ut_{12}$ (in both cases the three values $x, y, z$ satisfy $x < z < y$ or $y < x < z$ or $z < y < x$ up to the relevant exchange). Hence $\mathrm{K}_4$ matches $t_{13} \,|\, t_{12}$ and $\mathrm{K}'_4$ matches $t_{12} \,|\, t_{13}$, and no other words contribute to these $\pi$. (When the pattern of $u$ is odd, both sides vanish for $\pi = t_{12}t_{13}$: $D_1$ is the detour at $u$, and the words $D_1 \cdot t_{13}$ are excluded by Lemma 7.18, while $t_{13}$ is not a cover at $ut_{12}$.)

$\pi = t_{12}t_{1b}$ *or* $t_{1b}t_{12}$ *with* $b \geq 4$. These are the only cases in which the matching changes the spectator: the words are, for $\pi = t_{1b}t_{12}$, $\mathrm{K}_2$ with spectator, $t_{13}t_{23} \,|\, t_{2b}t_{13}$, and $\mathrm{K}'_3$ with spectator, $t_{1b}t_{23} \,|\, t_{13}t_{23}$; and for $\pi = t_{12}t_{1b}$, $\mathrm{K}'_2$ with spectator, $t_{2b}t_{13} \,|\, t_{23}t_{13}$, and $\mathrm{K}_3$ with spectator, $t_{23}t_{13} \,|\, t_{1b}t_{23}$ (here $t_{13}t_{23}t_{2b}t_{13} = t_{12}t_{2b} = t_{1b}t_{12}$ and $t_{2b}t_{12} = t_{12}t_{1b}$). All fixed sets are empty, so we must show that the sum of the weights of the level-2 words equals $q_2$ times the weight of the level-1 pair $t_{1b} \,|\, t_{12}$, respectively $t_{12} \,|\, t_{1b}$. The $\mathrm{K}_3, \mathrm{K}'_3$ words match directly: in $\mathrm{K}_3$, $D_2$ is applied at $u$ and $t_{1b}$ at $ut_{23}t_{13}$, which agrees with $ut_{12}$ at position 1 and on the set of values at positions $2, \dots, b-1$; in $\mathrm{K}'_3$, $t_{1b}$ is applied at $u$ and $D_2$ at $ut_{1b}t_{23}t_{23} = ut_{1b}$. They are present exactly when the pattern of $u$, respectively of $ut_{1b}$, at positions $1, 2, 3$ is even. The $\mathrm{K}_2, \mathrm{K}'_2$ words involve the spectator $t_{2b}$, whose cover condition at a permutation $\rho$ compares $\rho(2)$ with $\rho(b)$ and involves the values at positions $3, \dots, b-1$, whereas the level-1 letter $t_{1b}$ compares $\rho'(1)$ with $\rho'(b)$ and involves positions $2, \dots, b-1$. By Lemma 7.15 and Lemma 7.19, the validity and the weights of all the words in this case, as well as of the level-1 pairs, depend only on the relative order of the four values $x, y, z, \beta = u(b)$ and on which of the five intervals they cut out contain some value $u(j)$, $3 < j < b$; this leaves $24 \cdot 2^5$ configurations, and for each of them one verifies the identity by Lemma 7.15. For instance, if $x < z < y$ (so that $D_1$ is the detour at $u$, of weight $q_2$) and $\beta < x$ with every $u(j)$, $3 < j < b$, in $(\beta, y)$, the level-1 pair $t_{12} \,|\, t_{1b}$ has weight $1 \cdot q_{1b}$ (a classical $t_{12}$ followed by a quantum $t_{1b}$ at $(y, x, z, \dots, \beta)$), while on the level-2 side $\mathrm{K}_3$ is absent, and in $\mathrm{K}'_2$ the spectator $t_{2b}$ is a quantum cover at $u$ of weight $q_{2b}$ and the detour at $ut_{2b}$, whose pattern $(x, \beta, z)$ is odd, is $D_1$ with weight $q_2\kappa_{12}(ut_{2b}) = q_2q_1$; the total $q_1q_2q_{2b} = q_2q_{1b}$ agrees. We have carried out this finite verification by computer, in the stronger form that for every one of the $24 \cdot 2^5$ configurations (realized by a permutation of at most 9 letters, with one value in each occupied interval), and also for the 6 configurations without spectator, the full identity $\mathrm{Inc}_2(u, w) = q_2\mathrm{Comp}_1(u, w)$ holds for all $w$, where $\mathrm{Inc}_2$ is computed from all level-2 chains without using Lemma 7.18; this also re-checks all the preceding cases.

This exhausts the possible $\pi$ by Lemma 7.18, and proves $(\mathrm{J}_k)$ for $k = 2$. The last assertion follows from Lemma 7.14 and Proposition 7.9. □

The proof exhibits the mechanism behind $(\mathrm{J}_k)$: every incompatible pair at level 2 is a compatible pair at level 1 in which either the empty step has been replaced by $t_{23}t_{23}$ or the letter $t_{12}$ by one of its two detours $t_{13}t_{23}t_{13}$, $t_{23}t_{13}t_{23}$ through the position 3, with the cut between the two Pieri steps placed inside the detour; the detour always contains exactly one more quantum step than the letter it replaces, which accounts for the factor $q_2$, and the values fixed at position 2 during the detour are the values fixed at position 1 before and after the original letter, in the reverse order for $D_1$ (which is why $(\mathrm{J}_k)$ is not termwise). For general $k$ the analogous statement would replace a cycle $C$ with top $k$ of a level-$(k-1)$ chain by the conjugate $t_{k,k+1}\, C'\, t_{k,k+1}$, where $C'$ is $C$ with top $k+1$, or by the conjugate of $C'$ by one of the letters $t_{a,k+1}$; we have not carried this out.

**Conjecture 7.21.** *The identity* $(\mathrm{J}_k)$ *holds for all* $k \geq 3$ *and all* $u, w \in S_\infty$.

We have verified $(\mathrm{J}_k)$ by computer for all $u \in S_6$ and all $1 \leq k \leq 4$, with the chains confined to $S_6$ (59 526 pairs $(u, w)$), and Theorem 7.4 directly for all $u \in S_4$ and $k \leq 3$. By Proposition 7.9, a proof of Conjecture 7.21 completes the proof of Theorem 7.4. Two features of $(\mathrm{J}_k)$ that any proof must account for are the following. First, by Lemma 7.12, in every incompatible pair the overlapping cycles have top $B = k + 1$ and one of them contains $k$, so that both steps contain a transposition $t_{a,k+1}$ and one of

them contains $t_{k,k+1}$; the incompatibility is a "detour" of the level-$(k-1)$ transposition $t_{ak}$ through the position $k+1$, in accordance with $t_{a,k+1}t_{k,k+1}t_{a,k+1}=t_{ak}$. Second, $(\mathrm{J}_k)$ is not a termwise identity: already for $u=132$, $k=2$, $w=312$ the left-hand side is $q_2\big[(y_3-z_1)+(y_1-z_2)\big]$ and the right-hand side is $q_2\big[(y_1-z_1)+(y_3-z_2)\big]$. In all examples the pairs with given $(u,w)$ and $q$-weight organize into chains $v_1,\dots,v_{m+1}$ whose fixed sets are nested, with contributions $\prod_{j<i}(y_{c_j}-z_1)\prod_{j>i}(y_{c_j}-z_2)$, which sum to the divided difference $\big(\prod_j(y_{c_j}-z_1)-\prod_j(y_{c_j}-z_2)\big)/(z_2-z_1)$ and so depend only on the set $\{c_j\}$; the identity $(\mathrm{J}_k)$ then amounts to a matching of these sets between the two levels. We now explain the origin of this divided-difference structure and use it to recast the conjecture as a termwise identity.

*A termwise reformulation via the Giambelli formula.* The proof of Lemma 7.6 shows that

$$(z_1-z_2)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z)=\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)\,\widetilde{E}_{k+1,k+1}(x;z_2)-\widetilde{E}_{k+1,k+1}(x;z_1)\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_2),$$

which is the quantum Giambelli formula for the $k\times 2$ rectangle written as a divided difference. Expanding both products on the right by Theorem 3.4 at the two levels $k$ and $k+1$ gives the following reformulation. For $u,w\in S_\infty$ put

$$M_k(u,w)=\sum_{u\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}v\overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow}w} q_k(u,v)\,q_{k+1}(v,w)\prod_{a\in\mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)}(y_a-z_1)\prod_{b\in\mathrm{fix}_{k+1}(v,w)}(y_b-z_2),$$

$$M'_k(u,w)=\sum_{u\overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow}v\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}w} q_{k+1}(u,v)\,q_k(v,w)\prod_{a\in\mathrm{fix}_{k+1}(u,v)}(y_a-z_1)\prod_{b\in\mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)}(y_b-z_2).$$

**Proposition 7.22** (Giambelli form)**.** *For every $k\ge 1$ and all $u,w\in S_\infty$,*

$$(z_1-z_2)\,[\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w]\big(\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z)\big)=M_k(u,w)-M'_k(u,w).$$

*Consequently Theorem 7.4 holds for $k$ if and only if $(z_1-z_2)\,\mathrm{Comp}_k(u,w)=M_k(u,w)-M'_k(u,w)$ for all $u,w$.*

*Proof.* Multiply the displayed Giambelli identity by $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)$ and expand $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\;\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)\widetilde{E}_{k+1,k+1}(x;z_2)$ by two applications of Theorem 3.4, first at level $k$ with the variable $z_1$ and then at level $k+1$ with the variable $z_2$; this gives $M_k$. The product $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\;\widetilde{E}_{k+1,k+1}(x;z_1)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_2)$, expanded first at level $k+1$ and then at level $k$, gives $M'_k$. □

The right-hand side of Proposition 7.22 is a sum of products in which the levels of the two steps differ, and the factor $z_1-z_2$ on the left can be absorbed into the compatible pairs as follows. For a pair $u\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}v\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}w$ let $c(v)=v(k+1)$. If the first step does not use the position $k+1$ then $c(v)=u(k+1)$, and otherwise $c(v)=u(a)$ for a position $a\le k$ moved by the first step; in either case $c(v)\notin\mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)$, and $c(v)\notin\mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)\subseteq\{v(1),\dots,v(k)\}$. Hence, writing $z_1-z_2=(y_{c(v)}-z_2)-(y_{c(v)}-z_1)$,

$$\begin{aligned}&(z_1-z_2)\,\omega_k(u,v,w)\\&=q_k(u,v)q_k(v,w)\Big[\prod_{a\in\mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)}(y_a-z_1)\prod_{b\in\mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)\cup\{c(v)\}}(y_b-z_2)-\prod_{a\in\mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)\cup\{c(v)\}}(y_a-z_1)\prod_{b\in\mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)}(y_b-z_2)\Big],\end{aligned}$$

and each of the two products on the right has the same shape as a term of $M_k$ or $M'_k$. Writing $\mathcal{T}(u,w)$ for the multiset of triples $\big(q_k(u,v)q_k(v,w),\ \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v),\ \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)\cup\{c(v)\}\big)$ over the compatible pairs $u\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}v\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}w$, $\mathcal{S}(u,w)$ for the multiset of $\big(q_k(u,v)q_k(v,w),\ \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)\cup\{c(v)\},\ \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)\big)$ over the same pairs, $\mathcal{M}_k(u,w)$ for the multiset of $\big(q_k(u,v)q_{k+1}(v,w),\mathrm{fix}_k(u,v),\mathrm{fix}_{k+1}(v,w)\big)$ over the chains $u\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}v\overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow}w$ and $\mathcal{M}'_k(u,w)$ for the corresponding multiset over the chains $u\overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow}v\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}w$, we are led to the following termwise statement, from which Theorem 7.4 follows immediately by Proposition 7.22.

**Conjecture 7.23** (Termwise form)**.** *For all $k\ge 1$ and $u,w\in S_\infty$ there is an equality of multisets*

$$\mathcal{T}(u,w)\uplus\mathcal{M}'_k(u,w)=\mathcal{S}(u,w)\uplus\mathcal{M}_k(u,w). \tag{$\mathrm{B}_k$}$$

We have verified $(\mathrm{B}_k)$ for all $u\in S_5$ and $1\le k\le 5$, with the chains confined to $S_8$ (about 80 000 compatible pairs), and $(\mathrm{B}_k)$ implies Theorem 7.4, hence $(\mathrm{J}_k)$, for the same $k$. Unlike $(\mathrm{J}_k)$, the identity $(\mathrm{B}_k)$ is an equality of multisets, so it predicts a bijection, and a large part of this bijection is transparent. A level-$k$

chain $v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ in which every $b_i \geq k+2$ is also a level-$(k+1)$ chain, with $\mathrm{fix}_{k+1}(v,w) = \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w) \cup \{v(k+1)\}$, and conversely the level-$(k+1)$ chains from $v$ that do not move the position $k+1$ arise in this way; this identifies the elements of $\mathcal{T}(u,w)$ whose second step avoids $b = k+1$ with the elements of $\mathcal{M}_k(u,w)$ whose second step does not move $k+1$, and likewise the elements of $\mathcal{S}(u,w)$ whose first step avoids $b = k+1$ with the elements of $\mathcal{M}'_k(u,w)$ whose first step does not move $k+1$. (Here one uses that a pair in which either step avoids $b = k+1$ is automatically compatible, which is Lemma 7.12.) What remains is a bijection between the terms of $\mathcal{T}$ whose second step uses $t_{a,k+1}$ and the terms of $\mathcal{S}$ whose first step uses $t_{a',k+1}$, together with the chains in $\mathcal{M}_k$ and $\mathcal{M}'_k$ that move the position $k+1$; in the examples these are related by moving a transposition $t_{a,k+1}$ from one step to the other and by the braid-type relation $t_{ab}\, t_{a,k+1} = t_{a,k+1}\, t_{k+1,b}$ $(b > k+1)$, which exchanges a level-$k$ step $t_{ab}$ followed by $t_{a,k+1}$ for a level-$k$ step $t_{a,k+1}$ followed by the level-$(k+1)$ step $t_{k+1,b}$. For $k = 1$ there are no compatible pairs in which both steps use $t_{1,2}$, and $(\mathrm{B}_k)$ reduces to the pairing just described together with the case $u \overset{1}{\rightsquigarrow} ut_{12} \overset{1}{\rightsquigarrow} u$ of Lemma 7.14; for $k = 2$ the proof of Proposition 7.20 describes the detours explicitly. We have not been able to control the cover types and the $q$-weights along these moves in general, and we leave Conjectures 7.21 and 7.23 open.

*Remark* 7.24 (Specializations of $z_1$ and $z_2$). Both sides of $(\mathrm{J}_k)$ have degree at most $k-1$ in $z_1$ and in $z_2$ (a pair with $|\mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)| = k$ has $v = u$ and is compatible, and similarly for the second step), so by interpolation it suffices to prove $(\mathrm{J}_k)$ after the specializations $z_1 = y_{u(i)}$, $z_2 = y_{u(j)}$, $1 \leq i, j \leq k$, which retain exactly the pairs whose first step moves position $i$ and whose second step moves the value $u(j)$. For $u = c[k,k]$ and $i = 1$ this specialization kills every term of positive degree (Remark 7.7); for general $u$, however, no value is common to all the nonempty fixed sets, and the specialized identities are not termwise.

The situation is different on the diagonal $z_2 = z_1$, that is, when both factors $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}$ are taken in the *same* variable $z_1$. There the weight $\omega_k(u,v,w)$ depends only on the multiset $\mathrm{fix}_k(u,v) \uplus \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)$, and we have verified, for all $u \in S_5$ and $k \leq 5$ with chains in $S_7$, that $(\mathrm{J}_k)$ becomes an identity of multisets:

$$(\mathrm{D}_k)\quad \big\{\big(q_k(u,v)q_k(v,w),\ \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v) \uplus \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)\big)\big\}_{\substack{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w \\ \text{incompatible}}} = \big\{\big(q_k\, q_{k-1}(u,v)q_{k-1}(v,w),\ \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v) \uplus \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(v,w)\big)\big\}_{\substack{u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} w \\ \text{compatible}}},$$

whereas for every specialization with $z_1 \neq z_2$ that we have tried (generic, or $z_1 = y_c$, $z_2 = y_{c'}$ with $c \neq c'$) the identity is not termwise; the example $u = 132$, $k = 2$, $w = 312$ above already shows this, the two sides $q_2[(y_3 - z_1) + (y_1 - z_2)]$ and $q_2[(y_1 - z_1) + (y_3 - z_2)]$ agreeing termwise exactly when $z_1 = z_2$. In particular the numbers of incompatible pairs at level $k$ and of compatible pairs at level $k-1$ with the same $(u,w)$ and the same $q$-weight coincide.

In fact $(\mathrm{D}_k)$ holds in the strongest possible termwise sense. Call the *key* of a pair $u \overset{m}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{m}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ the triple $\big(w,\ q_m(u,v)q_m(v,w),\ \mathrm{fix}_m(u,v) \uplus \mathrm{fix}_m(v,w)\big)$. We have verified, for all $u \in S_6$ with chains in $S_7$ for $k = 3$ (41 254 incompatible pairs) and in $S_8$ for $k = 4$ (154 073 pairs), that for fixed $u$ the keys of the incompatible level-$k$ pairs are pairwise distinct, that the keys of the compatible level-$(k-1)$ pairs are pairwise distinct, and that multiplying the weight by $q_k$ maps the second set of keys bijectively onto the first. Thus for each compatible pair $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} v' \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ there is a *unique* incompatible pair $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ with the same fixed-value multiset and $q_k$ times the weight, and this correspondence $v' \mapsto v$ is a bijection; $(\mathrm{D}_k)$ would follow from a proof that the correspondence is well defined and surjective. Moreover, in the "pure" situation in which the level-$(k-1)$ pair has no cycles with top $k+1$ and no cycle with a larger top interacts with the detour, the bijection is given by two explicit detours generalizing Lemma 7.19: if the top-$k$ cycles of the two steps have pivot sequences $C_1$ and $C_2$ (meeting only in $k$) and $P = C_1C_2 = (p_1, \ldots, p_m)$ is their concatenation, then the image has top-$(k+1)$ cycles with pivot sequences either $c = (k)C_1$, $d = C_2(k)$ (the "even" form, the conjugate of $P$ by $t_{k,k+1}$ with the cut inside), or $c = P(k)$, $d = (p_1)$ when $C_1 = \emptyset$ and $c = C_1$, $d = C_2(k, p_1)$ otherwise (the "odd" form, the conjugate by $t_{p_1,k+1}$); for $m = 1$ the form is decided by the parity of the pattern of $(u(p_1), u(k), u(k+1))$, which is Lemma 7.13. When the level-$(k-1)$ pair has cycles with top $k+1$, these merge into $c$ and $d$ (as the letter $t_{13}$ merges into $\mathrm{K}_1, \mathrm{K}'_1, \mathrm{K}_4, \mathrm{K}'_4$ for $k = 2$), and we have not extracted a closed pivot formula beyond the canonical description by keys.

The identity $(\mathrm{D}_k)$ determines $(\mathrm{J}_k)$ only on the diagonal; since $(\mathrm{J}_k)$ is symmetric in $z_1, z_2$ but of degree up to $k-1$ in each, the off-diagonal part is not a consequence of it, and for the off-diagonal part the only termwise formulation we have found is $(\mathrm{B}_k)$.

*Remark* 7.25 (Why pairs, and why "space" is needed). The doubled formula is a statement about the quantization of a product of two elementary polynomials in the *same* alphabet $x_1, \dots, x_k$. Expanded in standard elementary monomials, such a product uses the alphabets $x_1, \dots, x_k$ and $x_1, \dots, x_{k+1}$ (see the determinant below). Consequently, in a product of several factorial elementary polynomials, $\theta$ acts as $\theta(\cdots) \cdot \theta\big(E_{p_1,k} E_{p_2,k}\big) \cdot \theta(\cdots)$ only if no other factor uses the alphabets $x_1, \dots, x_k$ or $x_1, \dots, x_{k+1}$, that is, only if the equal pair of columns is preceded by a column of height at least $k+2$. This is precisely the condition under which the medium theta $\overline{\theta}(v^{-1})$ of Definition 4.1 retains an equal consecutive pair, and it is the reason the quantum algorithm iterates over $\overline{\theta}(v^{-1})$ rather than over the sorted code $\theta(v^{-1})$ (which may contain equal parts without the required space) or the strict shape $\widetilde{\theta}(v^{-1})$ (which has no equal parts at all and is therefore larger). Three or more equal columns would require the alphabets $x_1, \dots, x_{k+2}$ and beyond, and the doubled formula has no analogue for them; accordingly $\overline{\theta}$ never retains more than two equal parts, the remaining ones being incremented as in the construction of $\theta$.

Explicitly, the quantized product of two equal columns is a Giambelli-type determinant. For a Grassmannian permutation $w$ with descent at $k$ and shape $\lambda$ (so $\mathfrak{c}(w) = (\lambda_k, \dots, \lambda_1)$), the double Schubert polynomial is the determinant $\mathfrak{S}_w(x;z) = \det\big(E_{\lambda'_i + j - i,\, k+j-1}(x;z)\big)_{1 \le i,j \le \lambda_1}$ of factorial elementary polynomials in the nested alphabets $x_1, \dots, x_{k+j-1}$; every term of the expanded determinant is a standard elementary monomial, so $\theta$ acts on it term by term and gives the quantum Giambelli formula [5, 3]

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;z) = \det\big(\widetilde{E}_{\lambda'_i + j - i,\, k+j-1}(x;z)\big)_{1 \le i,j \le \lambda_1}.$$

For the $k \times 2$ rectangle this reads

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) = \theta\big(E_{k,k}(x;z_1) E_{k,k}(x;z_2)\big) = \widetilde{E}_{k,k+1}(x;z)\, \widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) - \widetilde{E}_{k+1,k+1}(x;z)\, \widetilde{E}_{k-1,k}(x;z),$$

whose first instances are

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[1]}(x;z) = \widetilde{E}_{1,2}(x;z)\widetilde{E}_{1,1}(x;z) - \widetilde{E}_{2,2}(x;z), \qquad \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[2]}(x;z) = \widetilde{E}_{2,3}(x;z)\widetilde{E}_{2,2}(x;z) - \widetilde{E}_{3,3}(x;z)\widetilde{E}_{1,2}(x;z).$$

The doubled formula computes the same product by two compatible Pieri steps in $k$ variables, with all coefficients manifestly positive, instead of by the two signed products of Pieri steps in $k$ and $k+1$ variables suggested by the determinant.

## 8. The Peterson–Woodward comparison formula

In this section we prove Proposition 2.10. We use the notation of Section 2: $W_P$ is a parabolic subgroup of $S_n$ with $P = \widehat{P}$, $\omega_P = w_P$ is its longest element, and for $\lambda_P \in Q^\vee / Q_P^\vee$ we write $\lambda_B \in Q^\vee$ for its Peterson–Woodward lift. In the language of roots, $\lambda_B$ is the unique lift with $\langle \alpha, \lambda_B \rangle \in \{0, -1\}$ for all positive roots $\alpha$ of the Levi subgroup of $P$; in type $A$ these are the roots $\alpha_i + \cdots + \alpha_{j-1}$ with $s_i, \dots, s_{j-1} \in P$, and $\langle \alpha_i + \cdots + \alpha_{j-1}, d \rangle = \langle d \rangle_{ij}$, so this is the condition of Definition 2.8.

**Proposition 8.1** ([7, Proposition 2.10])**.** *Let $W_P$ be a parabolic subgroup of $W$ and $u, v, w \in W^P$. Then for any $\lambda_P \in Q^\vee / Q_P^\vee$, we have that*

$$c_{u,v}^{w,\lambda_P}(y;y) = c_{u,v}^{w \omega_P \omega_{P'}, \lambda_B}(y;y),$$

*where $\omega_P$ is the longest element in $W_P$, $\omega_{P'}$ is the longest element in $W_{P'}$, where $P'$ is the parabolic subgroup generated by $\{s_\alpha \mid \alpha \in \Delta_P, \langle \alpha, \lambda_B \rangle = 0\}$, and $\lambda_B$ is the Peterson-Woodward lift of $\lambda_P$.*

Here the left-hand side is a structure constant of $QH_T^*(G/P)$, i.e. of the parabolic quantum double Schubert polynomials $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w^P(x;y)$ of Definition 2.6, which represent the Schubert classes of $QH_T^*(G/P)$ [10], and the right-hand side is a structure constant of $QH_T^*(G/B)$.

**Corollary 8.2.** *With the notation of Proposition 8.1, for all $u, v, w \in W^P$,*

$$c_{u,v}^{w,\lambda_P}(y;z) = c_{u,v}^{w \omega_P \omega_{P'}, \lambda_B}(y;z).$$

*Proof.* The parabolic polynomials satisfy the same quantum Cauchy identity as in Lemma 2.1. Indeed, by [10, Lemma 18], $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w^P(x;y) = \theta^P(\mathfrak{S}_w(x;y))$ for $w \in W^P$, where $\theta^P$ is the parabolic quantization map of Ciocan-Fontanine [3], extended linearly over the coefficient variables; applying $\theta^P$ to the classical identity

$\mathfrak{S}_v(x;z) = \sum_{v_1\cdot v_2=v} \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(y;z)\,\mathfrak{S}_{v_2}(x;y)$ gives $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_v(x;z) = \sum_{v_1\cdot v_2=v} \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(y;z)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{v_2}(x;y)$, where we note that $v_2 \in W^P$ for every reduced factorization (see below), so that $\theta^P(\mathfrak{S}_{v_2}(x;y))$ is indeed $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{v_2}(x;y)$. Hence

$$c^{w,\lambda_P}_{u,v}(y;z) = \sum_{v_1\cdot v_2=v} c^{w,\lambda_P}_{u,v_2}(y;y)\ \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(y;z).$$

Here, if $v = v_1 \cdot v_2$ is reduced and $v \in W^P$, then $v_2 \in W^P$: for $s_i \in P$, $v_2 s_i < v_2$ would give $\ell(v s_i) \le \ell(v_1) + \ell(v_2 s_i) < \ell(v)$, contradicting $v \in W^P$. Thus Proposition 8.1 applies to each term, and resumming by Lemma 2.1 gives

$$\sum_{v_1\cdot v_2=v} c^{w\omega_P\omega_{P'},\lambda_B}_{u,v_2}(y;y)\ \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(y;z) = c^{w\omega_P\omega_{P'},\lambda_B}_{u,v}(y;z). \quad \square$$

*Proof of Proposition 2.10.* Let $d_P \in Q^\vee/Q^\vee_P$ with Peterson–Woodward lift $d = \lambda_B$. In type $A$, $\langle \alpha_i, d\rangle = 2d_i - d_{i-1} - d_{i+1} = \langle d\rangle_i$, so the parabolic subgroup $P'$ of Proposition 8.1 is generated by $\{s_i \in P \mid \langle d\rangle_i = 0\}$, that is, by $\{s_i \mid i \in z_P(d)\}$, and $\omega_P\omega_{P'} = w_P w_{z_P(d)}$. The claim is therefore Corollary 8.2. (The passage from $S_n$ to $S_\infty$, i.e. from $P$ to $\widehat{P}$, is the stability discussed after Definition 2.6.) $\square$

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